

Let it be!

Marcos Constandse Madrazo

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in writing from the holder of the same.

This novel is a work of fiction, in which real events are mixed with fictional situations and characters.

Any direct or indirect reference to any real-life person is merely incidental.

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Let it be!

Marcos Constandse Madrazo

Dedicated to:

In memory of my parents

To my wife INNA

To my son Marcos

To my children Ninotchka and Carlos, Vanessa and Herzen

To my grandchildren Herzen, Inna and Nathan

To my brothers Oscar and Vilma, Carlos and Noemí

To the Constandse Madrazo family living in Cancun

To the Constandse family

To the Madrazo family

To my sister-in-law Ludmila and her family

To my old friends from Mexico City

To my new friends from Cancun

To all my colleagues and friends from work in Cancun

To my editor Myriam and her family

To my assistant Irma

To all those who made my task easier with their observations

To all proud Quintana Roo residents, and especially to Don Hermilo Chan,
his wife, and their six children.

Summary

The book *Let It Be! (¡Déjalo ser!)* by Marcos Constandse Madrazo is a philosophical novel that blends fiction with deep reflections on technology, memory, identity, and the human journey. Through the life of Rubén Hernández Chi, the story explores how technological progress, love, and spiritual awareness shape the way we understand ourselves and our future .

Set in the year 2026, the narrative begins with Rubén accessing a global information system that stores every personal record since birth. By revisiting his life through videos, testimonies, and data recorded by his parents, he uncovers not only his family history but also the fundamental tension between two worldviews: one that embraces technology as a path to progress, and another that fears it may become a tool of oppression and control. Within this tension lies the broader philosophical question of individual freedom versus collective destiny .

Central to the novel is the relationship between Rubén's parents, Alicia and Rubén Sr. Alicia embodies optimism, faith in the future, and belief in technology's transformative power, while her husband, although deeply spiritual, mistrusts the system and warns against its dangers. Their conversations touch on universal themes: love, religion, human suffering, and hope. Alicia's heartfelt plea, "let it be," becomes the novel's guiding motif—a call to accept life's uncertainties and to trust the evolutionary process of humanity .

The book also connects Rubén's futuristic reality with his ancestral roots. His grandfather, a Maya man of great resilience and wisdom, represents tradition, strength, and cultural memory. This ancestral presence contrasts with the hyper-technological environment in which Rubén lives, creating a bridge between past and future, between individual identity and collective destiny .

Beyond its storyline, *Let It Be!* is a meditation on spirituality and the ethical responsibility of humanity in an increasingly interconnected world. The global information system serves as both a metaphor for collective memory and a warning about the dangers of losing privacy and freedom. The novel suggests that progress, pain, love, and loss are all part of an evolutionary journey that cannot be resisted but must be embraced .

In conclusion, *Let It Be!* is more than a futuristic novel; it is a philosophical essay disguised as fiction. Through Rubén's personal journey, Constandse proposes that the true task of human beings is to live with awareness, faith, and openness—accepting that evolution, both personal and collective, is the inevitable path toward understanding who we truly are .

The master in the art of life

AND He does not distinguish between his work and his play:
work and leisure, mind and body,
education and recreation, love and religion; he
can hardly distinguish which is which.
He simply perceives his vision of perfection in
everything he does; he lets others decide whether
he's playing or working.
In his eyes, he always does both.

Zen Buddhist text

Rubén, Rubén Hernández Chi —that was his full name, a reflection of his distant Mayan and Spanish heritage— found himself alone and anxious. The monitor indicated that it was 11:35 a.m. on October 13, 2026. The good weather forecast pleased him; it was a day of rest, and he would take advantage of it to immerse himself in his database to find the origins of his own being. He was 26 years old, and today he wanted to remember, go back in time, search within himself, and find his roots.

After a light breakfast, he took a blue magnetic card out of his safe, inserted it into the corresponding slot, placed his hand on the screen, and waited for the central computer to approve his biometric indicators, granting him exclusive access to record HECR000101HQRRHB03. The screen emitted the signal. From that moment on, Rubén had within reach the button that would start a series of videos containing some of the most important and momentous moments of his life, of his biography. He was prepared to enter all the access codes, one after the other; he wanted to squeeze every last drop of information the Central Bank kept on him.

In the first file, *Background*, the following legend appeared: “Data accumulated since 1995, the date on which Congress authorized the Law for the Universalization of the Computer System for the Registration of Personal Data and its Corresponding Coding.”

Encryption had always seemed simple to him:

Personal information accessible exclusively to the data subject.

General access data for state and federal authorities
corresponding.

Medical data, accessible to the health sectors.

Specific information: *curriculum vitae*, financial information, etc., accessible
to financial, educational, recreational, etc. entities, with prior authorization
from the interested party.

The information was stored in the same file, so that

To access it there were four different codings: Personal

information: only with magnetic blue card and indicators
biometrics (fingerprints, iris scanner, palm scan).

General information: official card, blue card or biometric indicators.

Medical data: medical card, blue card or biometric indicators.

Specific information: magnetic blue card and biometric indicators.

He started with the background files provided by his mother, anticipating that he would see only what she had chosen to record.

On the screen appeared Alice, his mother. He imagined her alone, sitting in front of the monitor and starting the recording to be sent to the Central Information Bank.

Seeing her young, beautiful, and full of vitality, he felt a mixture of anguish, sadness, and happiness. He listened attentively.

—Dear son: It's

2001. I'm speaking to you from the home your father and I have shared with you since you were born a year ago. Your father and I have been married for three years; I am 30 and your father is 32. The Data Archiving and Information System was established five years ago, so you will see my background just five years ago, from when I graduated in thermobiological chemistry, my first work experiences, my marriage to your father, scenes from our honeymoon, the moment of your birth, and what was your first bedroom.

He couldn't stop a tear from rolling down his cheek. Images of his mother flashed across the screen. He saw her smiling, self-confident, full of youth. First at university, as if pointing out the places she used to frequent; then he witnessed part of her professional exam, her passing, the moment he heard her ask her teachers to leave her a message. He heard them praise her in general terms, but what caught his attention was what the eldest of them seemed to say:

—Alicia, I hope your future experiences don't erase your joy for life, your faith in the sublime, and your admiration and trust in this information and data archiving system, which I can't help but call the spy of our past and the watchdog of our future.

She, relaxed and smiling, answered him:

—Say it, maestro, as you've always said: this infernal card that will make us slaves to our own destiny. Although I believe it holds some of the happiness of the future, only time will tell us who is right; only time.

And he saw her leave the scene after giving a kiss on the cheek to the teacher, whom she seemed to appreciate and respect.

Then he looked at the pictures of his parents' wedding: she looked graceful and lucid. His father, whom he found attractive, looked serious and circumspect. They gave the impression of being a completely dissimilar couple, except for their beauty. She was dark-haired and statuesque; her expression denoted a strong yet sweet character. He was tall, blond,

with a penetrating and sharp gaze, which softened greatly when he looked at the woman who would be his wife for the rest of his life.

The ceremony seemed conventional and formal to her. Her mother was a liberal Catholic—she said she had a deep faith in God and life. Her father didn't practice any religion, but he always respected her beliefs.

The civil ceremony was very simple and austere. It took place in the designated office with only four witnesses: two from her father's side, tall, white, smiling, informal, and pleasant-looking; and two from her mother's side, her father's side, and a friend of his.

He was deeply impressed by the image of his maternal grandfather. Despite having seen the ceremony several times, he hadn't observed him closely. He paused the video and rewound it to a *close-up* that focused with absolute precision on his face: very dark brown, wrinkled, with a strong chin, his straight hair swept back carelessly, his protruding nose, and his high forehead. But what caught his attention most were his eyes: small, slanted, and bright; they didn't look, they observed, giving the impression of penetrating solid things with their sharpness; they moved slowly, taking in everything. His gaze was a contradictory combination of infinite sweetness and ferocity.

His mother had told him many anecdotes about him: about his time living in the jungle region of Puerto Morelos, in Quintana Roo; about his time working as a carpenter and masonry worker in Nuevo Yucatán; about how he taught himself to speak Spanish and master its writing and reading; about how he fell in love with and captivated his wife, from the Nuevo Yucatán community, who was educated and had refined manners; and how he paid for her studies until she graduated from La Salle University in Mexico.

He became an important man in his small world. As a construction foreman, he created jobs, and by mastering Mayan and Spanish, he became a liaison between his people and the local contractors.

Later, a series of sequences of his father at the University of the Caribbean, where he met his mother, appeared on screen. These scenes always involved his mother or had been filmed by her. In the footage, I sensed how she had tried to communicate a message, capturing moments of success and failure alike; sometimes focusing on beautiful landscapes as well as miserable places and people. She expressed her point of view on each of them, as if trying to leave a record of her impressions for someone else.

Suddenly, the camera froze, and on the screen appeared her father and mother, comfortably seated on their sofa. She was already very pregnant. Their conversation went as follows:

—Rubén, I know that you are not in favor of the Information and Data Archiving System. You have always thought that it will bring serious problems to humanity, and above all, you fear that one day it will be used by some dictator or tyrant to abuse people. Your arguments—

ments are solid as is your intellectual formation in which respect for the human being and personal freedom are fundamental.

I, on the other hand, have been passionate about the system from day one. You know I've stored a wealth of information and many videos in it for our children to use someday if they wish. The time has come to decide whether we will enroll our next son or daughter in the system from the beginning of their life, or whether we will let them decide when they come of age.

—Alicia, you and I have had a wonderful life together, governed much more by love and understanding, faith and mutual tolerance, than by communication. Your life with me has filled me with joy and happiness. Your youth, your ingenuity, and your zest for life have transported me from a world of cold technology to a world of human warmth. I never thought that by sharing my life with someone I could achieve such fulfillment. You made me discover that life has many dimensions; with you, I have found spiritual peace, serenity, security, and creativity. In addition to loving you, I am deeply grateful.

"You know that I have studied in several countries and that I have a great passion for reading and studying. My introversion is a product of my own experience. I have seen nations born, full of faith and hope for those who created them, and I have seen how over time they have become deformed, bureaucratized, and eventually incorporated into the established order for the benefit of a few. I have seen ideas that have been deformed until they have become a tangle of conventions and programs, rites and ceremonies, which end up further closing the circle of oppression in which the majority ends up being manipulated by the most powerful.

You and I almost never talk about religion, but I must tell you that I am a religious man, perhaps in an unclear way, for I identify equally with a Christian, a Mohammedan, or a Buddhist, since in their basic principles all religions yearn for love of one's neighbor and personal improvement. But those men who sought these truths would be terrified and distressed by how men have distorted their teachings and committed the most atrocious aberrations: wars, torture, and hatred. Although many others have given meaning to their lives by dedicating them entirely to the dissemination, defense, and institutionalization of these precepts. History shows that the pursuit of power and primitive impulses of aggression have not yet been dominated by the intellect. There are still wars and dictatorships that would make the Greeks themselves shudder, who more than two thousand years ago preached civilization and democracy.

"Alicia, your optimism and your faith in life blind you, they don't allow you to see all the evil that exists in humanity.

—Rubén, as you said, we haven't had all the communication we should have, but just as you have your reasons for being introverted and pessimistic about life, my faith and my joy for life aren't based solely on naiveté.

"One day I realized that my father came from the jungle, from a way of life you might classify as primitive. My childhood was spent in unhealthy places; I survived childbirth, which left my mother dead. And I witnessed the arrival of civilization:

First roads, then schools, electricity. I don't deny that behind them came power and abuse, but also the opportunity for a better life. I am living proof of what I'm telling you; if it weren't for these advances, I'd probably still be in the jungle fighting for survival in the most adverse conditions. And I'm speaking of my own life, a mere 30 years, which projected into history has no meaning, but which for me, for us, and for our children represents a difference of centuries.

And he added calmly:

—For me, Rubén, that is the meaning of technology, that is the origin of my joy. of living and of my faith in the future.

—But you're forgetting one detail, the exception. Your father was a unique man who broke the barrier of the jungle, of language, because his temper was of steel. But let's talk about those who stayed, those who have paid the price of technological oppression and who have seen their traditional way of life, their values and customs shattered; who have been dispossessed of their lands, who see their children leave for unknown and terrifying destinies, which they may never see return, and how they are used for the personal benefit of others, and who in their anguish take refuge in alcohol, which is the only escape they find from an enemy that tears them apart and imprisons them and which they cannot even see or understand. Their fear of the tiger turned into fear of the unknown, the incomprehensible, which destroys them inside and out without even giving them the chance to confront it by the most primitive means of brute force. Alicia, we need to ask them about the benefits of technology; them, the ones who are paying the price, not you, the exception.

—No, Rubén, I'm not the exception; you've already said that; the exception was my father. And my father was one of them. But in the face of contempt, he responded with arrogance; in the face of ignorance, with effort; in the face of misery, with work; he wasn't disconcerted by technology but embraced it; in the face of change, he adapted with anguish, with pain, with suffering, and fear, just as I plan to face the birth of our son, because nothing is born without, in some way, destroying that which gives it life. My father seemingly confronted the world, but in reality, he confronted himself through his fear, his ignorance, and his passion. Blessed are those who confront it, who pay the price, who know no boundaries, who from their torn body and spirit give birth to a better world! They are the exceptions, Rubén, and they are the ones who are creating a better, more just, and more beautiful world.

With anguish and anxiety reflected on his face, but with great serenity he added:

—Rubén, I beg you, I implore you for the humanity in which I believe, for my faith in human beings, allow us to move from primitive life to the cybernetic age in a single generation.

And in a desperate attempt, with tears in his eyes and an uncontrollable cry of anguish, he said:

—Ruben, for our love, let it be!

—Alice, for our love, so be it!

They fell into a hug that united them completely, as if the rest of their lives depended on it.

Rubén cried as he watched the screen, and in that moment, he deeply loved his parents, himself, and everything around him. He felt deep within himself that he was him.

The following scenes in the video took place in the hospital. In the delivery room, he witnessed his own birth, anguished and fascinated. His father operated the camera, and just as he focused on his mother's face—tense and constricted by pain—he framed the doctor's serene face or the scene of his birth. He heard his mother's wails grow louder. The delivery was difficult. The baby was turned upside down, so the doctor performed a skillful cesarean section; first the head appeared, and then the entire baby: an elbow, then an arm, then a shoulder. His mother's scream during the cesarean section and expulsion was intense; it was a mixture of pain and satisfaction. It was a baby. It was him emerging into life.

Then, the image of his father appeared with a tiny bundle in his arms, sitting in front of the camera and looking at the baby's face, to whom he began to speak as follows:

—Rubén, because that's the name we've decided you'll have until you're of age and you either renew it or discard it: Rubén Hernández Chi.

"Four days ago, you came into this world. I filmed that wonderful moment, but I must clarify that it was a painful birth, chosen by your mother and against my wishes. She said she wanted to repeat the painful birth her mother had with her. You'll understand in due time, when you analyze, if you wish, everything we recorded for you.

"From birth until age 18, the law allows parents to register their children in the SIC's Personal Data Registration System. By the time you're aware of this, the concept will be as much a part of your daily life as sleeping or eating; however, I think it's worth explaining what it means.

"In 1996, Congress approved the incorporation of our country into the bmd (World Data Bank) system, which consists of a large database that seeks to integrate universal history and culture. This bank was created at the initiative of one of the most developed and industrialized countries in the world, which allocated an enormous sum of money to

such an effect. It began with a symbolic ceremony in the first minute of the first day of 1995: 00/01/01/1995.

"I watched the ceremony on television, and it was the event watched by the largest number of human beings in the history of humanity. It was attended by almost all the leaders of democratic countries. The ceremony took place in Washington, DC, the capital of the United States, against the backdrop of the Abraham Lincoln Memorial.

"At the ceremony, the President of the United States said only one sentence: 'There is no freedom in ignorance.'"

"In theory, this great collection would be accessible to all humanity, so that every human idea or action would be recorded in the aforementioned center. Thus, all libraries and archives would be reduced to their minimum expression before such fabulous resource.

"Thus, all the countries registered, after paying the corresponding fee. They sent information about their history, about their achievements in the fields of culture, art, and the development of humanity. They included biographical notes on their most illustrious or important citizens.

"At first, the United Nations, as the promoter of the idea, proposed it as a summary of universal culture, but without a political focus, that would be accessible to all humanity.

"After a few years, Russia, which had also participated in its creation, created its own data bank, having demonstrated to the UN that, inevitably, the criteria for culture were different in free-market countries compared to others.

"China did not participate in the original idea because it declared that this seemed to it a way of decadent penetration of both Russian and American capitalist culture.

"In short, three major banks of culture and information were created: that of the democratic capitalist countries, led by the United States, which groups together countries with free market economies; that of the socialist countries, led by Russia; and that of the communist countries, led by China. These are the forces fighting for world hegemony in this century.

"Mexico is registered with the BMD of democratic and free-market countries, but the political swings of the developing world—of which we are a part—allow data from other blocs to penetrate into various areas, which causes us some political problems, both external and internal. However, we have the support of underdeveloped countries, who see Mexico as a neutral leader to lean on in this era of technological and energy colonialism.

"The initial thesis of the bmd has had all kinds of variations, but it is undoubtedly the culmination of one of the most important efforts in the development of humanity.

"Each country that has registered with the BMD has also created its own SIC (Central Information System), which in Mexico is called SICRM (Central Information System of the Mexican Republic). You have been registered in that system.

"I must warn you that this will have a major impact on the rest of your life, because until you reach the age of 18, when you will be making your own decisions, we will record in the Central Bank all the data that we, your teachers, friends, and classmates, deem important for your future life.

"I must add that your training will be different from most, as your educational cycle will be divided into two: one part in school at the initial studies level for nine years for social integration and obtaining basic concepts, and another starting at age 14, where you will not need to go to any school, because through your computer you will receive all the instruction you require, and at the age of 18 you will be able to choose the area and professional specialty that you decide to study to practice in life.

"Your birth, my information, and your mother's information have now been registered. Your registration number is HECR000101HQRRHB03, which refers to Rubén Hernández Chi, born on January 1, 2000. Until you come of age, those initials will be your inevitable companions; they were discharged from the hospital; they will continue to be with you at home and at school. This will be how our government identifies you, and, if you so wish, they will be your record until the day you die. Through them, you can project whatever you want about yourself to your children and descendants.

The government talks about wonderful plans for the future of the System. A Central Bank will be created to unite all banks. In theory, the amount of money in circulation will gradually decrease until it disappears. There will be private and open numbers, and with your magnetized and encoded card, you can collect and pay whatever you want. The Medical Data Bank gathers your birth data, birth characteristics, blood type, family history of illnesses, etc. The Civil Bank compiles official data on each citizen: date of birth, school records, legal irregularities, salaries, etc., and will be used to control taxes and benefits. There is also talk of many other applications that you will experience in due course.

"I must express my deep concern that this could generate mechanisms of control and repression for the benefit of unscrupulous, ambitious individuals who could seize the information despite the pact signed in Sydney, Australia, by all member countries, which stipulates that in the event of a political change or shift, the bank will be under UN control, and that every citizen will have the right to erase any private information about their recording. Your mother tells me I'm a pessimist. I believe I'm a realist. As for you, the decision has been made, and we both hope this will contribute to your benefit and happiness."

Rubén smiled. Who would have thought his father would have the same passion for the system as his mother, to the point that he channeled all his energy into studying it.

He was also somewhat melancholic listening to his father talk about the future plans for the Central Computer System, which had been far surpassed, and in whose development he had been a partner.

His thesis, "*Application of Satellite Tracking Data to Economic Planning in Mexico*," caused a stir among economists and political scientists in the country.

Phrases like "Applied cybernetics is the solution to the social and economic problems of our country" or "I place my faith, my hope, and my future in the hands of technology" sparked a wave of protests and were the subject of televised debates. There were counter-arguments like "Man controlled by the machine," "Human creativity transformed into magnetic circuits," "Humanity controlled by energy," and so on, from politicians, sociologists, anthropologists, and many distinguished individuals.

This deeply moved Rubén, but he found encouragement in a phrase his mother had said to him on his 18th birthday when she handed him his magnetic card: "This card is yours from this moment on, as is your will. In this time of uncertainty and change, I can only give you one piece of advice: act according to what your conscience dictates, with equal criteria for yourself and others, and always try to do so with faith and love."

He did not give in, and the result was his current position as head of the Development Section of the BMD and SIC in Latin America, a position to which he was dedicated with total devotion and passion.

He later observed his parents in conversation when he was two years old.

"Rubén, our son is no longer a kindergartener. At the beginning of September, he'll start his initial studies. As you know, once he's incorporated into the SIC, he'll have to complete one year of pre-school and nine years of social integration and basic concepts. He could spend these first ten years at school, but I think it would be best for him to prepare here at home. We can set up his own schooling with everything he needs, and I'll be by his side, guiding and directing his learning process."

"I want to have more communication with our son; I have nothing against established systems and schools, but I want to be more involved in his intellectual, spiritual, and even physical development. We can set up a gym here, and the ranch lends itself to many outdoor sports activities. I know we spend the weekends together, as well as the moments we share each evening, but I'm not satisfied with that."

He answered him:

"I don't mind the idea of you preparing a splendid dinner for me every night. But there are several things you should consider before making a decision like this. First, you've always said that you like your job, that through it you feel creatively integrated into your environment. On the other hand, leaving your job can make you lose practice in your profession. Finally, and what worries me most, is that you live through

"of your child, which can eventually create a deep void within you. When he decides on his own path—which must happen—you may not find a fulfilling activity in your life and may become an absorbing and selfish mother or face great loneliness."

She added:

"Believe me, Rubén, I've thought deeply about this decision. The remote work process is excellent. My professional development won't stop even if I work from home. The other point is more serious. I've often wondered if I'm actually running away from myself by wanting to contribute to the child's development. My greatest anguish is thinking that I'll end up becoming an all-consuming woman and distorting her aptitudes and abilities. On this point, you know that I'm very clear that every individual must forge their own destiny and that this opportunity is theirs by right from the moment of birth; that everyone will pay the price for their own decisions. As for my probable loneliness, if fate puts it in front of me, I'll know how to face it with fortitude. I've always said that loneliness is a spiritual state, rather than a physical one, and I hope to be capable of facing it when it presents itself."

With a jovial face and that look full of sweetness with which he always observed her, Ruben said to him:

"As always, your arguments convince me, Alicia, and in this case, you're making a decision that fundamentally affects your life. The idea of our son spending more time with you makes me happy, and I think even a little envious."

They both laughed happily; she looked at him with love, gratitude, and passion.

Rubén turned off the computer and remained thoughtful, unable to prevent the pleasant memories of his life with his mother from coming to mind: 22 years in his studio alongside that companion, who was a combination of discipline and sweetness, always willing to assist him while respecting his own inclinations. Except for a few pre-established rules of order and discipline on which she was inflexible, she always respected his individuality and natural inclinations. He didn't recall her ever asking him what she would become in life, and yet he was fully aware that it was a subject that interested her deeply.

Of the decisions his parents made regarding him, perhaps this was the one he was most grateful for. Perhaps during that time, he acquired that shy, introverted, and somewhat solitary character; crowds and company unnerved him. In return, he enjoyed a certain spiritual peace and great self-confidence, which allowed him to

projecting an image of serenity and firmness that was highly respected. He spent most of his time in his study, in the gym, or on the terrace, filled with pots of tropical plants and flowers, insects, birds, and where he always encountered some small animals from the ranch's orchards and coconut groves. These rooms had ended up becoming his little kingdom, an extension of himself. In the center was the study itself, with his work table, some bookcases and musical instruments, and a comfortable sofa, from where he had traveled the world, visiting almost every country, their landscapes, history, traditions, and customs. He was passionate about wildlife and had watched hundreds of documentaries about animals, delving into the behavior of many of them.

He expanded his professional studies by coming into contact with the most advanced technologies of his time, meeting many people through various national and international associations that shared his interests, and learning and speaking four different languages with people from many countries. He was perfectly informed about events of global significance; he watched documentaries and read biographies of historical and current figures from around the world. He visited their homes and the paths they walked during their moments of meditation and rest, and the tools they used for their discoveries and studies. He visited virtually every museum of natural history, science, technology, art, anthropology, and history in the world, and delved into the works and events that interested him.

Before choosing his professional studies, he had the opportunity to observe how various professionals, artisans, artists, writers, farmers, and ranchers carried out their activities through vocational guidance videos. He listened to them enumerate the advantages and disadvantages of their activities. He was aware of the most advanced scientific research of his time, their successes and failures, and had seen daring men experience the most unlikely adventures, penetrating jungles, climbing mountains, or traveling into the infinite celestial space.

He had a universal overview of the world's culture, customs, landscapes, achievements, and failures, and he had achieved it all from his studio, through that 1.40 m x 1.00 m screen installed on his wall in front of his desk, which he controlled at will from his computer, his friend and beloved companion, the source of all wisdom and information. He had also stored his own knowledge and opinions in his files, which he had deemed appropriate to safeguard. Now he harbored the immense hope, accompanied by the illusion of adequate financial compensation, that his thesis, "*Application of Satellite Tracking Data to the Planning of Mexico*," would be part of SICRM, and with a bit of vanity—why not?—he aspired to the same BMD.

All of this came to his memory after having witnessed the moment when his parents had made those two decisions so transcendent in his life and he felt that his

His gratitude grew, as did his immense love for them. But along with that feeling, the profound sense of loneliness that had plagued him ever since that terrible day he was deprived of their company revived.

Shortly after, he continued staring at the screen, and sequences and images, now perfectly identified in his memories, began to appear. He saw his mother working at home in front of her own computer. Who would have thought that the decision to be with her son would open up the world to him?

The images continued to flash: his teenage life, always in the company of his uncles and cousins. The views he expressed on life, his philosophy, and I watched them change as the years passed, how they evolved, some becoming increasingly complex, while others became clearer.

The time came for his coming-of-age ceremony, that fantastic day in that his father handed him his magnetized card saying:

—Son, you have always been the master of your own life, but until this date, your parents have decided certain matters related to your freedom. From now on, you are the master of your life, your will, and your freedom. You will choose and forge your own destiny, and you will be the sole judge of your own actions. Be creative and happy.

Then his mother appeared and said to him:

—In a previous recording, I promised you a message. Your father and I have gone over it over and over again, rewriting it a hundred times: “Everything we would like to say at this moment has been said over 18 years of living with you, filled with love. We have done so with words, but most importantly with our example. Take from this what seems appropriate to you. Live your own life and remember that in us there has been and will always be only love for you. Bless you, and may God be with you.”

Rubén, calm, recovered, with profound spiritual peace and great confidence, did what he had never done before: he typed the code **HECR000101HQRRHB03** on his keyboard , followed by the code (dpim), available to everyone. From that moment on, everything he had experienced was available to anyone who requested it; his life was an open book.

The commission he had been assigned truly fascinated him; he felt fortunate and fulfilled. A Central American country, once a great nation, had just shaken off the yoke of a long dictatorship, and its new leaders, members of the victorious national liberation movement, had requested that the UN carry out a thorough study to analyze the possibility of implementing the SIC in the country. The UN had appointed Mexico as the designated nation to conduct the study, due to the fact that it already operated the system, its geographic proximity, and, most importantly, its historical similarities, which made it possible to draw on past experiences.

The government, in turn, had appointed him as head of the Commission for the Study of Adaptation of Methods and Systems for the Implementation of the Central Information System in Latin American Countries (ceamsiscpla), which would later be abbreviated as the Commission for Latin American Studies (cela).

The committee was composed of Rubén, as director, and three deputy directors: Fernando Plascencia, Computer Science; Eduardo Hernández, Economics; and Juan Tok, Sociology. Each of them would be in charge of the different areas of their respective specialties, and they would always agree with him. His responsibility was enormous, but he felt no fear of it; on the contrary, he felt a deep desire to face the challenge with the utmost responsibility and a great fighting spirit. He was aware that he would have to perform serious teamwork, that he would have to compile, analyze, and analyze data of various kinds, that he would have to be forgiving when listening and clear and concise when organizing. Teamwork worried him because he was very independent, but he was fully aware of the challenges that teamwork presents when integrating diverse branches of specialization. The combined efforts to integrate a whole always filled him with euphoria.

He had the SIC **cards** of his collaborators and the resumes of each one. While driving, he decided to listen to them to get to know them better. He picked up the first one, by Fernando Plascencia.

Fernando had personally recorded it and authorized anyone who listened to it to confirm their information at the Central Bank. A great passion for electronics, which manifested itself since his childhood, had led him towards cybernetics. Fernando stated: "Humanity has had two great tools of evolution throughout its history: faith and

"Cybernetics." This phrase, a strange blend of social technology and science, stuck with him deeply and didn't seem contradictory; on the contrary, he experienced that rare inner sense of balance he felt when a clear idea was communicated to him.

The recording was very long. It described Fernando's childhood, adolescence, youth, and early adulthood. As she listened to it, she felt a natural sympathy for him; without knowing him, she knew many things about his life and realized his great passion for music.

The final phrase of the recording moved and puzzled him at the same time. As Talking to himself, Fernando said:

"To you, my self and constant companion, I say that you know and perhaps understand more about me than I remember. That you summarize my past and present; that you possess more of me than my own memory, but that you exist because I so desire. That you lack will, and your future depends on me. That you are today, and if I so desire, tomorrow you are not. That you are not created in my image or likeness. That you are merely a tool for me to use in my creative endeavor and my evolutionary drive. That's who you are, let no one be mistaken!

He smiled and understood the message Fernando had conveyed in his recording, which he shared.

Then he heard the second one, that of Eduardo Hernández, and, as in the case of Fernando, he turned off the image so as not to be distracted.

It was a conventional recording full of technical data. Eduardo's resume was very impressive given the number of graduate courses he had. She was particularly interested in the courses on cybernetic agroecoeconomics, as the country they would be studying would require them, as it was still in the pre-industrial era and still depended on conventional agricultural products. She noted that Eduardo was married with four children. It was unusual for a person with his resume to have such a large family. Obeying more on impulse than a well-thought-out rational action, she contacted Eduardo. Since she was in the car, it took a few seconds for the shortwave frequency to be picked up and the image to appear. Eduardo answered personally.

Rubén, without further preamble than a courteous greeting, said:

"Eduardo, I've heard your resume. I'm very satisfied; I suppose you've studied mine."

—That's right, Ruben, and I'm very happy to be working with you.

—Eduardo, may I ask you a personal question?

—Go ahead, Ruben, do it.

—Why such a large family? May I know why you decided to have one?

"Of course," Eduardo replied, smiling, "for two fundamental reasons. The first is because my profession and my studies have made me an optimist about the future. I believe there will be abundance for future generations. I will show you the second."

And as he opened his camera lens, the entire family appeared on the screen: three older children and a beautiful little girl, just like her mother, named Patricia, smiling, playing an electronic board game with her siblings. When she noticed, she turned to the camera and blew a kiss, smiling slyly.

Eduardo asked, "Is that enough for you? Chasing this one is how I dared to take four. It was worth it!"

Rubén, with a big smile, said, "Thank you, Eduardo, and congratulations. We'll be in touch. Best regards and thank you."

He disconnected the monitor and for a long time he stayed with the image of Patricia and her four children playing. He thought he understood Eduardo and found himself bewildered.

He was a great advocate for small families, having been an only child himself, but from time to time he would get the feeling that something was missing. At that moment, that feeling hit him intensely, and with sadness reflected on his face, he realized what it was.

The afternoon was splendid, and he loved driving. The countryside gave him a soothing sensation. The GPS indicated that the Toro Dam was nearby. He liked the idea of touring the irrigation district again and receiving an explanation. The subject interested him; he wanted to understand it.

Minutes later, he entered a clean room with a large whiteboard and various monitors. In front of him was agricultural engineer David Fernández, who, with a big smile and a mocking tone, invited him to take a field tour, "From this comfortable armchair, listening to a recording with Beethoven's music in the background."

Puzzled, Ruben took a seat in front of a large screen and put on his headphones. We were willing to see and listen, a little disappointed, but very interested.

Nothing surprised him in the first ten minutes: the original state of the land, previous and current satellite photographs, aerial shots, and the plan's schedule, all delivered in a somewhat demagogic tone. At the end, he asked Fernández:

—Is it true that the area devoted to fruit trees can increase tenfold simply through the rational and measured use of water and the humidity it produces?

Fernández replied: "Maybe not tenfold, but fivefold—we're already doing it! It's an absolute reality with targeted irrigation and optimal humidity detectors that automatically activate the system. You'll see it during our remote-controlled visit."

Fernández began with a panoramic view of the dam and said jokingly, "It's going to be hard to drain all that water, drop by drop, but we'll do it, and you'll see it happen." He then showed off a complex facility that looked more like a large refinery than something related to an irrigation district:

—Here we purify the water and enrich it with the various fertilizers and corresponding ingredients. Notice the eight large pipes leading from it; each one carries water with different nutrients that in turn flow to the different irrigation areas.

"For example, we can follow line one, which carries water to area number one, which is fruit trees. The outlet line ends one kilometer away at this large tank," he said, showing an image of the tank. "Four secondary lines emerge from it by gravity, which in turn supply ten large systems, each of which supplies ten branches, each of which supplies ten hectares, so we have 1,000 hectares of irrigated fruit trees.

"Each ten-hectare branch is distributed in an area that strives to be as uniform as possible in terms of soil characteristics. The valve you see on the screen with its individual container allows you to regulate the nutrients in the water, in addition to those already brought in from the 'refinery,' as we jokingly call it.

"Those valves you see buried in the ground, electrically connected to each other, determine the humidity coefficient and automatically activate the system when required. Everything is automatic and controlled from this room. Quality and quantity are delivered directly to the point of consumption, as the drippers are also controlled; this is what we call maximum soil and water optimization with maximum efficiency in performance."

"This is how we feed the plant, eliminating vaporization leaks and excess water, which are the most common in a conventional system."

Smiling, and as if in a confidential tone, Fernandez added:

—I have seen and heard your resume; I know that you are not a politician and I know the reasons why you are visiting us. I will speak to you frankly.

"What we have just witnessed is an absolute reality. The water efficiency and results of the plantations, which total 2,000 hectares, are the best in the country, without question and without demagoguery, but the matter is not as clear-cut as it seems.

"The system's objectives are fundamentally threefold: land, water, and production. But the criterion that must prevail is economic, and unfortunately, some of the new systems have been implemented for political reasons, resulting in inadequate systems in inadequate locations and with dubious results. Therefore, the rational study of reserves and resources must be ended, and we must leave it to the electronic brains to decide where, when, why, for what purpose, for what reasons, and for what market, what products, and in what form the next districts should be established. If we do not establish these premises clearly, the technology will not yield the desired results, and we will only continue to create images of developmentalism and not real development."

"We must also consider the problem of labor, which is critical in the country where you will be operating, since it is argued that computer systems reduce labor in the field. Any economist will refute this with grounds, but policies, which ignore reality, do not take into account that statistically each hectare

The area of harvested product generates at least one permanent source of employment, if the product is in turn industrialized.

"On the other hand, my friend, you must not overlook the fact that in the countryside, life, science, and technology move to the rhythm of the sun. In the countryside, there is still night and day, activity and rest. Do not forget that agricultural development has been and continues to be the slowest to evolve, and that while it is true that we irradiate seeds, select them using cybernetic methods, feed them more and better, protect them from pests, make plants more productive and resistant, accelerate their development, their production, select them genetically, etc., we make them produce through natural methods, and these maintain their rhythm, the rhythm of time, the rhythm of life. I can only tell you that altering that rhythm without foundation, without study, without planning and planning can produce the greatest failure, not in the plants we manage, but fundamentally in ourselves, human beings."

Fernández asked politely: "Anything else, Mr. Hernández?"

And when she remained silent,

he added: "I will always be at your service. With your permission."

And he left the white and sterile "operating room" of the Paso del Toro irrigation district.

Already in his car on the way to Guadalajara, he began to recover. After his conversation with Fernández, they showed him the "plots without laborers," strips of land worked with sliding frames that plow, fallow, fertilize, sow, irrigate, clean, harvest, and till completely automatically. They showed him the automatic harvesting equipment, the targeted sprinklers... He was impressed by the district's technology, but even more impressed by what Fernández had said.

Until that moment he became fully aware of the responsibility of his mission. He perfectly realized that Fernández was speaking to him about the problems Mexico had faced when he was born. Words like "demagoguery" and "unemployment" took on their true meaning in the countryside, that slow and beautiful place where seemingly nothing happens and which is and always has been where ideas are realized. He remembered his sociology professor saying: "When a change takes root among the people of the countryside, it transforms underdeveloped countries, unlike industrialized countries, never before." That's a difference that few people have been able to understand."

He hadn't understood it at the time, and in response to what Fernández said—a technician like him who understood it—for the first time he became aware of and felt fear in the face of the mission that had been assigned to him. Fear of not knowing enough, of not understanding when facing the world of the past. And he said to himself: "I have never feared either the present or the future, but I hadn't thought about the past. Perhaps the past, my past, was not resolved."

"to with the SCC," and suddenly felt on his shoulders the weight of the history of the past, of the miserable, backward peoples who still suffer from hunger, ignominy, and the worst of all human evils: ignorance. He felt overwhelmed by the responsibility.

Upon arriving in Guadalajara, the GPS guided him to his hotel. Minutes later, he handed over his card at the reception desk and, with a single action, his arrival was registered in his private system: the corresponding account was opened, it was recorded in the telephone exchange, in the bar, in the restaurant, and—at his request—in the city's visitors' registry for work purposes, as well as in the registry of the state SIC office, leaving a note in the messages section that he would arrive at 10:00 a.m., the time at which the appointment had been scheduled.

Meanwhile, he watched the registration difficulties of a beautiful woman at his side—who most certainly came from some underdeveloped country without a SIC card—he was about to offer his help when two collaborators arrived, but their movements put him in front of her. When their gaze met, he experienced a strange sensation. She had a firm, resolute gaze, and she was a very beautiful woman.

He offered to help her, but Teresa calmly rejected him. Disconcerted, he retreated to his chambers. Sleep came to him amidst unexpected excitement. His last conscious images were of the beautiful woman at the counter and her steady gaze.

His cell phone, whose screen displayed the face of a pretty young woman asking to confirm her 10:30 a.m. **appointment** with Mr. Gallo, director of the **state** SIC, woke him up. Without connecting the imaging system, he grumpily confirmed it and disconnected.

Annoyed with himself for the abruptness of his response, he cleared his head and prepared to take a good bath.

He was having a leisurely breakfast at 7:30 in the morning, wondering what to do for the next three hours, when the beauty from the day before appeared at his side and, without further ado, introduced herself as María Teresa Ríos, Nicaragua's delegate for the study of the implementation of SIC in her country.

—I know who you are, can I join you for breakfast?

"Of course!" he replied cheerfully, and as he stood up awkwardly to invite her to sit down, he almost spilled the juice he was drinking.

—Forgive my clumsiness, but I don't usually have such beautiful company at this time of the morning.

Aware once again of her inappropriate apology, she blushed.

She noticed this and, with a sincere smile, said,

"Forgive me, my introduction was perhaps hasty, but I couldn't resist approaching the person on whom the future of my country largely depends. I want to tell you that I spent more than 24 hours in front of my embassy's computer reviewing your life from beginning to end, or at least what you authorized."

He answered candidly: —I

authorized everything.

—I assumed so. I think I know more about you than I do about myself. I'm delighted to meet you. Did I tell you my name? Call me María Teresa, please, or better yet, Tere, if speaking familiarly to a stranger doesn't bother you. For my part, allow me to call you Rubén, if you don't mind, because I'm sorry to meet you. I think I know more about you than I do about many of my friends. I've carefully reviewed your life, so you're already an important person to me.

Sorry, I was hasty again.

And looking down, she blushed.

Rubén, more confident and aware of what was happening, took her hand gently and said: "Tere, you are wonderfully hasty. I

hope you continue the same, because there is much to be learned."

I need to know about your country and about yourself.

He remained silent, feeling deep down that his interest in knowing was not sufficient. hierarchy that had been expressed.

They had breakfast like two old friends. He answered her countless questions and was pleasantly surprised to notice the care with which she had listened and watched the videos of his life, remembering names and family dates important to him. Suddenly, he began to feel something "with a fire mark," as his mother would say, something deep and definitive. Tere had touched him; that unknown woman fascinated him minute by minute.

It had been a shock for her. She saw him against the light in the window overlooking a beautiful hotel garden. First, she felt like she was speaking to a lifelong friend; then to someone more important. She seemed to guess his every response. In the end, her bewilderment was total, as was her joy. As they said goodbye to meet at 10:30 for the official presentation, she only managed to say:

—I want you to know that I'm a widow and I'm 27 years old. Excuse me.

And she walked away confused and surprised by the wonderful moment she had experienced.

Unaware of the time, he arrived at the **state-run** SIC at 10:00 a.m. He was greeted by the receptionist, who recognized him because, as was her custom, at 8:30 she had seen on her screen the photographs of all the day's visitors who had an appointment. She led him to a large meeting room, offered him a cup of coffee, and gave him some news that surprised him. The secretary at

The head of the SICRM would be at the meeting. He was surprised, as he hadn't expected Juan Hurtado, his boss, to be present. He felt a mixture of respect and fear toward him; he judged him to be a mix of technician and politician. At times, he seemed surprisingly informed; at other times, backward and indirect. The impression he made on her was confusing, but he was a whirlwind of action at work, honest and dedicated, and he had earned her respect. On the other hand, Hurtado admired Rubén and saw him as the very embodiment of the men who would create a better future for humanity. He had intervened directly with the president to appoint Rubén to that position. The mission wasn't easy because the Secretary of the Interior wanted the position for his nephew, who, in Hurtado's opinion, wasn't qualified to carry it out.

The opening session of the program would be solemn, more so than he had anticipated, and he felt awkward having arrived so early. Suddenly, the door opened and Tere walked in, wearing a different dress than the one she had worn just two hours earlier at breakfast. He found her splendid, sober, and elegant; even her hairstyle was a subtle difference; she was more formal than at breakfast. She arrived accompanied by her country's foreign minister, whom she introduced to Rubén with a familiarity he wasn't used to.

He said simply: "Rubén,

this is José Araiza. He's my country's Foreign Secretary, a great patriot, a great friend, and I dare say the most fervent defender of the implementation of the sic. During the revolution, he served as our liaison with the rest of the world, which gave him an accurate understanding of the system, having lived in countries that had already established it."

Turning to José, he said,

"This is Rubén Hernández Chi. During our trip from Mexico City, I think I bored you talking about what I saw of him on his monitor.

Rubén greeted him effusively and respectfully. José Araiza's name was universally known, as he had given the first speech of the Nicaraguan National Liberation Front after the triumph of the revolution against the dictatorship. His phrase, "Dictatorships are regressive; it is humanity's duty to combat them," had a worldwide impact, sparking controversy at the UN, as it was said to denote a tendency to export the revolution to other countries. The topic was widely discussed.

Tere was accompanied by three remarkably young assistants, the oldest of whom was no more than 35. Tere introduced them as Commander Javier González, Dr. Lucio Cañedo, and her personal secretary, Carlos Arturo Aguado, who caught Rubén's attention with his youth and spirit, which radiated confidence.

Shortly after, Hurtado entered with his inseparable friend and personal secretary, Mario Ernesto Porres, whom Rubén seriously disliked, finding him elusive and complex. Whenever he saw him, he wondered why Hurtado had chosen him for such a position. Then the governor entered with four or five aides, and finally Fernando Plascencia, Eduardo Hernández, and Juan Pok.

The quorum was present, 16 people in total.

After the introductions on the main screen, they took their places around the table. Rubén was greatly surprised and couldn't help but turn to look at Commander Javier González, whom Tere had so familiarly introduced him to a few minutes earlier: he was Commander Zero, world-famous and now Commander-in-Chief of the Nicaraguan Army, and at Dr. Lucio Cañedo, none other than the Secretary of Development. Rubén turned to Tere with a reproachful look, which she noticed and responded with a wink, which made him even more uncomfortable.

During the opening, Hurtado explained that at the last minute, given the presence of such distinguished visitors, the president, a longtime supporter of the Nicaraguan National Liberation Front, had sent him with his personal representative since the meeting wasn't planned to be at such a high level. Rubén noticed the discomfort of the Nicaraguan delegation, which had surely altered protocol without prior notice.

Hurtado continued saying:

—Through me, the President sends you his warmest greetings and expresses his firm support for the energetic efforts undertaken by the people and government of Nicaragua to advance a world of justice and peace.

The governor then spoke, clearly having no idea what the meeting was about and lavishing praise on the sister nation that had achieved freedom...

Hurtado was in charge of making the presentation on behalf of the Mexicans.

—Gentlemen, I have the pleasure of introducing the delegation that will represent Mexico in this request from the sister Republic of Nicaragua. They will have full powers and independence in all areas in which they participate: Dr. Rubén Hernández Chi, Director of SCC **Implementation** for Mexico in sister countries of Latin America; Mr. Juan Estrada Cajigal, Governor of the State of Jalisco, host of this meeting; Mr. Mario Ernesto Porres, my private secretary, who will be the commission's daily liaison with me. —Rubén couldn't help but show a look of displeasure, which he noticed.

María Teresa—, Mr. Fernando Plascencia, Head of Computing and Archives, Dr. Eduardo Hernández, Head of Economics for the Commission, and Dr. José Tok Pakal, Head of Sociology. And now I'll give the floor to Rubén, and I clarify that it's customary in the Secretariat I lead to call each other by our first names.

Rubén asked María Teresa to introduce the members of the Nicaraguan delegation. She proceeded: "Mr.

José Araiza, revolutionary, Minister of Foreign Affairs, who as part of his duties has visited some of the countries that have implemented the SCC and who proposed it to our country's Governing Junta. General Javier González, revolutionary, known to you and the world as Commander Zero and head of the Revolutionary Army. Dr. Lucio Cañedo, revolutionary and Secretary of Development."

Economic Affairs, Mr. Carlos Aguado, revolutionary and private secretary of a servant, Dr. María Teresa Ríos Espíndola, general coordinator of the Implementation of the SIC in the Republic of Nicaragua.

Rubén was surprised, because Commander Javier Espíndola was famous for regrouping Commander Ortega and all his troops after they were defeated in the first confrontation with the army, and upon entering the capital triumphantly at the head of the army, he was assassinated by a fanatic in the parade. He assumed she was the widow of Commander Espíndola, the first great hero and martyr of the triumphant revolution.

Then the governor said:

"Gentlemen, I declare the session open and I beg your pardon as I owe withdraw from a meeting with the greengrocers of the municipal markets and their leaders.

He stood up, nodded, turned around and left.

Rubén felt embarrassed by the governor's abrupt and clumsy farewell, but he wasn't surprised, as it was well known that Governor Juan Estrada Cajigal (known as Canijal, from "small") was not a supporter of the sic, whose principles hampered his economic and political activities. He spoke again:

—As you all know, the implementation of SIC is based on five fundamental principles, which are worth remembering:

- It is only established in countries with democratic governments.
- It only applies to countries that belong to free trade, although it is important to note that it can be applied to cooperatives and therefore to socialist countries.
- It is a purely technical instrument applied without any political purpose, oriented toward the common good and inducing economic development.
- It requires the approval of Congress and the Senate, with independent financial allocations, an autonomous council, and leaders approved by Congress, the Senate, the presidency of the republic, and the corresponding business coordinating council or private association. Its director must be a person who has not recently held public office and who is recognized by the association of countries affiliated with the SIC.
- It must be approved by citizen vote. (We know that this requirement has already been met and that the people of Nicaragua approved it by an overwhelming majority.)

"In developing countries, the process begins in two parallel stages: on the one hand, a universal citizen registry is established, where all the main data is recorded. On the other, the process of agricultural technology is initiated with a cooperative financed by the World Bank, with an association of independent agricultural producers who contribute their land, or with a specific unit and a farmer with a farm larger than 1,000 hectares who contributes their land and capital.

"We know that the governing junta, led by President Ortega, has set July 6, 2031, as the date for elections. This makes the start of the SIC in Nicaragua an exception. The current government, born from the revolution, was approved by 96% of citizens in a plebiscite and four years were given for party formation. Parties with more than 5% of the registered signatures of the electorate are expected to participate in the first elections. We believe the electoral register can serve as a starting point for the SIC of personal data."

"The Association of Central American Countries, where the World Bank and the UN also have voting rights, endorse this effort as a model that can be replicated in other Central American countries."

"It is essential to emphasize that the funds allocated to this project over the next two years will come from the UN, the World Bank, and Mexico, which will cover the expenses and costs of this commission, charged to the Mexican Embassy in Nicaragua, as a contribution to the development of our sister republic."

"Starting with the 2031 elections, in which Congress will be elected, it will have to determine and allocate the budgets for the SIC, and that will be the definitive moment for the constitutional launch of the SCC."

"It is important to mention that its foundations, procedures, and objectives must be clearly established in the new constitution that the first democratic congress approves in its first sessions, as has been announced, and this will be the seventh requirement for formally establishing the SIC in Nicaragua."

Hurtado suggested a lunch break, and that the meal be shared in pairs, in agreement with the relevant specialists and officials. Rubén, as head of the Mexican delegation, was assigned to eat with María Teresa, head of the Nicaraguan delegation.

The session will resume at 4:00 p.m. with a four-hour program featuring presentations by the three department heads: sociology and politics, computing, and economics.

From that moment on, Rubén experienced two hours of indescribable intensity; the two most passionate and disconcerting hours of his life. Having spent his childhood and youth studies practically in seclusion, his experience of love was limited to the deep feelings toward his mother and the sympathy and affection for the cousins and friends with whom he spent time as a family on weekends and vacations. On a long trip to various countries around the world, he met several women who provoked a profound attraction in him, but never the intensity and rapture that enveloped María Teresa's presence from that afternoon on.

The first thing that struck him when he stood before her was her blue eyes, so intense they seemed dark, yet possessing an indescribable depth and beauty. This quality impressed him deeply, as she was a brunette with blue eyes, an impeccable figure, and wearing heels practically his own height, 1.82 meters.

On the other hand, I noticed in her a kind of inner peace that I had never felt in anyone else, strengthened by the immense security she radiated.

They spent a few minutes in silence, observing each other. Finally, he said, "You're Espíndola's widow. Am I correct?"

She, with a slight smile, confirmed that this was indeed the case, and following an impulse, she narrated:

—It was a marriage both fortunate and unfortunate. Javier and I met at university while studying economics, and we were friends from the beginning. After graduating, we became boyfriend and girlfriend, but he knew I wanted to pursue a master's degree and a postgraduate degree, precisely the postgraduate degree the UN had established for SIC.

Javier knew perfectly well that this was my wish and that I would hardly change my mind. Then he made me a most disconcerting proposal:

—I'm experiencing the only profound conflict I've ever had in my life. You know I'm an enemy of the dictatorship. I've never had the opportunity to do anything against it. Making a mistake seemed absurd to me, even though I can't help but see the cruel and profound repression that suffocates us.

"Now I have to tell you a secret I swore I wouldn't tell anyone with one exception, and that exception is you. Ortega, our comrade and friend [he was our closest friend and also an idealist, like Javier], just asked me to join a revolutionary movement in the mountains of Nicaragua. He told me something incredibly hard to believe had happened. That Jesús Smith, our schoolmate and son of the U.S. ambassador, named Jesús Smith like his son, had invited him to dinner at the embassy.

'At the beginning of the dinner, the ambassador said to me

directly: "Jesus, you are a friend of my son's and also his namesake, as well as mine, and we have thought, given your ideals and passion, that you may be the right person to start a national liberation movement, because we believe that a leader is needed who is both university-educated and capable of facing the challenges of the future. We know that you have a distant family relationship with Commander Ortega, president and dictator who, upon his death, passed the presidency to his wife, Sofía, the current dictator of Nicaragua.

As you understand, this decision has been deeply considered and is not a clean slate. Since Ortega's death, and especially since Sofía's rise to power, we knew that his government would descend into a communist dictatorship, because we know Sofía's Spanish advisors and they are rabid communists who played a part in the disaster in Venezuela, with all the dire consequences we are all familiar with.

'We've worked with the ranchers in the south, whose lands were stolen by Sofía, and they've formed a group willing to take up arms to overthrow the dictator, but they asked that the leader be a young person with a university education.

'At the same time, in some properties in the area, in basements for this purpose, we have created sufficient arsenals to start an armed movement. Many of those who are in the

The list includes older but experienced people, as they were “contras” in the previous revolution, as well as other revolutionaries who felt betrayed.

'Our intelligence informs us that there are other groups forming with similar intentions; that is, the country is ripe for the beginning of this movement. On the other hand, I inform you that the United States will be behind you, with capital, weapons, and direct advice for the movement that you can lead.'

Ortega was speechless. He had never considered that alternative for himself, but the idea moved him to the core, and he felt his fate was already sealed.

According to Jesús, he responded with something we were never able to confirm: 'Mr. Ambassador, I accept with absolute unconditional acceptance and I inform you that the first person I intend to invite to this fight is Javier Espíndola, with whom I have discussed this possibility on countless occasions.'

The ambassador replied that from then on, everything was his responsibility, that he should form his battle cadres, as well as later form his government cadres, with absolute autonomy, and that the American government would only support the revolution in the way he had mentioned, and that it would have no further interference in the matter.

That day, Javier and I talked until dawn, but at the last minute, a fear appeared that darkened the outlook. Javier knew I was pregnant with what would be our first child. He told me: "You can't go to the mountains, to the

guerrilla, in the state you're in. The pregnancy has been difficult, and I don't want to risk our child. I propose the following: we get married immediately, we go to the United States for our honeymoon, you stay there, and I secretly return to the guerrilla."

I wanted to shout no, but he added: "You will study for your master's and doctorate at the BMD, which is the great passion of your life [Rubén immediately thought of his mother with the same passion]. "At the end of the revolution, you will return to implement that system in Nicaragua. That will be the only condition I will impose on Ortega to support him in this effort, and I will do so with all my love so that you can realize your dream, not only of studying the system but of establishing it in a free, sovereign country, like the Nicaragua of our dreams."

I knew deep down in my heart that the proposal was right; that I couldn't stand the life of a guerrilla in my country, and that I couldn't stay in Nicaragua as the wife of a guerrilla. So I accepted, with a great pain in my heart but at the same time with a great hope.

We went to Washington, where Javier held several interviews with people from the CIA. We spent two wonderful months and said goodbye filled with excitement. No one imagined the revolution would last four years, much less Javier's tragic end.

Upon my return, Ortega welcomed me with deep affection and immediately appointed me director of the BMD Program and the SIC. A year later, the plebiscite was passed, and that's the story and the reason why I'm here now.

I can only add that I have been a very happy child, a teenager and an adult, and That except for the loss of Javier, my life has been pleasant and peaceful.

I have felt deeply loved by my parents, who are fortunately alive and well. My father is a great reader, especially history, and often says that it is necessary to know it to understand the world and its vicissitudes. In my case, during my four years in Washington, I also developed a deep interest in history and spiritual themes and the evolution of humanity.

Rubén gazed at her, lost in thought, with an emotion he had never experienced before. The thought crossed his mind that she would be his lifelong companion. They returned to the meeting at the scheduled time, and Juan began by introducing Fernando Plascencia, head of Computing and Records.

Fernando began by saying: "The

computing and archiving area encompasses three major divisions, which are as follows: First, the vast bmd **database** not only replaces the great encyclopedias of humanity, but also attempts to encompass all human knowledge, from the beginning of the universe to the present day: evolution, history, philosophy, sciences, activities, professions, and specialties. It has more than 50 million files translated into more than 300 languages."

"I must clarify that the data update department is interconnected with all research centers and universities in partner countries and many other affiliated countries, with all private technology development centers, and with the research centers of chemical and biological laboratories, which update their information daily. All research, epidemiology, and medical experimentation protocols are described and can be followed there.

"Furthermore, all schools in the BMD **member countries** have virtual classrooms where teachers and students can explore any topic of human knowledge currently available. The BMD places great importance on this topic and provides scholarships in all member countries for teachers who choose to upgrade their knowledge of the BMD, so they can make the most of it in their teaching."

"In short, there is no subject of human knowledge that is not covered by the BMD. It only remains to add that the BMD is under the control of the United Nations, which manages and supervises it, such that it is the United Nations General Assembly that controls it and guarantees its neutrality.

"Secondly, the SIC **database** is the repository where the personal data of all residents of the countries where the BMD is established is gathered. This has always been a very complex issue in all the countries where the system is established, but we believe it is the heart of the center.

"It records everything from birth to death, that is, their entire life, with key health data and progress, including annual checkups, illnesses and treatments, academic studies, and the work they have done.

"There are private divisions where every citizen can record anything they want: dialogues, ceremonies, interviews, personal conversations, philosophical, religious, political, and economic viewpoints—anything related to themselves and their environment. Filmed on video, or just recorded, you can have everything you want in it and divide it into two sections, public and private, and it's up to you to make everything you want public or confidential.

"Third, the media archive, which brings together all current communication media: telephone, WhatsApp, Facebook, Twitter, email, satellite television, cable, direct 3D communication, etc. It functions as a means of communication that is not recorded anywhere except at the explicit and coded request of the user, with the consent of those participating in it.

"These are the three main areas of the bmd, the great world information center known as the *stratosphere*, in reference to the *cloud* of the 2000s."

It was Dr. Eduardo Hernández's turn, Head of Economics:

—This department of the MDB relates solely and exclusively to the economies of the countries in which the system is implemented. It has already been clarified that it is established only in free market economies, and therefore integrated into the "Universal Free Trade Agreement," to which all nations that sign the MDB are registered.

"The treaty is established with all nations that meet the minimum requirements for freedom. It has already been stated that they must be democracies, and therefore meet the basic requirements of any democracy, which not only mean free elections, but must also have social security; labor laws that fairly govern the relations between workers and employees; freedom of association; minimum wage laws that guarantee adequate subsistence levels; education systems that guarantee the training of their citizens, whether public or private, but a free system that allows everyone a guaranteed level of education; affordable housing programs that guarantee homes with the required water, electricity, sewage, and urban services, etc. All these laws and regulations must be public and will be in the BMD for consultation by any person, country, or company.

"Similarly, all financial statements of companies affiliated with the stock exchanges of all countries that make up the BMD community were published, and private companies that so wish may also do so, so that any interested party can access information to start business in any other country.

"There is a department of production and price statistics for all the manufactures produced in the world, so that when a new business is started in any area of the economy, whether agricultural, industrial, tourist, etc., the entrepreneur can obtain studies on his future projects anywhere.

of the world. This department also deals with initiatives that the World Bank finances in any country around the world.

“This is the final instrument of the so-called *global economy* that is used for everything international trade on the planet.”

Finally, Dr. José Tuk Pakal, a friend of Rubén, spoke. Originally from his mother's village, his grandfather had helped José's father support his son until he completed his doctorate. They were lifelong friends, although they saw each other infrequently due to Rubén's school system, mainly on weekends. He was one of the few people who introduced Rubén to the everyday world. He was known for his prodigious memory and enormous sensitivity.

—This department is responsible for establishing the standards required in countries that sign the BMD **Treaty** for the adaptation and adjustment of citizens to the processes of economic modernization and globalization, as well as for all the training courses they must receive.

“In the 1960s, the globalization of the economy began, and in the 1980s, maquiladora production became widespread. This consisted of manufacturers moving to poorer countries where wages were lower, allowing for greater competitiveness of products and more affordable prices for consumers. This, however, produced very complex social phenomena, as workers in developed countries lost jobs in manufacturing and were untrained for other service jobs, generating significant problems of unemployment and political and social discontent that demagogic politicians used to exert pressure. There were no technical and psychological training programs for workers who lost their jobs, and for this reason these social development programs were created.

“Similarly, the countries that attracted maquiladora industries generated problems with the overcrowding of labor, initially low-skilled, such as clothing manufacturing. But gradually, maquiladora industries specialized toward highly skilled workers, with higher wages but still much lower than in industrialized countries. For example, a worker in an underdeveloped country could earn \$8 an hour, while in a developed country the wage was \$26 an hour. In the countries that received maquiladora industries, technical and psychological training was required for these jobs, and there was an opportunity for both men and women to work, which generated a serious social problem for children, as there were no daycare centers or schools with trained teachers to care for the children. This department is responsible for implementing the programs that have been created with experience to guide governments in implementing them among the population.

“We must not forget that many citizens have very different paradigms and worldviews, and this program requires unity. That unity and awareness are the fundamental objective of this department.

Ruben intervened:

—There is no room for questions and answers in this session, as it is merely the formal presentation of the group that makes up the commission appointed by Mexico for the implementation of the BMD and SIC system in Nicaragua. We are scheduled to travel to Nicaragua in mid-August to begin work and resolve any questions and issues that arise.

María Teresa added:

"I appreciate everything you've said. Indeed, this is merely confirmation of the basic principles of implementing the BMD and SIC system that we had already studied and analyzed, but it was extraordinary to personally meet those responsible for helping us establish this wonderful procedure and tool for well-being and progress for the people of Nicaragua. If anyone in my delegation has any concerns, now is the time to voice them."

General Javier González raised his hand and said,

"Ever since I read and learned about the system analysis process this past year, I've had concerns about it, but I believe the right thing to do is wait to resolve them during the working sessions in Nicaragua. For now, I can only thank you for your attention and look forward to your arrival in our country."

Hurtado closed the session with a few formal words.

Rubén approached María Teresa and suggested taking her to his hotel. The rest of his entourage had decided to go to dinner, and María Teresa had declined.

—Today is Friday and the city is crazy with traffic. I'd be happy to offer my services. to accompany you.

She, without hiding her joy, accepted.

Once settled in the car, Rubén confessed: "Today,

during lunch, I experienced one of the most intense emotions of my life when I heard you describe your life with such extraordinary simplicity. The sincerity of your explanations, the calmness of your voice, the inner peace with which you expressed yourself—everything seemed incredible to me. I felt like I'd known you forever. I'd like to tell you about my own life with the same simplicity, but I don't even know where to begin."

"I spent the first 22 years of my life on my grandfather's ranch. My parents decided two things that would be fundamental in my life: first, that I would be the first baby registered in the SIC (National Institute of Statistics) in Quintana Roo, my home state. Second, that I would study in the *homeschool* system, created in Australia and institutionalized by the BMD at the time.

"On my grandfather's ranch, a studio was built next to and connected to the main house, equipped with the latest communications technology so I could study. So I didn't attend any school; all my training was carried out in my studio under the tutelage of my mother.

"My childhood and adolescence were spent on that ranch by the sea. My friends were my little cousins, the children of the ranch's managers, who went to school in Puerto Morelos and played with me in the afternoons. With them, I learned Mayan, the language of my grandfather, who spent every weekend with us until he died. I left the ranch on weekends to go with my parents to Puerto Morelos, Cancún, Playa del Carmen, to the parks and the cenotes, and sometimes my grandfather took me to his town with some of my cousins, and we had a lot of fun. We swam in the cenote, shot birds with slingshots, went hunting with the older kids, and ran and played all over town with complete freedom. Then came my studies in the United States and work in Mexico City, until this meeting where I met you."

She was fascinated by Rubén's story, which she already knew. She was completely drawn to his spontaneous personality, in addition to the fact that he was a tall, well-built, and handsome man. And from his brief history, she understood why he seemed different to her: his life spent on a ranch and 22 years of homeschooling had instilled in him a great sense of self-confidence, not without a certain candor. Without a doubt, he was the healthiest and most natural man she had ever met.

Rubén, quite spontaneously, said, "I know you have summer vacation. What are your plans?"

—My son is arriving from Nicaragua tomorrow. He's on vacation and about to start elementary school, so I took this break. I plan to take him to Disney World in Florida, and then we'll figure out what we can do.

—Look, I have a proposition for you. I invite you to Cancún and to see my ranch. You'll see some of the most beautiful places in Mexico, and whenever you want, you can continue your trip to Florida, or anywhere in the world, because Cancún is connected to more than 50 cities, including Managua, the capital of your country.

Without hesitating for a moment she accepted.

They arrived at the hotel door, and she said with the utmost familiarity: "I'll expect you tomorrow at 1:00 for lunch and then pick up my son at the airport at 5:00 p.m. I'm really looking forward to seeing him, and I'm sure you'll like him."

And without further ado, she said goodbye, kissed him on the cheek, got out of the car, and headed into her hotel. Once inside, she turned around and noticed Rubén with his car stopped in front of the door.

He was stunned; he couldn't believe what had just happened; he was enthralled. A car horn blaring behind him snapped him out of it, and he drove off to park at the same hotel like a zombie. He felt like a different human being. The next day they met in the hotel lobby at exactly one in the afternoon; he suggested having lunch at the airport, since he was worried about the city traffic and wanted to be on time for the child's arrival at five in the afternoon.

She gladly accepted. On the way, Rubén showed her the plane tickets for the entire family to leave for Cancún on Sunday: they would leave on the 9:00 a.m. flight and arrive around 11:00 a.m. He figured they'd be at the ranch in time for a little surprise, since Tere had mentioned it was Javier's seventh birthday.

At the restaurant, he gave her the plane tickets, and she noticed her seat was next to her son's, while Rubén would be across the aisle. She secretly appreciated the thoughtfulness; she was getting to know Rubén better. Rubén also explained that she and her son would be staying in his parents' bedroom, with two beds under mosquito nets, since even though they had air conditioning, they still needed to protect themselves from the mosquitoes.

She was nervous and the rest of the wait was distracted by talking about work issues.

At 5:30 sharp, an airline flight attendant handed Javier over. Rubén watched with delight as they embraced with joy and emotion. She couldn't hold back her tears, and between sobs, he said to her:

—My grandparents treated me very well, but I don't want you to leave me alone again.

She promised him no and Rubén watched the boy's beautiful smile.

Little Javier had slightly curly hair, a dark complexion, an aquiline nose, and deep, keen black eyes, unlike any Rubén had ever seen. María Teresa had told him about his father's famous penetrating gaze and his charisma. The boy was a delight; he had inherited both his father's and mother's characteristics: a self-confidence.

During the trip, the boy fell asleep on his mother's lap, who explained that all the energy he'd exerted vanished once he got into the car. He didn't like closed spaces; he preferred open spaces. The boy's sleepiness and the gentle caressing with which his mother caressed him encouraged them to continue in silence for the rest of the journey. The boy slept, cuddled up to his mother.

They arrived at the hotel and she said goodbye quite naturally: "See you tomorrow at 6:00. We'll be ready."

And gratefully, she kissed him on the cheek again, woke the boy, got out of the car, and went into the hotel. The boy had no luggage; she had brought it from Nicaragua so Javier wouldn't get into trouble. That cautious attitude was very characteristic of her.

He went to his room very satisfied; he had initially loved the boy.

Aside from being very handsome, she found him energetic, lively, and intelligent. She was interested in getting closer to him.

The next day, during the flight, she observed the relationship between Tere and the boy: she had brought him a screen with many games to entertain him on the plane and noticed how skillfully they both played. It was evident they were used to this and were having fun and laughing together.

Although María Teresa's first impression of the Cancún airport wasn't pleasant, as it was crowded and baggage claim was cumbersome, upon exiting the airport, a very pleasant person was waiting for them, who caught Tere's attention. He was a very dark-skinned, tall, and strong man with broad cheekbones and a serious, deep gaze. Rubén introduced him as his uncle Juan Chi and told her he was the ranch manager. Juan reacted and spoke a few words to Rubén in Mayan with a huge, radiant smile. He extended his hand to her, and upon seeing the boy, he bent down and held out his arms, calling him by name. Javier turned to look at his mother, who nodded. The boy felt like he was being lifted like a feather; in that instant, a great friendship was born, since Juan had no family.

Juan signaled, and some assistants immediately loaded the luggage onto a van. As she got in, she noticed the door was very heavy. He casually replied, "It's armored." She didn't comment further, but she remained somewhat uneasy.

The drive from the airport to the ranch surprised him because it practically bordered Puerto Morelos. Rubén told him that when he was a child and they went to Cancún, it was all jungle. Beyond Puerto Morelos, there were areas of mangroves and also jungle.

Just beyond Puerto Morelos, Juan turned left and honked his horn at a gate. When the car entered, she was stunned. It was a road flanked by large, thick palm trees and about fifty meters deep on each side of a garden; the road ended in a round water fountain with four large stone trays, from largest to smallest. There were two small colonial-style houses flanking the entrance, and at the end of the garden, cows were peacefully grazing. The car turned around the roundabout and stopped at the main entrance. The house was simple and sober, a single story, elongated, and with a carved wooden doorway that was clearly oriental. They entered, and she was stunned; the corridor ended in a terrace overlooking the beach and the most beautiful sea she had ever seen in her life, a sea of blue and turquoise.

Ruben installed them in a room and said to them:

—I have a surprise for you. I want you to meet my uncle, Jacinto Chi.

They walked out onto the terrace to the beach and to the right, to the southern corner of the ranch, where Uncle Jacinto's house was. He introduced himself, speaking with difficulty in Spanish: "Mi casa es su casa," and led them to the backyard, where Javier was surprised to see about two dozen children, ages two to ten, gathered around a large piñata. Rubén said to Javier:

—This piñata is for your birthday; you thought I hadn't remembered that today You're turning seven, but of course I remembered, and I prepared this surprise party for you.

Very gently, Uncle Jacinto called the children in a language that Javier didn't understand.

He laid out his clothes and Rubén translated for him. Jacinto said:

—Let's see, kids, his name is Javier. He's going to be with us on vacation for a few days, and we're going to play with him a lot.

And he began to call them by their names, which Rubén repeated to Javier.

There was a small piñata next to the large one and Rubén said to María Teresa: —The children are going to break it so Javier can learn the game and then they will break the large piñata which is theirs.

Juan untied a rope from a giant tree that held a pulley from which the small piñata hung; Jacinto gave the stick to a little boy, who hit the piñata with a club without hurting it. Older and older children came along. The piñata went up and down, and whenever someone managed to hit it with a stick, even though some were blindfolded, they broke off a piece. Finally, an eight-year-old girl gave it a good blow and ripped it open. Javier was surprised at how candy, fruit, and toys sprouted from it, and how all the children threw themselves to the ground to catch whatever they could.

He was having a blast in Ruben's arms and asked him to hang his.

The children were excited because it was a large, pot-bellied piñata, which surely had many toys and which aroused enormous curiosity in them, since they had never seen one so large.

Everyone surrounded the piñata, and Jacinto innocently gave Javier the club and told him in his half-Spanish that he wouldn't blindfold him because he was too small. Javier took his place, and Juan lowered the piñata and began to raise and lower it slowly. The boy got into position and, when the piñata was within reach, he hit it with such a club that it completely broke the bottom, taking everyone by surprise. Without waiting, Javier pounced on candy, toys, and fruit. The others reacted and threw themselves at him, laughing and shouting, to grab as much as they could. It was sensational, because the piñata had so much that it was enough for everyone. Rubén gave Javier a bag to put everything in. Rubén was on his knees helping him pack his loot when, unexpectedly, the boy hugged him, kissed him, and thanked him. María Teresa was crying tears of joy.

Then the children's parents arrived. Rubén introduced them one by one; they lived in the houses at the entrance to the ranch. They all sat at a table.

It was under another large tree overlooking the sea. Adults, children, and teenagers helped by bringing dishes and drinks, and the women prepared Yucatecan dishes that Rubén described to them on braziers, pots, and casseroles: papadzules, relleno negro, cochinita pibil tacos, chicharrón with pork, rice, beans, and tortillas in abundance, along with several types of fresh water and beer. The meal passed between laughter and jokes. They were like one big family, speaking in a mix of Spanish and Mayan.

A couple of hours later, Rubén thanked everyone for coming in Mayan, picked up the child, took María Teresa's arm, and walked toward the house. Javiercito, happy, excitedly talked about all the winnings he had made in the piñata, but he looked tired. When they got to his room, they found two hammocks hanging on the terrace, and Rubén said to them:

—Now you're going to learn how to take the Yucatecan siesta. Shoes off.

And laying the child down in the hammock, he began to rock him while pointing to the other hammock for Tere to lie down in. After ten minutes, he left, as the gentle sea breeze and the lullaby of the waves lulled them both into a deep sleep.

Around 5:30 p.m., the children arrived to pick up Javier. They were going to invite him to play soccer, and they brought a ball. The grass field was between Juan's house and the one at the northern end of the ranch. Rubén called Javier, and when he saw the children inviting him to play soccer with them, his eyes lit up. He had learned to play soccer in kindergarten in the United States, but mainly in pre-primary school in Nicaragua, and he loved it. He had a natural flair for all sports, but especially for soccer. Ten minutes later, the children were running after the ball. Some shirtless, others in shorts or underwear, with or without shoes, all kicking the ball, and little by little, Javier surprised them by kicking and passing the ball with ease.

While the children were playing, Rubén said to María Teresa:

—Tere, I invite you to swim a little in the sea.

She was surprised, as he had never called her that before, and she loved the diminutive and the tone. He practically never called her María Teresa again. She put on her swimsuit and happily, hand in hand, they entered the ocean. She was surprised by the warmth and clarity of the water. She was a magnificent swimmer and headed over to where the children had been playing soccer for a while. They got out of the water and sat on the beach to watch the children play. They had a great time watching them enjoy the game, shouting and laughing at each other's mistakes. When they got tired and some of them left, Javier went to where his mother was and, taking off his pants, jumped into the ocean in his underwear. Rubén asked someone to carry his clothes back to the house, and the three of them swam away. He was surprised by how well Javier swam. The return trip was a bit difficult, and when they reached the beach, Rubén explained to them that there was a current from south to north, which, when it went around the peninsula, was the Gulf Stream.

Rubén explained to Javier that when the current caught him, he shouldn't swim against it or try to return to the beach, but rather swim with the current little by little. He invited them into the water and the boy noticed the light current, how it carried them north and how

They had to leave. He showed them the reefs; he explained that they were very long, that they reached all the way to Belize, and that around them the sea was very deep and the currents were stronger.

They left the sea, took a refreshing dip, and dined on the terrace, listening to the sea and seeing the most starry sky they had ever seen. They said goodbye and left to bed.

María Teresa was truly enthusiastic and surprised by the familiarity with which Rubén treated her. She was fascinated by his character and the ease with which he navigated his world, both at work and at home. She sensed the respect and admiration everyone on the ranch had for him. He seemed like a patriarch. But what fascinated her most was the ease with which Javier had become familiar with Rubén and his surroundings in just one day.

She fell asleep peacefully and happily, as she hadn't done for a long time.

The next day, María Teresa and Javier woke up a little late, and when they arrived for breakfast, Rubén was already waiting for them, reading the newspaper. He moved him aside and naturally greeted Javier. He kissed María Teresa on the cheek and asked them how they had slept. They both replied very well and laughed because they had answered at the same time.

Rubén told them he wanted to show them the property after breakfast. After breakfast, he climbed into something resembling a golf cart, sat Javier on his lap, and sat Tere next to him.

He headed toward the main road and, once at the gate, turned left, heading for the small house on the southern corner. There, José Luis Chi was waiting for them with his wife and four children. He introduced them to Tere and told her that José Luis was in charge of quadrant No. 1, a 50-hectare plot. In the small house, there were chickens, pigs, two dogs, and two horses tied up in the shade. They said goodbye and arrived at the house that guarded the southern part of the entrance, where the same ritual was repeated. Tere was surprised that when he introduced her to the head of the house, he said, "My friend, Commander Gilberto Chi." They went to the house across the road, and she introduced them to Commander Jesús Chi and his seven children, as well as the commander's sister, since his wife had died giving birth to their fifth child, and his sister had left town because she was a widow. In fact, he clarified, the commander's children were five and his sister had brought her two children and took care of them all.

Then he headed to the north corner. The ritual was repeated: he introduced Commander Adalberto Chi, who had only four boys and no girls, and his wife. There he stopped in front of the corral, as three young men, sons of the older commanders, were bathing the cattle in a tick bath, which was a passageway that ended in a kind of narrow pool where the cattle jumped into the water with tick repellent.

Each commander of each 50-hectare corner had ten cows with their calves, and each one gave a liter of milk to the main house for Juan and whoever else was there, and the rest was for themselves. He explained that in the tropics, the zebu breed cow doesn't give much milk.

Hey, and after what the bull suckles, there's even less milk left. Javier asked how they milked, and the commander ordered them to tie a cow with a newborn calf. Miguelito, one of his sons, who was the same age as Javier, quite naturally placed a bucket under the cow's udder and, moving the calf away, began to milk it. A few minutes later, they brought glasses for each of them, including Javier, and they were fascinated by the taste and temperature of the milk, because to their surprise, it was lukewarm. Javier loved the flavor and said it tasted completely different.

Then they continued toward the sea, through the third quadrant, around the ranch. There was a wall and a wire fence four meters from the wall, and it was the path they took to reach the fifth house they were visiting. They found many chickens roaming around in a very large yard, because Guillermo Chi, a friend, loved animals and had turkeys and some animals with yellow heads, which Rubén told them were pheasants. They were observing them when suddenly a doe appeared from the grass with a small buck, his skin brown with yellow spots. Javier was excited and wanted to play with him, but Rubén told him he couldn't get too close because his mother might get angry. He also told her that there was a deer on the ranch with four females, who lived freely and wandered from one area to another. They didn't get too close to the fence because the dogs chased them.

They said goodbye and went to Juan's house, where he was waiting for them. They were surprised by the fact that he had two beautiful horses tied up in the shade of a tree and a dog with a sour face, but according to what Juan told them, he was tamer than a lapdog. Juan lived alone; his wife died along with their first child in childbirth, and he never remarried. He was cared for by an elderly woman whom Juan called Aunt Abel, which sounded like a man's name.

They said goodbye and went to the south corner, facing the sea, where Uncle Jacinto was. He greeted them with a smile and showed them the cenote where his wife bathed. It was a kind of marvelous cave, with water so crystalline that you had to throw a stone in it to see the ripples. It was as big as a swimming pool, and there was a hole in the roof through which a beam of light entered, penetrating all the way to the bottom. It was breathtakingly beautiful, and as if that weren't enough, to the left of the entrance were two pairs of gorgeous scarlet macaws, squawking like crazy as they played with each other. Upon seeing them, Javier said to his mother, "Mom, there are more animals here than at the zoo back home where you take me some Sundays." He loved animals, which matched his dynamic and playful nature, and he was delighted to enjoy the walk.

Then Jacinto led them to the corner of the ranch where there were some rocks that jutted into the sea. It was a small mound where there was a leafy, hard rubber tree that had withstood several cyclones; in the back there was a beautiful garden with four crosses and a plaque. Jacinto said, "Tata Cecilio and brother Juan—Rubén's great-grandfather and grandfather—and Alicia and Rubén—Rubén's parents."

He took off his hat and looked at the graves with a smile that seemed to Tere to be of infinite innocence. Beyond the garden was a kind of vegetable patch with Jacinto's medicinal plants, which he watered with a handheld watering can, not a hose, because he said they should be watered as if it were rain from the sky.

They returned to the house and ate, discussing their walk around the property. Tere was happy and excited, and Javier was overjoyed. Rubén explained that he called the ranch's caretakers "commanders" because during the Caste War against the whites, more than a hundred years earlier, the Maya organized themselves into an army with generals, commanders, sergeants, and troops. His grandfather Juan had named them commanders to defend the ranch, and they had taken it very seriously.

After eating and taking a mandatory siesta, Juan stopped by Javier's place, and to his surprise, he was riding a horse smaller than the others; it was black and not very pretty. They called it Chombo (the buzzard's nickname, because of its black color). It had a calm look and was riding a small, silver-encrusted saddle with short stirrups for a child. Turning to Javier, he said, "This is your birthday present," and taking him by the waist, he lifted him into the saddle. He turned to Tere and said, "Don't worry, I'll teach him how to ride with patience, and Chombo is tamer than a donkey." Taking the reins in his big hands, he started off with the child on his back, a smile that couldn't be bigger than his face. Tere's eyes watered with joy.

Ruben took her by the hand, led her to his study and settled her on a comfortable sofa in front of a big screen. He sat down next to her and said:

—It's time I told you about my family. I took all these photographs and videos; I'm a fan of photography, computers, and videos. My grandfather told me that my mother had also been fascinated by "these diabolical devices."

"My family is easy to explain. My great-grandparents were the famous Jacinto Chi, a general during the Caste War, and his wife, Alicia Peón García. My grandfather was Juan Chi; my grandmother was Alicia Medina de Chi; my father was Rubén; my mother was the same name as my grandmother, Alicia Chi Medina. She said it was a fusion of divine caste with Mayan. My aunt Meche, my uncle Jacinto, my uncle Juan, whom you already know, and me. That was the world I moved in from the first two years until I was 22, when I graduated and went to Washington to do my master's and doctorate. After finishing, I took a sabbatical year, during which I traveled around Europe and Asia. I visited 30 countries in Africa, Egypt, and Morocco. My story is simple, but its description is long, and I've decided to start with that of my grandfather Juan."

To describe the characters in his life, Rubén combined all the information his mother gathered through conversations and videos. All this information was stored in the family's private section of the BMD.

He posted a video recorded by Alicia in 2018, a month after her father died, when Ruben was 18 years old.

My beloved son. I am going to record and organize all the details of my father, your grandfather, before memory forgets them. As you will see later, your grandfather was an exceptional figure. His father, Jacinto Chi, was a general in the rebellion that history knows as the "Caste War," fought by some Mayan peoples in the late 19th and early 20th centuries, and in which they were defeated by a bloodthirsty general sent by Porfirio Díaz to pacify the Yucatán Peninsula. They were mainly from the provinces of Mérida and Valladolid, where there was a greater concentration of Mayans, although all the Mayans of the peninsula gathered during the war. In the flight following the defeat, many settled in a few places near the Caribbean coast, from the northern tip of the peninsula to very close to Chetumal, mainly around Carrillo Puerto, with its center called Chan Santa Cruz, avoiding Chetumal, as there was a small garrison of soldiers there.

Many stayed in Yucatán as laborers on the haciendas and as workers during the henequen boom, which was the first great wealth and main source of employment on the peninsula. Your great-grandfather, Jacinto Chi, settled in Ma'y Tab, near where a large sawmill for fine woods would later be built, which was another of Yucatecan's boom times. All the Chi families who were involved in the war stayed there, which is why all the townspeople called each other uncle, aunt, or cousin, and in fact they are. Your great-grandfather, after the birth of your uncle Jacinto and your grandfather Juan in 1952, went to the coast, about 30 kilometers from Puerto Morelos, a place where there was nothing and where many Maya settled and made their lives for many years, on coastal lands with a hundred meters of beach, and even several kilometers inland, from Punta Norte in Yucatán to Tulum.

There were about two hundred landowners, all like your great-grandfather, who lived from hunting and fishing. Sometimes they went to a chicle field to earn some money in the jungle, or to cut precious woods like mahogany. They also had some money to buy oil and gasoline for the lighters or the lamps, matches, clothing, ammunition, and whatever little they needed. A boat sailed from Cozumel along the coast, collecting copra from the large coconut groves there, supplying their few needs.

They lived like this for nearly 40 years, until the dirt road from Puerto Juárez to Cancún was built, where your grandfather would also work, and a major land speculation movement began. The owners were offered thousands of pesos for their land. Your great-grandfather was never interested in the offers he received, and that's when he fenced his land, also to protect the cattle he had introduced in the 1950s. He fenced 200 hectares from the highway to the sea: one kilometer of road by two kilometers to the sea. That ranch would be his adoration until his death, as it was your uncle Jacinto's, your grandfather's, mine, and I hope one day yours.

In 1974, the state's first governor, a kind, just, and native man, granted agrarian property titles to 12 of the Mayans who had fought in the caste war, along with civil and marriage registration certificates. That was how my grandfather received his first document certifying him as an owner. From then on, he had to appoint a partner.

dre at the ranch's entrance gate, because not a month went by without someone wanting to enter under the pretext of wanting to buy the property. By then, my father had already left town; he had married my mother, your grandmother, who had already died, and I was living with my uncles Jacinto and Lencha. In 1982, when your grandfather took me to live in Cancún, Uncle Jacinto went to the ranch with his father, who was already an old man of over 80 years old, and who, although strong, had to be cared for. Your great-grandfather lived to be almost 100, and when he died, Jacinto and your grandfather buried him on the stone mound on the southern edge of the ranch, which was and would later be your grandfather's favorite place to view the ocean. On the recommendation of the lawyer who had obtained the title for your great-grandfather, he was willing to donate the ranch to his children, but your uncle Jacinto said he didn't have any children and didn't want any trouble, and that it would be better to put it in my father's name. That's how the property ended up in your grandfather's name.

Your great-grandfather was venerated by the entire Mayan community, and when he died, people from all over Yucatán came to his burial. Your grandfather had to organize a ceremony with enough food and beer for all the mourners. Your uncle Juan wouldn't let me leave, and my aunt Lencha stayed behind to take care of me. I was terrified of so many people, and politicians came and gave speeches in honor of your great-grandfather.

Then Alice began to tell the story of Grandpa Juan.

Your grandfather was a very special person. When he told me stories and things that had happened to him, if he talked about his Mayan relatives and friends, he referred to them by name. But when he talked about those who weren't Mayan, he never used their names. He would say, "The governor," "The architect," "The foreman," "The manager," "My friend the engineer," "The restaurant owner," "The group of merchants who had come from Mexico," etc., identifying them by their trade or profession, never by name. He felt he could express himself much more easily that way. At first, I was a little disconcerted, but little by little, I got used to it and began to recognize who he was referring to.

He didn't like talking on video, or being recorded. Even though I said it was for the future, for his grandson, he wouldn't agree. He told me, "You record it and then explain it," so apart from a few photographs of meals or videos of celebrations, he hardly appears in the narration; I'm the one who plays him.

Your grandfather was born in Ma'y Tab in 1950, six years after his brother Jacinto. He lived with your great-grandfather in the village for ten years, until Jacinto married your aunt Lencha. Then your great-grandfather went to the ranch in Puerto Morelos and left your grandfather with Jacinto and Lencha, who had married very young and never had children. No one knows why he stayed in Ma'y Tab and attended the village primary school. He started late because, unlike Jacinto, who wasn't interested in school, he was very good at two things: Spanish and arithmetic, as he performed basic calculations naturally.

At 14, he left the village because he had deep concerns. He once told me, "There was an inner strength that told me to go see the world, not to stay here." So, he went to Nuevo Yucatán, when it was already a huge sawmill founded by a man from Yucatán who, it was said, was a distant relative of the woman who later became his wife. There he met her—she was a mestiza with light eyes, like me—and fell in love with her, but he had nothing to offer her, so he waited. He went to work on the highway from Mérida to Puerto Juárez, and that's where he learned masonry, doing all kinds of work. He worked for four years, saving whatever he could.

At 20, he returned to Nuevo Yucatán, married my mother, and they went to live in Ma'y Tab. It was 1970. I was born in 1971, and my mother died in childbirth, a sudden and premature death at seven and a half months. My father wasn't in Ma'y Tab because he had gone to Puerto Morelos on horseback to take care of some business and see his father. Uncle Jacinto called the midwife, and together they took me in, but they couldn't prevent my mother from bleeding to death. My father never said anything, but many years later he told me: "I've never forgiven myself for not being by your mother's side when she died." I replied: "But I was seven months old, Dad, and even if you had been there, you wouldn't have been able to do anything." He said, "I know, I know, daughter, but what do you want? I've never forgiven myself, and I couldn't tell her how much I adored her. She's just like you, 'my girl,'" which is what he called me when he was feeling sentimental, and that's why I could tell, because he had a hard, expressionless face and the same cold, penetrating gaze as all the Chis.

That same day, Aunt Chepita had lost her baby, a girl, in a difficult birth, but she was perfectly fine, and Uncle Jacinto brought her into the house as a wet nurse. She turned out to be wonderful because, besides being extremely affectionate, she considered me her daughter and breastfed me for two years. Uncle Jacinto overfed her so I could eat well. She stayed to live with us because she had been a failed single mother, and she helped Uncle Jacinto and Aunt Lencha raise me.

My father had built a spacious house in the village with high ceilings, with a beautiful palapa, which, along with Jacinto, his godfather and my godfather, the palapa maker Isauro Kan Choc, had built. He later built all the palapas my father built, as well as those of many other architects and engineers. They had met in Nuevo Yucatán a month after my mother's death.

For almost 12 years, my father would leave on Mondays at 5:00 a.m., since there was no gap near the town, and return on Saturdays at 8:00 p.m. He would kiss me and cuddle me and go to "the store" with his friends from the town to listen to the radio, and later, when the electricity came on in 1976, to watch television. He would spend the whole day with me on Sundays. He taught me to swim in the cenote, to ride a horse, to climb trees, to walk carefully in the jungle, and to look out—he called it spying. to large animals like deer and wild boar. On two occasions I saw him tense, and I spotted a kind of large cat. He stood in expectation; on both occasions he placed himself between

The cat and I, machete in hand. Later, he would explain that that was the jaguar, and that it was the reason I should never be alone, either at the edge or deep in the jungle.

During school breaks, my dad would take me to the ranch and teach me how to swim in the ocean and milk cows. We would drink coconut water; he was happy, like his father, and sometimes we would take Uncle Jacinto along. We always went with Uncle Juan, who from that point on was my dad's driver and assistant. He spoke Spanish very well, and my father said he was excellent at doing construction work. He almost never took me to Cancún, but he did take me to Akumal with his friend, and to swim in the cenote and the Xcaret cove with my namesake Juan. His children were very good people and swam with us in the cenote. But my dad never left my side, not even a meter away, no matter where we were.

In 1972, at Maleno's recommendation, I had begun working with a young man who wasn't an engineer, but whom the owner of Akumal, Don Juan, a tall, plump gentleman, trusted a lot. There, he eventually trained as a teacher, building what they called bungalows and a large palapa, which was a restaurant built by his friend Isauro. He told me years later that there he met "the group," as he called them, a group of young architects and engineers who had come to live in the area at the invitation of the oldest of the three brothers in the group and who knew the owner of Akumal. Years later, he told me that "the engineer," his friend, as he called him for years until his death, had told him that the true promoters of tourism in the region had been the owners of Akumal and Bacalar, bankers who had influenced the birth of Cancún.

My dad boasted that he had built the first hotel rooms on the coast, which were the Akumal bungalows.

From 1974 to 1982, he built schools with the group, but he also built one of the first hotels in Cancún. It belonged to a very knowledgeable engineer who had a family he liked. He had a yacht that he invited him to ride on one day, and he also rode around in a small truck they called *the Chupibús* (the "*Chupibús*"), because the engineer was a good drinker. That year, 1982, he took me to live in the house in Cancún. It was a huge piece of land on the highway from Cancún to the airport, where he said he had built a house for me. It had a huge garden with animals, chickens and turkeys, two beautiful dogs, and Uncle Juan had a house at the entrance. During all the years I lived in that house, from the age of 12 until I got married in 1996, Uncle Juan never went out at night if I was home. He told me he was the caretaker of a treasure that he would tell me what it was when I grew up.

While I was studying primary school in the town, during the holidays we spent at the ranch, Aunt Mercedes would come with us. Everyone called her Meche. She was a teacher at a school in Cancun called "El Británico" which belonged to an enthusiastic couple.

She was a teacher and he was an architect, whom the "bearded architect" (as he called him) of the group had helped build, and my father had been the construction foreman. He would laughingly comment that they might as well not charge him tuition, since he hadn't earned anything on the first classroom they built. The "bearded architect" would smilingly respond: "You, teacher, built the first hotel room in the Riviera Maya, now you're building the first private school classroom," since he had already worked in public schools. Aunt Meche, at the ranch, during her vacations, taught me many of the things I studied in school and helped me advance in my studies, because when I entered secondary school at the Británico, I was well prepared. I was always first in my class, in the town, and then at the Británico, and later in all my studies.

The more work my father did, the more friends and acquaintances he brought from all over. He brought people who didn't speak Spanish and settled them in the Puerto Juárez neighborhood, where he set up camp for them. He assigned a teacher to teach them Spanish. All the master carpenters, blacksmiths, bricklayers, and floor and tile setters used them as laborers because they spoke Mayan like them. But my father forced them to learn the trade, and when they grumbled, he always remembered the name of the journeyman who had taught the one who was grumbling and said, "In gratitude to him, you must always have an apprentice to teach, at least as long as you work with me." His boys, as he called them, adored my father and were willing to do anything for him. On more than one occasion, he had to signal to stop one of them when some engineer, architect, or owner got angry with my father and raised his voice. His boys would give their lives for him. But my father was patient; He once told me: "Look, daughter, I often have to teach engineers and architects, and construction managers, how things are done."

When I moved into my dad's house in Cancún, Aunt Meche, as we called her, was already settled there. She had a small but beautiful bungalow next to the house. She was a widow and had no children. She arrived in Cancún very poor, seeking her fortune. She was a teacher, and my father, who knew her, introduced her to the owner of the school he had built. Aunt Meche and the school owner became great friends; she lived in a small house run by Infonavit until she moved to the ranch to take care of me. We became inseparable friends. She greatly admired my father and called him "Don Juan" all her life. She said he was the most intelligent, honorable, serious, and kind man she had ever met. She saw him as a father, even though he was only eight years older than me.

Since my arrival in Cancún, my dad and my life changed radically. He came home to sleep every night, and only went out with his friends on Saturday nights, when we weren't going to the ranch for the weekend. Uncle Juan, my dad, Meche, and I always spent Sundays together. He took us to Isla Mujeres, to eat at Cancún's restaurants, to the movies, and to the shopping malls, and he allowed me to go with Aunt Meche to my school friends' parties. Whenever we went out to eat, I ran into lots of friends my age, and my Aunt Meche even more, since she knew all the kids' mothers in Cancún.

Cancún was very small; we all knew each other. Some businessmen knew my dad and greeted him happily, although some women were surprised when I introduced them. One day, sitting on the ranch's terrace, I asked my dad why some friends and women were surprised when I introduced him and Uncle Juan. I was probably 14, and we were planning a 15th birthday party at the ranch. He told me: "My daughter, it's very important that you understand

that not everyone believes or thinks that human beings are all the same, and those who don't believe this try to differentiate themselves by race, money, or any other reason. For people, especially the most ignorant and frustrated, for various reasons, feeling superior to others makes them feel better. People of our race, the Indians, have been subjected to inferiority for centuries and have always been considered that way. You are a mestiza with light eyes, like your mother, and that's why you don't feel it. Besides, you're very pretty, and Aunt Meche has taught you to dress well, that's why you don't feel anything, but when you're with me and Uncle Juan, who are, as they say, 'patarrajada Indians,' then things change. They can't understand how such a beautiful young lady could be the daughter of a pure-blood Mayan Indian."

I've never had a problem with that. I know the proud history of my race, and I am the son of a leader of that race, who earned his position with courage, effort, and struggle, just as I have earned mine. I owe nothing to anyone, and no one owes me anything, so I'm not affected by those who look down on me or those who look up to me. I know who I am, I know where I come from, I know where I am, I know where I want to go, and I hope you know that perfectly well, too.

I don't know why, but from that date on I never worried about "what people would say" again. When I mentioned this to Aunt Meche, she said, "Oh, dear, you don't know what I would have given to have a father like yours. Mine thought he was a god, and that ruined the lives of the whole family, including mine. Sometimes I think that if it weren't for your father, I wouldn't know where I would be."

From that year until 1992, he said he'd had the best run of his life. He joined a new group, one his engineer friend's group had formed with friends from Mexico and a Turk (that's what the Yucatecans called the Lebanese) and worked like never before for eight years straight. He eventually had crews of up to 600 men, 90% from the towns of Yucatán, and some teachers and officials from elsewhere. He worked from 6 in the morning until 6, 7, or 8 at night. He said that on Fridays, between piecework and work schedules, he barely slept. On Saturdays, he'd come home early, have a few drinks—sometimes at home, sometimes in the neighborhood with his friends—go to bed early, and sleep for more than nine hours straight. My father said that sleeping more than six hours was a waste of time. He had tireless energy; That was the stage in which he began buying those three-story apartment buildings, of which he ended up having 20, because for ten years he bought one every six months. For some reason he liked them, and he said that a Yucatecan built them.

that he was a hard worker, that they got to know each other and that they had sympathy between them and did not pressure him when for some reason he could not buy the building. semester.

He told me a lot about the engineers he worked with; he told me about the little guy he used to build some houses where they welded walls and roofs together and then assembled them. These were the first houses he built like that, and then he built a very large condominium with the short engineer, his friend the engineer, and the Turk, as he called the "arqui with the beard." He then worked with an engineer who said he was the kindest, most honest, and hardest-working person he had ever met, and who got along very well with the Turk.

He told me they were finishing a large hotel in 1988 when Hurricane *Gilberto* hit. He was at home during the storm, didn't let me out the next day, and my uncle Juan stayed to look after us. My father ordered no one to leave and went in the truck to see the construction. When he returned at night, he told us that all of Cancún was a disaster, with fallen poles and trees, and that the police weren't letting anyone in. He had managed to get through because the commander was a friend who knew his father and had let him in. He was traveling on Kukulcán Boulevard between trees, glass, aluminum windows, and fallen palm trees, but he arrived at the hotel, where the deputy director and the director were already there. They mostly organized surveillance; he said he hadn't seen any hotels or buildings that had fallen down, but that they all had a lot of broken glass.

That night, Uncle Juan and I organized the well in the garden for water, since the power had gone out and the pump wasn't working. A crew of laborers, two of whom were from the village and whom I knew, settled in the house. They spent the whole week cleaning up fallen branches and other debris. My Uncle Juan had bought a lot of food, candles, and oil lamps, which I hadn't seen since the village, and we put hammocks on the terrace, since the air conditioning wasn't working.

The next morning, all the architects and engineers were there, and the director and the engineer, his friend, gathered everyone who had arrived, whether they were masters, workers, or laborers, and told them they had to clean everything first. The cyclone had taken out the entire lobby, tearing out all the screens and destroying the furniture, but the room windows held up, and there was very little damage. He told me that the first two hotels they had built suffered little damage. He had people cleaning up the damage, patching, and gardening. That week I saw little of him, as he arrived very late and left very early. He worked 16 hours a day. But oddly enough, he didn't seem tired; he loved challenges and effort.

On the third day, Uncle Juan, who had been watching us all week, took us around the city. Everything was a mess: there were tons of downed power lines and more trees, branches, and glass everywhere. There were lots of downed signs, but no buildings had fallen down. Just as my dad had everyone cleaning the hotels and helping clear the boulevard, the whole city was working on cleaning not only their own homes but also the streets. There was a kind of festive energy; everyone was helping out.

Everyone; there was no water or electricity, but people shared food with each other; neighbors helped each other. And in the afternoon, we noticed people sitting on the sidewalks in chairs they'd brought from their homes, like in my town, because it was hot inside. In the houses, except for a few that were flooded, there hadn't been any serious damage. The biggest problem was water, and although the government provided trucks to distribute it, there wasn't enough water for bathing or toilets, and the sewage system didn't work, which was a problem everyone solved as best they could. Never had such support and solidarity been seen among the people.

My father used to say that the true heroes of the tragedy were the Federal Electricity Commission, who had sent crews and equipment from Mérida, Villahermosa, Chetumal, and Tuxtla Gutiérrez. The line that ran along Colosio Avenue from the airport to Cancún had been built in three days; it was very impressive. He said that at one of the hotels, two days after the cyclone, tourists who had taken refuge in the city had arrived, and since they had emergency power plants and large water tanks, the elevators worked, the refrigerators, one or two elevators, and some lights. They gave them lamps and said they were happy, that they considered it an adventure. On the third day of the cyclone, a genius produced some T-shirts that said "I survived Gilberto," and at one hotel, they put up a sign that said "1-0," as if they had scored a goal against Cancún.

Within a week, we all had on "I survived Gilberto" T-shirts, and the electricity, which reached the tourist area first, gradually spread throughout the city. In Cancún, no one died, and it was said that the only deaths were those from a fishing boat that broke loose and sank off Punta Sam, where the captain and sailors drowned. For years, the top of the sunken ship could still be seen, and people would visit the site. Another Cuban boat broke loose off Isla Mujeres and dragged its anchor until it ended up on the beach, almost on top of a house in one of my father's projects. He said that when he went to see it, the owners of the houses, who were a very nice couple, were already friends of the Cubans, and since the boat was a fish freezer, they had managed to get it donated to the people of Cancún. My father, like many others who had vehicles, brought 30 tons of fish to the Puerto Juárez neighborhood and the city. There was another boat on the island with 20 tons, also donated by the Cubans, so there were 50,000 kilos of fish, which helped a lot while the supply was being established, which was very fast, as the trucks with supplies began arriving three days after the cyclone. The problem was the electricity, as the food couldn't be refrigerated. The neighbor who somehow managed to get ice would share it with friends for a strong drink.

We spent eight or nine days on the terrace of the house, where we talked about what had happened. My dad said to me: "Look, honey, if we all behaved like we did this week, the world would be a different place."

My aunt Meche was helping her friends, bringing them water from our well and getting a tanker truck that she filled at home and distributed to her friends' cisterns and buckets, and she told us many anecdotes about how everyone helped.

The hardest part was the departure of the tourists, as they all went home. A few disoriented and adventurous people came to see what was happening. It was difficult, but by December, the hotels that were ready were already receiving guests. My father was happy because the hotel he built, whose *lobby was destroyed by the cyclone*, had opened in December. He told me that nothing had happened to the first hotel he had built—he called it “the little one”—but since the cyclone blew the sand from the beach, the waves began to hit the wall and unnailed its foundation, and one night, fortunately, the wall fell into the sea. The pool, which was made of concrete, didn't fall. The hotel had tourists, and once again my father and his staff worked day and night to fix it. He said that the engineer who was overseeing the work—who was very serious and bad-tempered, but very good-natured—one day the earth slipped and almost buried him, and that he helped pull him out and nothing happened to him, and they ended up getting along, because despite being bad-tempered, he was a good engineer and a good person with the workers.

After that, he built another hotel, which he said was one of the first *all-inclusive hotels* in Cancún. Around that time, my dad attended a Coparmex dinner, because his friend had invited him, along with other project engineers. During that time, many hotel rooms were opened, and Cancún went from 3,000 to 8,000 rooms, and many people were angry.

The engineer told him: “Come on, Don Juan, you're going to get better.”

The engineer spoke at the meal and said that Cancún had been built not for a small group of citizens to live in paradise, as was often said, but to generate jobs that were urgently needed in Mexico, and particularly on the peninsula, since the shift from henequen to synthetic fibers had led to widespread unemployment and poverty. He said the 8,000 rooms that already existed were 80% occupied, and he believed that by 2020 there could be 100,000 hotel rooms. It was a scandal; environmentalists said it would destroy Cancún, and people who wanted to keep Cancún small were angry; there were even hoteliers who didn't want any more rooms because they wouldn't keep their hotels full.

After that, another project came along with the architect from Xcaret; they called it “the museum.” He was the architect who didn't like drawing plans and said he did architecture “on arrival.” By the way, he had two masters who my dad said were geniuses at making holes, tunnels, and strange walls. The “architect on arrival,” who walked around the construction site and the park all day long, picking up trash with his hands, would see them two or three times a day and give them instructions on arrival, and everything ended up the way he wanted and it looked wonderful.

After that, he worked on several hotels and construction projects with some architects, in particular with one he called “el Güero,” and he said he was always cheerful and smiling and that he had a short engineer who was very good at construction projects.

By then, I had already finished high school and was studying computer science; those were the years I enjoyed my dad the most.

He continued to do very well; he continued buying buildings and renting them out, and he had built many small commercial spaces; he built them in groups of three or four and rented them out to small businesses, workshops, shoe stores, shops, etc.

One day, he caught my attention because he said he was going to see something and someone. Uncle Juan was driving. He told me he was already of age and that I should see something, and we went to see all the buildings and commercial premises, as well as a small office building on Náder Avenue, near the Holiday Inn. We got out, and he said, "This little building is mine too," and then he introduced me to Pedro Chan Chi. The name struck me as odd, and my father said, "He's your cousin, the son of a first cousin of your grandfather, who studied accounting in Mérida. He's my accountant and manager of everything you saw today. He collects the rents and pays all the property taxes, and mine too. He oversees the accountants who pay all the benefits for the construction workers, and he's also bought his buildings; he has four now. He's my right-hand man, and if anything happens to me, you'll have to see him for everything. Your uncle Juan also knows everything. Everything you see, including the house and the ranch, is in my name." He took a document out of a precious leather briefcase and handed it to me, saying, "This is my will. I leave everything to you, to be your inheritance." "And you don't leave my uncle Juan anything?" I asked.

To which my uncle Juan replied: "My child, you are my heritage. We have nothing, we have no children. All I ask is that if anything happens to us, take care of your aunts or take care of us when we're old." Tears started to my eyes. I hugged him and said: "All your life long, you only have to ask for whatever you want." My father smiled and said: "That's my daughter."

From that day on, I saw Pedro, his wife, and their two little twins, a girl and a boy, more often. They were curious, since she was more of a mestiza (mixed-race) girl and the boy was a "pa-tarrajada" Indian, as my father used to say.

Two or three years later, I graduated and started dating Rubén, your father. I was worried because I didn't know how my dad would take it. My aunt Meche helped me a lot with that. She knew Rubén's parents very well because they were teachers, and his mother was a volunteer with the Red Cross and also with the Gilberto Foundation, which had been founded after the hurricane, and with the Cancún Pioneers. My aunt was involved in everything and had known Rubén since he was a child, saying he was the most studious and good boy she had ever known. He was an only child.

The day Aunt Meche prepared a meal to introduce Rubén to my dad, I was very nervous. Aunt Meche had already given my dad all the information about Rubén, but I was apprehensive.

But it was all a big surprise. At the end of the meal, Rubén said to my father, "Sir, I want to tell you that I know a lot about your father," and my father, curious, fixed his penetrating gaze on Rubén and asked, "Why is that?" And Rubén calmly said, "Because, Don Juan, I wrote my sociology thesis on the caste war in Yucatán."

And from that moment on, a conversation began that lasted all afternoon. I was surprised by how much they both knew about that time, not just about the peninsula, but about Mexico. I had never heard my father speak with such knowledge of Mexican history. It's true that I saw that my father always read for an hour, and many Sundays after returning from lunch, my aunt and I would watch television while he read. It's incredible that until I was in my twenties, I was still aware of my father's culture. I knew of his love for Mexico, and he would occasionally throw out facts and dates that surprised me, but I never imagined he had so much knowledge. That night, my aunt Meche told me: "Your father will never cease to amaze me." And at that moment, my aunt and I realized how reserved he was. He always spoke to me as if I were a child; it was as if he hadn't seen me grow up. Those were also times when parents didn't talk much to their children, especially their daughters.

When Rubén left, I asked him, "Dad, I was very nervous. What did you think?" He said, "My daughter, there's no doubt your Aunt Meche was right. He's a good boy and very intelligent; he knows what he's talking about. I'm just worried that he's very idealistic, like all good young people, and I don't like him saying so many bad things about our rulers. He might get into trouble. You'll have to watch him closely." And then he said to me: "But why were you nervous? I'm happy. I was already worried that you wouldn't have a boyfriend at your age. Your mother and I got married when we were 20, and you're already 25. I know you're going to get married, and I think it's with this guy, and not only am I not worried, I'm glad, because anyone who goes against the laws of life is wrong. Parents have children so they can live their own lives. I left home at 14 to live my own life. You were late," and he gave me a tender kiss on the cheek. "May you be very happy, my daughter."

He, as always, was right. Shortly after, we were getting married, and my father organized a big wedding for us at the ranch. It was attended by people from Chetumal, from Rubén's family, from Mérida, from the town, and from Cancún, and there was another huge surprise. At the end of the wedding, he took us aside and said:

"Rubén and Alicia, you told me you wanted to do a master's degree and a postgraduate degree. I know you teach at the University of Quintana Roo, which Alicia knows is my favorite, since I built the first part of it, and you expressed your concern about leaving classes to pursue your master's and doctorate degrees. I spoke with the rector, who is an acquaintance of mine, since I was part of the first board of trustees, as I was the construction foreman, but I also donated all the library furniture and the first collection of books—something he'd never told me—and I explained your wishes. He told me not to worry, that on the contrary, he loved the idea, since he wanted the quality of his teachers to be the highest; he's a great person.

So I did some research on how much those master's degrees might cost at some university in Boston. They both speak English perfectly, so it's not a problem," and he gave us an envelope with a bow that my Aunt Meche had probably made. We opened it, and to our surprise: my dad gave us two checks, one for \$400, which was the cost of Rubén's master's and doctorate degrees in sociology at Harvard, and one for cybernetics.

for me, and another for \$240,000 which he said was for living expenses, at \$10,000 a month, which he had figured out would be enough.

Rubén and I couldn't believe it. He was giving us \$640,000 for our studies, a fortune I hadn't even imagined. Rubén didn't say anything; tears just trickled down his face. My father noticed and said, "Rubén, don't say anything." To end the conversation, he jokingly said, "Don't think I've used up all my savings with that!"

As Aunt Meche used to say, my father would never cease to amaze us. I said to him, "Thank you, Dad. I hope you'll visit us several times," and he replied, "No, my daughter, I'll never get a passport to leave this country." He made a very strange face. He gave Rubén a big hug and said, "I really entrust her to you. Love her and take care of her for the rest of your life."

"I couldn't do the same with his mother," he kissed me, turned around, and left the room.

My uncle Juan took us to the airport, and I didn't see my dad for the next two years. During our honeymoon, we arranged everything, and at the Mexican consulate in Boston, we obtained student visas and began our studies.

I graduated and got married in 1996; I was abroad until 1999, and my son, whom we named Rubén after his father, was born on January 1, 2000. My father said that would have some important meaning, and my uncle Jacinto said that being born at the beginning of the century meant a long life like that of Jacinto, his father.

It was at the hospital where we were able to talk again. It all started because Rubén and I wanted the boy to grow up on the ranch, and I spoke with my dad about our desire to move there and that Rubén would drive from the ranch to Cancún; with the new road, it would take 40 minutes to get to the university. My dad was delighted; I couldn't have given him better news, and he began to tell me about the ranch. He told me that one day, the lawyer with whom he was working on the notarized deed for the ranch, since he only had the title deed given to him by the governor, introduced him to a very pretty and well-dressed lawyer and said, "Don Juan, I'll introduce you to Ms. Cristina; I believe she's the person who knows the most about ecology and environmental law in the Mexican Republic."

I've done some things with her, and while talking, I told her about the title I was managing for her, and she told me that next year there would be a review of the ecological planning program, and that if you weren't interested, that would be interesting.

My father told her that he didn't like environmental issues at all, as he had had a very difficult experience. The lawyer asked him what it was, and my father told her the story.

One day, the engineer, his friend, went to see him at the work he was doing and told him that the Association of Owners and Investors of the Riviera Maya was defending a pro-

Xcaceel and Xcaceelito project, on land that had been sold to them by the Xel-Há and Caribbean trust, since they were from Cozumel, and the trust had taken over land that the government had nationalized from the tall, blond man, owner of Akumal, which ran from Akumal to the Xel-Há cove. In exchange for issuing the deeds to the Akumal lands, the owner had been buying the possession rights from the several Mayan possessors for years, and he did not have all the titles, and since he feared that they would take everything away from him, he accepted.

So, "the Cozumeleños" had bought that land and wanted to build hotels. The project was very beautiful and had many advantages, as those beaches were home to a large number of turtle nesting sites, and they were leaving 100 meters of beach depth unbuilt so as not to disturb the nesting season. They also offered not to leave lounge chairs or anything else on the beaches during nesting season. They also promised to give a dollar per night for each guest's stay to help maintain the turtle research center. The project was going to be discussed at a sports center in Playa del Carmen, and he wanted to defend it because, in addition to complying with all the regulations, it offered the advantage of the beach and the research center.

The engineer, his friend, asked him to help him gather people to support the project, as it would mean hundreds of jobs during construction, and hundreds to operate the hotel.

My father was friends with the leaders of the two strongest construction unions, and together they convinced them and brought hundreds of workers to support the projects. They wore T-shirts that said "We Want Work" and filled the stands. My dad said he was surprised by the three tables in front: those of the environmentalists against the event, about 20 of whom were present, the authorities, and those who had conducted the studies. At the owners' table, there were only the engineer, his friend, the union leaders, and the architect, who was the president of the association.

The environmentalists spoke first, offering a thousand reasons why it shouldn't be done. They provided a respite from the leaders' and my doubts about everything they had said, since I knew the jungle much better than any of them and knew that since the four-lane Cancún-Tulum highway was built, all the land between the highway and the ocean had practically ceased to be virgin jungle, connected to the entire jungle behind it, and they spoke as if it were virgin jungle. They said the hotels blocked the wildlife corridors between the jungle and the ocean. I didn't understand a thing, because when the ranch didn't have fences, I never saw a jaguar, a deer, a pacas, or a wild boar walk to the beach to drink seawater. And they said that with the construction, the turtles would stop laying their eggs, which was a lie. On the ranch, the turtles laid their eggs in front of our houses, and the children even rode them while playing. We never removed an egg from the nest, and we protected them with chicken wire so dogs and opossums wouldn't eat them. It was a wonderful sight to see them emerge from the holes in the beach and run into the sea. The children scared away the seagulls that wanted to eat them. Everything they said seemed like a lie to me.

They gave us a lunch break; we had brought about a thousand cakes to give to the kids. That's why the environmentalists said they were being carted off, but we didn't force anyone. We explained to everyone that anyone could come; most agreed, and the Association paid for cakes and trucks. We asked them to be respectful and let everyone speak and listen.

My friend, the engineer, explained the following to me: "Don Juan, in my experience all these environmentalists are good people, with good intentions, but they give you very bad information. Some international organizations, run abroad, that don't want underdeveloped countries to progress, spend fortunes on television programs, videos, books, etc., to misinform millions of young people and people of good faith, whom they invite to "save the world." Many of them, whose lives aren't fulfilling, find their purpose in this mission and become fanatics, repeating and repeating what these **environmental** NGOs tell them. It's a very cheap form of informational colonization, because it stops highways, dams, roads, and hotels, which keep countries in the underdevelopment stage, and thus they have cheap labor. Why do you think Florida has hundreds of condominiums, hotels, houses, and golf courses on its coasts, and nothing has happened, and yet here we can't build a hotel on the beach because it's a fight with the environmentalists?

And he continued saying: "Look Don Juan, for me there are three categories of ecologists:

The first generation are fanatical people who believe there is no relationship between ecology and economics, so they attack any project that involves any modification to the environment, flora, or fauna of a place.

Second-generation environmentalists have come to perceive that there is a close relationship between energy, ecology, and human development, and are becoming a little more cautious when declaring themselves against any project.

Third-generation environmentalists have developed a clear awareness of the relationship between the economy and human development, who know how to analyze the cost-benefit ratio of any project, and who accept that some ecological damage can be mitigated or compensated for in different ways.

Unfortunately, in Cancún, first-generation environmentalists, along with some radical politicians and members of the press, systematically oppose any new development. Since each group has its own interests and municipal, state, and federal legislation is unhelpful, it's very difficult to overcome this situation.

The architect then spoke and explained the entire project, its advantages and offerings. That's when everyone we had brought applauded. The authorities didn't issue the ruling there; shortly after, we learned they had denied it. When I asked my engineer friend why the owners weren't present, he told me that the private sector was always divided and never appealed because they didn't want to get into trouble with the authorities.

Then Ms. Cristina told him that she knew the case perfectly and that was why she and the lawyer believed that he should, at the same time as obtaining his property deed,

Conduct all the environmental characterization studies and manage the correct density of rooms for their land in the upcoming Ecological and Territorial Planning Program that was going to be implemented. My father replied that he never planned to sell his land, and she added: "Don Juan, we're not eternal; the land must be left in good order for your future generations," and he agreed.

Cristina continued to go to the ranch with technicians who conducted studies, and the lawyer with surveyors who drew up plans. And something interesting happened: one day Cristina met her brother Jacinto, and a close friendship immediately developed. She was a naturalist and knew a lot about home remedies. She liked to chat with Jacinto, and she always carried a bundle of healing plants, which she used and gave away. Years later, when she died, my father and Jacinto felt deeply for her and attended the wake, where they greeted the engineer, their friend, who was very sad, and Aunt Meche, who was a good friend of Cristina's and knew almost everyone there.

Well, it turned out that, like a miracle, that beginning of the century had been wonderful. A few days earlier, they had given him the deed to his beloved ranch and all the approvals from the POET (Spanish House of Representatives), stating that the ranch could be built with 50 rooms per hectare. And then his grandson was born, who would be the heir to that property. Although I wanted to have more children, due to complications during childbirth, I couldn't. He would be the sole heir to that ranch.

Later, my father began a major project at Xcaret, a hotel built by two companies: one by the architect "El Guero" and the other by an engineer he already knew, which included several teachers he'd also known for years. He said the architect was the one supervising and that it was the cleanest and most orderly project he'd ever done. All the plans were perfect, and they took great care of nature. It didn't have a beach, so they built a beautiful inland beach instead. That project was finished perfectly on time; it cost exactly what they had anticipated, and it was inaugurated with a very nice party to which all the engineers and teachers involved were invited.

After that project, my father continued building buildings and hotels for various owners and engineers. He did one project with the architect, a building on the highway from Puerto Juárez to Punta Sam. It was a very beautiful project, but he later learned that the architect's project had gone very poorly because the owner didn't want to pay him what he had promised and never did. The architect was having bad luck at the time, because they later built another beautiful building, which he built with the white architect, and he supervised. However, the owner, a Spaniard, also owed money to both of them and many other suppliers. He continued working with the architect on some buildings on the beach in Puerto Juárez. Everything went well there, but since they were finished in 2008, it was very difficult to sell because of the crisis at the time.

Afterwards, my father spent part-time at the ranch, since there was very little construction work. My father had to help many of his fellow construction workers who weren't doing well. During that time, he worked with the brother of his friend, the engineer of Akumal, as he called him.

He was the friend of his friend, the one from the restaurant in Akumal. He did various odd jobs for him, he said, at some schools the engineer ran in Akumal town and Puerto Aventuras town, for children who had dropped out of school, where they finished primary and secondary school, and for older children who hadn't studied, and for women who taught them things, and no one charged him.

It was very beautiful and there were people he had met. One day the engineer took him to Chemuyil, which he thought was the most beautiful Mayan village in the region, and the engineer explained that Xel-Há sponsored programs there and showed them to him. My father decided to do the same with his village, and since there was little work, he went to the town a lot to build the plaza, the community center, and other things.

With the crisis, he had little work to do. He told me he was saving money to cover expenses and to be able to provide some work for people, which was his main concern. It was during that time that he had an accident in which he hurt his leg, making it very difficult for him to work, as it hurt when he walked and climbed scaffolding. He only allowed Uncle Jacinto to look after him.

Then came the year 2012. My dad said that never before had so much nonsense been said about the Maya as in that era. Uncle Jacinto was dying of laughter at everything that was being said; he knew perfectly well that it was all lies, because the reality was that there had simply been a Katun shift, he said, which was very important, since it was an era of about 5,200 years, but nothing more.

My dad went to the inauguration of a monument that he had helped the bearded arch make, who was enthusiastic about the monument, and he says it was important for two reasons: he was sitting with the engineer, his friend, and since the governor arrived two hours late to the inauguration, as he occasionally did at events to which he was invited, he had the opportunity to talk at length with the engineer, his friend, who asked him what he thought of the monument.

He replied that he liked it a lot, but that he thought it was too much of a scandal, like the one that had been caused by the turn of the millennium in the year 2000. The engineer, his friend, told him that he agreed, but that he attached a lot of importance to it because for him what this monument represented, apart from the change of the Katun, was that in Cancún and the Riviera Maya the most important change in the history of the Maya had taken place since the conquest and the caste war, and that finally the Maya had been incorporated into modern Mexico, that they had ended their isolation and centuries of exploitation by conquerors and landowners, that they had water, electricity, sewage and good communication, television, etc., and above all work, which for him was the only true social justice.

That without work there is no dignity, only marginalization and poverty. And then she told him something that moved him deeply:

"Don Juan, you are the clearest example of what I've told you. You and your daughter represent the new world and the evolution of the ancient Mayan culture. I have never believed in Mexican indigenists who preach the preservation of the customs and traditions of indigenous peoples, and by doing so, what they seek is to keep the indigenous people in their ignorance.

I believe that it is time for the indigenous people to be Mexican, like all of us, like

You are today, but I also see in this monument a tribute that my brother pays to you, to all the Mayan peoples of the peninsula, because I believe you are the true heroes of the creation of Cancún. You more than anyone know how hard the construction is; the conditions in which all the workers live, far from their families, toiling in hellish heat under the rays of the sun. That is the price we pay so that your children stop being indigenous and finally become Mexicans, because you are the first Mexicans in Mexico, who were taken from you during the conquest by Spaniards, most of whom were ignorant and despotic, and then government after government, who, with the lie of indigenismo, did not build roads for you, did not provide you with electricity or water, they only gave you excuses.

"It was thanks to that president, Tata Cárdenas, who, apart from giving them land, gave them some dignity with rural schools, and those teachers, true heroes of Mexico, taught them to speak Spanish just in the last century. There are still many who don't speak it. How can there be Mexican identity if they can't even communicate with their peers? They want to keep them speaking Mayan. Forgive me for saying this, they want to think they're not Mexican, because in Mexico, whether we like it or not, Spanish is spoken. How many of you have suffered injustices and even imprisonment in courts where only Spanish is spoken?

"Don Juan, I remember that when I met you, you used to bring 'ropes' of your countrymen, who didn't speak Spanish, to work on construction sites, and that was just a few years ago. When the archbishop arrived, as you call him, he told him: 'I love Mayan,' and he built a building to house a center for the study of Mayan epigraphy, which helped decipher the history of his people. But one thing is one thing and another is another. The Mayan language is now a language of the past; no one in the world speaks it except the Mayans; it's a language in which they cannot speak to the world. You speak it perfectly, don Juan, but you can only do so with your friends and in the village. Modern times are times of globalization; today everyone communicates with everyone else, and to do so, you have to learn languages, like your daughter, who speaks Mayan with pride, but also Spanish and English. For me, she is what this monument reflects. This monument should remind you of your daughter, and all those who, with their efforts, made Cancún. For me, don Juan, that's what it means."

My father told me that after hearing that, he had to stand up and secretly hide his tears. He believed no one would ever understand what he had done, and he wished his beloved Alicia had heard what he had just heard. When he told me about it, it was the only time in our lives that we cried together, holding each other.

Rubén and María Teresa also shed tears, because ultimately, the work they wanted to do was a reflection of that way of thinking. They wanted to bring the depth of universal knowledge of the BMD to the people of the villages, who, for so many historical reasons of technological and social disadvantage, and above all, ignorance, maintained the villages as the Mayan villages of the Yucatán Peninsula had been preserved until then.

From that date on, every day as they traveled the road from the ranch to Cancún, they would stop for a minute at the monument to remember those who had created the opportunity to end centuries of oppression and ignorance of the Mayan people of the Yucatán Peninsula. Alice continued:

After the inauguration of the monument in 2012, a very strange and different period began for my father. In early 2013, while I was at the ranch, the lawyer who had obtained the title for him arrived, and as the three of us sat down, he said:

"Don Juan, I have some very bad news for you. While I was at the courthouse, a court clerk, the son of one of your friends whose name I don't remember, approached me and very quietly handed me an envelope. Already in the car, I opened the envelope and realized it was a complaint from someone claiming to have been in possession of his ranch before your father. I remind you that the title the governor gave your father was based on the fact that he himself had been in possession for more than 10 years, but it didn't give the date of possession; that was 1974, which means your father had been in possession since 1964."

"But lawyer," my father interrupted him, "my father was a possessor since 1924, and you know it."

"Of course," said the lawyer, "of course I know, but let me explain what's going on, Don Juan. A group of state officials, with the consent of their superiors and an undersecretary of Agrarian Reform, have been dispossessing landowners and hotels in Tulum using two methods. One involves fabricating a group of workers who supposedly worked at the hotel, for example, and who were unjustly fired. They file a labor lawsuit. They don't notify the owner during the trial, since they are authorities from the Ministry of Labor and the Board of Conciliation and Arbitration, along with a labor judge, who are in collusion. When the trial ends, without having notified the owner, or with false notifications ignored, the property is supposedly auctioned off and awarded to the plaintiff. It's all false, but in theory it's legal, and that's how the owner is dispossessed."

He took a sip of strong coffee and continued:

"This isn't your case; I just gave it to you as an example. The other method of dispossession is the one they're trying on you, which is fictitious possession. In collusion with the Secretariat, they register a false possessor with a date prior to that of the real possessor. They entered the 1954 date in very old agrarian records, perhaps because there was a gap there, some record that allowed for it to be recorded, and then that possessor initiated a lawsuit to reclaim his property. I assume they were following a method similar to that of the false employees, but they didn't count on the loyalty of that employee, who gave me that copy to warn you."

My father interrupted him again: "Tell me your name, sir, to show you my eternal gratitude."

And the lawyer calmly replied: "Don Juan, I really don't remember your name right now, but of course we will know it in due time and you will be able to show your appreciation."

decision. I come to request your approval to begin the defense procedure.

"I still don't know how, because until you are notified, I can't present any arguments or evidence, and it's obvious that notification won't arrive. But I'll see how, and for now, we can count on the loyalty of the court clerk who gave me the copy."

My father told him, "Lawyer, you have all the resources you need to do this." The lawyer left, and my father sat on the terrace without saying anything. I knew there were times when my father didn't want to talk to anyone. That night, he skipped dinner and sat in his chair without sleeping all night.

From that moment on, two very important things happened: my father, always serious but cheerful, became more stern and thoughtful, and a closer relationship was established with my son Rubén, for from time to time he would come into the study and ask him to put on the monitor certain articles of the Mexican Constitution, or certain articles of the Agrarian Code, or matters of legal procedure. He had the copies the lawyer gave him, and he would ask Rubén to locate each article mentioned in them, and he would study and analyze them, and sometimes he would call the lawyer to discuss them with him and give him his points of view. On more than one occasion, the lawyer agreed with him on some observation, and he also allowed him to know how and in what way Rubén studied, for he had viewed that "cosmic classroom," as he called Rubén's study, with great respect. I noticed that there was a closer relationship between them, despite the fact that it had always been very strong.

In 2015, some statistics were published by a journalist who had caused a sensation in Mexico for accusing a businessman from Cancún, a governor, and others of being pedophiles. She proved it, and they all ended up in jail. That journalist published an article accusing several officials of committing these acts of theft and described the methods they used, exactly as the lawyer had told my father.

And then one day the lawyer came to see us and told us that the governor had managed to get the local congress to accept and pass some anti-corruption laws, within which he appointed an anti-corruption prosecutor who would protect him from any accusations and would also appoint bodyguards for 15 years to protect him. The method and the confession were clear and explicit in everything that happened, and we all understood it that way, but the problem didn't end.

One day, the lawyer arrived, a little nervous, and said to my father: "Don Juan, there's going to be a hearing of very important witnesses, since it's the presentation of evidence. The accuser is going to present the apocryphal papers proving his possession from the Agrarian Reform. Since we don't have any papers from that period, other than the title, I want to present witnesses who certify that your father was a possessor since 1924."

On the day of the hearing the lawyer got a hell of a scare, because he arrived-

There were no fewer than 20 elders who wanted to testify that they had been with my father at the ranch. One of them, about 100 years old, said he had been at the ranch as a child in that same year, 1924, and that he remembered the great General Jacinto Chi. Another 50 from my father's town testified to having visited him from 1935 until his death. One said that General Jacinto Chi had never left, as he was still buried there. The judge, who was known for her corrupt rulings, was so scared that she officially postponed the hearing to February 3, 2018. That had saved everything, because after the governor's departure, all the claimant lawyers and officials disappeared and abandoned their claims.

In 2016, in the midst of a lawsuit, one day the lawyer showed up with a younger, very well-dressed colleague, whom my father said was the kindest, most personable, and polite lawyer he had ever met, and who had great patience in explaining his business. The lawyer told him that the younger lawyer was a specialist in family trusts and that they wanted to explain what it was all about. The younger lawyer said: "I know, Don Juan, that you don't have any will problems, since your daughter is your sole heir,
but you've told me that you're worried about your brother and all your friends who live on the ranch."

My dad interrupted him: "Look, sir, it's true that I'm worried about them, but I already told my daughter to take care of them and I'm sure she will."

To which the lawyer replied: "I know, Don Juan, the lawyer told me so too, but this will be an instrument that will help your daughter do her best," and he explained:

"This document has four clauses. The first is that a trust will be established in which you will be the settlor, a bank will be the trustee, and your daughter will be the beneficiary."

The lawyer interrupted and explained to my father what each of those terms meant: the trustor is the one who gives the property; the fiduciary is the holder of the property; and the beneficiary is the one who has all the rights to the property, the one who will receive the usufruct of it.

The young lawyer continued:

"The second is that neither the property nor the usufruct may be sold during the 99 years that the trust lasts and that no foreign or Mexican company will be able to buy it."

"I love that clause," my dad commented.

The young lawyer continued: "The

third is that the trustees will only be able to inherit the property to direct descendants of their family."

And finally, the fourth clause stipulated that in the event there were no direct descendants, the trustee rights would pass to the families, children and grandchildren of his first cousins who lived with him on the ranch and who would also be trustees for 10% of the property to be distributed.

My father immediately authorized it and asked what his fees were and if the bank he knew could act as trustee; the lawyer agreed, and everything went smoothly.

The famous phantom possessor trial was resolved in my father's favor at the end of 2017, and one day he invited Rubén, me, the five compadres, my uncles Jacinto and Juan, and the two lawyers over. He had a brown leather briefcase from which he took out four documents.

"I hand over to you in the presence of all your uncles the following documents:

My will, in which you are heir to all my properties, the title of possession and the notarial deed of the ranch and finally the trust."

And he said to everyone: "In this way, everyone present will benefit from something you have helped me create, and so will our children's children." Everyone applauded with tears in their eyes.

From that day on, my father never worked again. He dedicated himself to visiting the towns where there were people he had taken to Cancún. He talked a lot with Uncle Juan, Uncle Jacinto, and his cousins, friends from the ranch. He told Rubén about his time as a child in the town and about adventures with jaguars and vipers that he had never talked about.

In early 2018, he fell asleep one day and never woke up again. His face looked so happy and content. We buried him next to his father's grave. At his funeral, the ranch was filled with compadres, townspeople, and people who had worked with him. Uncle Juan told us that one day, shortly before he died, he had told him that he didn't want anyone who wasn't of Mayan origin to be invited, except for the engineer, his friend, and the lawyer who had saved his ranch, but that they should come alone, and so it was. My uncle Juan had a hard time organizing transportation for all the visitors, although he had sent trucks to pick them up, and my aunt Meche, the comadres, and I took charge of feeding everyone who came.

Everyone said that my father had been an exemplary Mayan and a great Mexican, and we believe that is the case.

After finishing the story with photographs and videos that his mother had made, Rubén told Tere:

After —Tomorrow I want to surprise you. I want you to pack a bag, because I'm going to take you to visit the most beautiful hotel in the Riviera Maya and the Destination Xcaret parks. We'll be there for three nights, from Friday to Saturday.

Javier was with them and Rubén told him:

—I assure you that you will have fun.

On the way to the hotel Rubén said:

—Tomorrow we'll visit Xcaret Park; on Sunday morning we'll see Xplor, and in the afternoon we'll see Xenses.

Javier asked him what the parks were about and Rubén said, "It will be a surprise."

They arrived at the hotel late; they spent their time getting to know it. Rubén booked two suites, one for Tere and the boy, and one for himself. They toured the hotel's canals, then the oceanfront pools where there were dolphins. Javier wanted to swim with them, but it was already closed. They climbed the mound to the church at the top and browsed the specialty restaurants to choose one. The boy chose the Italian one, as he loved spaghetti. They took a boat along a river that looked real but was artificial, and stopped by a hotel that Rubén had told them his grandfather had built. They went to swim and change, and Tere mentioned that it had been hard to get Javier out of the jacuzzi, as he was so happy in it.

Dinner was wonderful, and they talked about how much they liked the hotel. There was a *show*, but they left it for another day because Javier was very tired. Rubén told them he had a surprise for them the

next day: "The park director, who is a good friend of Aunt Meche, who said she was the most charming and capable woman she'd ever met, and the pride of the women of the Riviera Maya, having reached the highest position in one of the 100 most important companies in Mexico, promised me early entry to the park so we could swim in the underground river alone. That's why we have to get up early to get there on time."

The next day, they arrived in their swimsuits, grabbed a locker, and waded into the river. Afterward, Tere said it had been one of the most enjoyable experiences of her life. Javier was thrilled, as he couldn't understand how there was such a beautiful river with such clear water underground, since he only knew rivers upriver. They got out of the river, left their life jackets, and, after breakfast at a delicious restaurant, dressed in T-shirts and swimsuits, set off for the tour of the park.

Rubén told them they would tour it in reverse, and first they went to the butterfly farm; they were amazed by its beauty and the number of butterflies. Javier was very interested in the display at the entrance about how butterflies are born. Then they toured the Mayan village, where artisans were showing how to make crafts. The boy admitted he had swum across and wanted to buy something, and Tere wanted a hammock, but Rubén told them not to because they would have to carry it all day.

They climbed a little and entered an aviary. Rubén told them, "You're going to see a place I like most in the park."

They started at the top, in the cage of the quetzal, the red-faced vulture, and the bald eagle, and when they got out, they had a general view of the aviary. They crossed a suspension bridge that Javier said was enormous and that went over ravines, rivers, and waterfalls, and they began to observe the large number of birds there. They went down, enjoying everything, until they got out. Upon exiting, they entered the stained-glass window of butterflies, and Javier realized that he had swum past there. Tere was amazed by everything.

Afterward, he took them to see the jaguar and puma islands. Rubén remembered that the yellow jaguar with black spots—because there was another black one, and they were both male and female—was just like the one his mother and father had seen in the jungle when she was a child.

They stopped by the "Xcaret cemetery" and wandered around, reading all the funny signs on the tombs. Rubén told them they had to see it on the Day of the Dead, which was celebrated in Xcaret with a huge ritual, visited by thousands of locals and tourists.

They continued on and arrived at the museum of models of the main Mayan monuments and ruins, where they played the ancient ball game. Next to the store, which Rubén said they would see at the end, they entered the Mexican restaurant. As the meal progressed, Tere said it was the best Mexican food she had ever tasted, and that in Nicaragua, as in Washington, there were many Mexican restaurants that she visited.

After finishing eating, they went to the aquarium. Rubén explained that it wasn't really an aquarium, but a reef, since the reefs they were going to see were alive and some of the few in the world. Javier, who was fascinated by fish, loved it.

As they left, Rubén said to Javier:

—Come, I have a surprise for you.

And he took him swimming with the sharks. Tere was alarmed, and Rubén replied:

—Come with us, don't worry.

And the three of them had a blast. Javier was excited, and Tere was terrified. As they left, Rubén said to Javier:

—Look, these are cat sharks; they're harmless, but if you happen to see one at the ranch at night, don't get in. And if you're already in the water, swim slowly without splashing, because the ones that attack are very dangerous.

Tere calmed down with the explanation. Somewhat hurriedly, they went to visit the Yucatecan hacienda, where a guide told them about the furniture and customs of the time. They also visited the machine used to make henequen thread from henequen leaves, which was primarily used to make sacks. Afterward, they went to Tlaxco, the theater where the *Xcaret night show* was presented, which Javier thought was enormous, the largest he'd ever seen. Rubén explained to them:

—This isn't a folkloric ballet, although the second part is almost entirely one. At the beginning, it tells the history of Mexico.

The show began with the ball games, and Javier said they were exciting, but he liked soccer better. Tere was absorbed, saying nothing. Then the conquest and the battles between the Spanish and Native Americans began, ending with the horses chasing the Native Americans. Javier exclaimed, "That's not fair!" and laughed. Then came the mestizaje (mixed race) scene and the painting of the Virgin of Guadalupe.

Tere burst into tears, for in Nicaragua there was a church dedicated to the Virgin of Guadalupe, and she had attended a school run by nuns who venerated the Virgin of Guadalupe. Then came a painting of Mexico from my memories that she loved, and a painting of the Mexican Revolution. There was an intermission, and they were served a delicious dinner. Tere was truly excited. A year before going to Mexico, she had studied its history. She said it was so she could understand Mexicans, and the show reminded her of that. The folkloric dances began, which fascinated her: the Tehuanas with their beautiful dresses and proud bearing; the dances and music of Veracruz, which she had always found very joyful, as well as its carnival. Rubén told her his favorite was the tambora norteña, and when the mariachis came on, it was the apotheosis in the theater.

Ruben told them:

—Do you see the enthusiasm of the people? They all seem Mexican, but 70% are foreigners and they seem happy.

Javier surprised them and said:

—What I liked the most was the one about the men who fly.

He was referring to the Papantla flyers.

Everyone left happily. Rubén took them to the store and said, "Now, buy whatever you want, because from here we're going to the hotel." They bought toys for Javier's friends. Tere bought a Yucatecan dress for her mother and one for herself, and a hammock, and they took the little train to the hotel. They were happy and excited. Tere said to Rubén:

—I never believed there was a place as beautiful, as natural, and as Mexican as this park.

Ruben answered him:

—My aunt Meche said that before Xcaret it was said that Cancun was like Miami, and that after Xcaret and Xoximilco, it was never said again.

They arrived at the hotel and went to bed early; they were tired, and the next day they continued on to the Xplor and Xenses parks. They had an exquisite Mexican breakfast and were at Xplor at nine o'clock sharp. Rubén told them:

—There are four things here: the zip lines, the jungle cars, the swimming river, and the rafting river, which are underground rivers.

Javier asked if it was like the one at Xcaret, and Rubén replied that it was bigger and had many points called stalactites and stalagmites. Javier didn't understand, but didn't ask any more questions, and they started on the zip lines. They were all very excited, but the ones they liked the most were the ones that led from the entrance to the hill up and the ones that ended in the cenotes. Then they went to the jungle carts, in which they went into puddles, caves, swamps, and rivers. Rubén drove carefully, and Javiercito would say, "Go for it, man." Tere loved the relationship Javier had established with Rubén. Then they went to the rivers; Tere was fascinated by them both, and Javier was enthusiastic; they couldn't believe the beauty of the illuminated caves. Although they had already seen many, since beautiful illuminated caves connected one place to another, Tere loved the cave where the beating heart was. Afterwards they went to eat and wanted to swing in the hammocks, but Rubén told them they couldn't because they had another park in the afternoon, and they immediately went to Xenses.

When they arrived, Rubén told them: "There are four attractions here: a store that distorts reality; the Sensorama, which is a series of dark tunnels with four habitats: jungle, tundra, beach, and desert; and a crooked town." "A crooked town?" asked Javiercito. And Rubén replied: "You'll see, I can't explain it to you." "A spa that begins with a bird's eye view." Javier asked: "Like yesterday's?" And Rubén replied: "No, different, you'll see." "And a saltwater river in which you float." And looking at Javier, she said smiling: "You'll see. A river of mud." "Of mud?" Tere said: "Yes, of mud, you'll see, and some showers and a hot sauna, and a nice soak at the end."

And they started through the sensorama tunnel. Tere was amazed, and Javiercito said, "I didn't understand it!" They arrived at the crooked town, and when they entered, Javiercito asked, "Are we going up to the church?" And Rubén said, "No, we're going down." "How?" Tere asked, "it's up there." And then Rubén showed her a river that was on the right side of the street at the edge of the houses, and it looked like the water was rising, and Rubén asked Tere, "Do you think the water in a river can go up?" And Tere and Javier didn't understand, and they said to Rubén, "Explain it to us." And he said, "It's all an optical illusion, an illusion of the senses that I can't understand either," and they began to walk through it. The optics told them they were going up, and their bodies told them they were going down, and Rubén told them that if they got dizzy, they should look at the ground. Javier was excited; with his energy, he went into the houses, and in one, he said,

The furniture was on the ceiling; in others, she couldn't walk because all the vertical furniture seemed to be tilted, and there were staircases that seemed to go up but were actually going down. It was a wonderful experience, and Rubén said, "Every time I come here, I come back without understanding it." They entered the church and heard the bells and were surprised to see that they were plates, which, when they moved in the water, seemed like bells. And Tere exclaimed, "All my senses deceived me!" Rubén replied, "Now you understand why it's called Xenses." And she asked why it was called with an x and not an s, and he told her that all the names of the parks in that group began with an x.

They arrived at the spa after drinking lemonade from a lemon tree trunk and passing a cenote that Tere loved, and they climbed into a kind of spiral pyramid. Javier said, "Surprise!" and went first down a slide that descended rapidly and landed in water that was illuminated by blue. Rubén followed, and finally Tere, who was a little afraid. Down below, almost breathless, she was dying of laughter at the sensation of falling down the slide. They reached bird's eye view and were harnessed to fly like a bird, looking down at the ground with their arms open wide. Javier enjoyed it very much and said that after the crooked village, this was his favorite. They entered the salt river and the mud river. Tere said she now understood why they called it a spa, because upside down in the two rivers, they glided without sinking, with a sense of tranquility and beautiful music.

All in caverns lit with very soft tones. They entered the sauna, the showers, and left at dusk and went directly to the hotel.

Tere said to Rubén: —

Excuse me, but I am truly amazed, distracted, enthusiastic—

I'm tired and exhausted. I can't take it anymore and prefer to take a shower and order room service.

Javercito asked him:

—Mom, can I get in the jacuzzi?

And she said to him:

—As you wish, son.

And Ruben remembered his grandfather saying to his mother: "As you wish, my daughter."

Everyone went to bed happy for the two incredible days they had spent, and as they said goodbye,

Rubén said: "Tomorrow,

whoever gets up last wakes up the others."

Tere smiled, but Javercito didn't understand.

The next day at breakfast at 11:00 in the morning, Tere said to Rubén:

—Rubén, last night Javercito told me that he didn't want to go to Disneyland anymore, that if instead of leaving, he could stay at the ranch.

And Javercito, looking at him, asked him:

- Yeah?

Ruben's happiness was overwhelming, and with great satisfaction he told them:

—My house is your house, for life if you wish.

Tere felt a thrill of satisfaction at that answer and couldn't allow herself to imagine what it meant. Everyone laughed, and Tere said, "We could stay for lunch and enjoy the hotel a little longer."

Ruben said there was no rush and they enjoyed the morning peacefully. They went and left the hotel. On the way Tere said to Rubén:

—I never thought I could enjoy my son so much. I'm so grateful.

And he replied:

"No Tere, don't be mistaken, I'm the grateful one. I've come many times to the parks, but I have never enjoyed them as much as I did this time, with you and Javier.

And he asked Javier:

— Did you have fun?

And the boy

said: —Great.

They arrived at the ranch. Juan was waiting for them, and they went to sleep early. The next day, Rubén had a lot of business in Cancún: he had an appointment with Pedro Chan and a lot of tax payments and other matters to go over, and he wouldn't be back until the evening. Juan would stay for whatever they needed. Javier spent the morning playing soccer with his friends, who didn't have school, for some reason or another. But he spent lunch and the afternoon with his mother.

At lunch, Javier told his mom: "Hey mom,

Rubén is really great, I feel really good with him, he makes me feel really good."

Happy. Does he look like my dad, whom I never knew? I wish he was like my dad.

She understood the message and simply said: "No, son, all human beings are different."

Javercito replied: —Too bad.

And she continued eating as if nothing had happened. She felt that little shiver again, the kind she used to get whenever something important happened in her life.

Rubén returned and told them that Pedro, the accountant, was wonderful. He explained all the accounts in detail in one morning, and everything was in perfect order. He was very happy. After dinner, Javercito got up from the table, hugged Rubén, kissed him, and said, "I'm very happy when I'm with you."

He turned around and went to his room. Tere watched them and couldn't stop a tear from rolling down her cheek. Rubén felt a little embarrassed; he wasn't used to such expressions of affection from other people, except for his

mother, but he felt enormous happiness and immense affection for the boy he had just met ten days before. Everything was happening at a rapid pace. He felt moved and experienced emotions he had never felt before in his life.

The next morning, Don Juan came with his horse to pick up Javier; When the children weren't around, he and Jacinto played with Javier and had a lot of fun.

Rubén told Tere,

"Now I want you to watch a recording my father made in 2018. I would have been 50 years old at the time. It seems I was more influenced by my mother and grandfather than by my father. In reality, I lived with my mother on the ranch for practically 22 years, since I worked every day in my studio, and until I finished high school, she guided me in my studies the whole time. Later, when I was pursuing my degree, we didn't spend as much time together. She said the roles had been reversed and that I knew more than she did, but I constantly needed her support. She had set up a studio in a semi-abandoned warehouse between Uncle Jacinto's house and ours. It was spacious, and she installed equipment similar to mine and began to work more intensively on her photography. She was in close contact with Aunt Meche and all her friends in Cancún on Facebook. Sometimes she would ask Juan to take her out to lunch with them, and she would return with my dad. My father was very dedicated to his work at the University of the Caribbean. He loved it and got along very well with the rectors, wonderful people always carefully selected by the Steering Committee. He left at 7:00 in the morning and returned at 8:00 at night every day. He didn't come home for lunch, only on Saturdays and Sundays. Only once a month did he not eat with us; he went to Isla Mujeres to fish, which was his life's passion. When my mother once asked him why he never fished at the ranch, he replied: "The weekends I'm at the ranch are for spending with my son and you." I have the impression that they were very happy, loved each other deeply, and respected each other's time and space. On Sundays, we went out to eat, often with my grandfather and my uncle Juan; they understood each other very well and chatted happily. Now I'll show you the video my father recorded:

Today, October 13, 2017, I have decided to record many ideas and concepts that I have in mind and that have not been easy for me to express to my son, who will be 18 years old, and to my beloved wife.

During university breaks, I continued to go to the university to study sociology in the virtual classrooms that were operating at the time and were available for studying different subjects. I studied sociology and took notes about things I had experienced in Cancún. This is what I will narrate in this recording, which is my first, but it won't be the last.

My parents were two truly dedicated teachers. My father was always a high school teacher in a government school, and he was passionate about reading, sociology, and philosophy. They had a classroom on the ground floor of the house—which was a three-story building that

They had bought an apartment with their savings upon arriving in Cancún, along with help from their parents, who were merchants in the small town of Chetumal. He and his mother, who was an elementary school teacher at the British School, offered evening classes, and in the afternoons they had many students whom they prepared for exams, or gave them "tutoring," as they called it, for their studies. In the afternoons, they worked between two and three hours, and during exam season, sometimes up to four hours. They started at 5:00 p.m. In that apartment, my father had reserved the largest room, where he had his beloved library, as he called it. When I discovered it, the three of us spent many hours reading. Despite his income, we didn't have much financial leeway, but I attended the best schools in Cancún. I attended private elementary and middle school, and high school and college at La Salle. Our fun included going to the Américas mall on Sundays, which they loved. We ate delicious food, went for walks, my mom went grocery shopping, and we went to the movies if there was a movie we liked. They had a car that my dad used to drive us to and from school. They bought me a new Toyota when I entered college.

We didn't suffer deprivation, but we didn't have much. When we went on vacation, we went to Chetumal with relatives. We rarely went to the beach because my father didn't like being around many people, and the public beaches in Cancún were few and far between. Although the beaches are open to the public, my father didn't like being bothered by hotel security. When I was in college, I sometimes went to Isla Mujeres on weekends with a very dear friend from elementary school who had dropped out of high school to live on the island, since he never liked Cancún. He was a true islander; his father had fishing boats, which were among the few that were in working order, and a freezer. He loved fishing and loved me visiting him. He was and is my best friend, and I fished with him on the weekends when I stayed on the island at his house.

As you can see, my life, which you already knew but which I wanted to summarize, was very simple and very happy, until I married you, Alicia, I became friends with your father, we had our son, and I reached fulfillment.

Once this brief introduction is complete, I will begin with the geographical description:
Cancun is clearly defined by four zones:

1. The tourist zone; 2.

The city planned and built by Fonatur; 3. The Puerto

Juárez neighborhood, the only thing that existed before the city of Cancún was started,

since that's where the pier to cross to Isla Mujeres was located, which grew due to the need for housing among construction workers and hotel services, which were growing exponentially; and 4. The Bonfil ejido, I call it a magical ejido, created

by a president who didn't know that stones don't produce crops and who moved farmers there, supposedly so they would produce what Cancún would consume.



[In the video, Rubén Sr. displayed maps indicating these areas and their boundaries.]

The tourist zone. Fonatur created this zone in what could be defined as an island with first-world urbanization, with all its underground facilities, a large boulevard, Kukulcán, with two access bridges, one through the city and another entering through the airport, and two bridges crossing the canals connecting Nichupté Lagoon to the sea—the well-known Sigfrido Canal, in memory of one of the creators of Cancún and highly regarded throughout the world—and the Punta Nizuc Canal, in the southern part of Cancún Island.

There was also a bridge connecting the large Nichupté lagoon with a small lagoon that bordered one of the first hotels in Cancún, the Méditerranée, which was the creator of the *all-inclusive concept* in the world.

Originally, the boulevard would run along the shore of the lagoon to always have a view of it. On the wider eastern side, a beautiful, immense coconut grove was preserved, with access through it leading to the oceanfront lots. It's a world-class hotel zone in terms of urban quality, although the boulevard is already saturated.

Fonatur's idea was that the government would sell all the land and that private enterprise would build the hotel infrastructure, taking charge of the development and job creation needed on the peninsula, since the population was practically unemployed and impoverished by the region's limited agricultural production.

I believe that if Cancun had not been built, the rebellion movement of the Mayan ethnic groups of the Chiapas Highlands would have occurred earlier in the Yucatan Peninsula.

Perhaps Fonatur made a mistake by creating single-family oceanfront lots, as the project's primary purpose was to develop hotels or condominiums. This was with the exception of Pok Ta Pok, the Isla subdivision. Although it was included in the master plan, Fonatur did not develop it and sold it to ICA, which was responsible for developing and marketing it.

Later, also stemming from the master plan, there was Puerto Cancún, which was essentially a vast mangrove swamp and which Fonatur had repeatedly failed to develop for many years. In the end, it was in the hands of ICA, and Fonatur arranged for it to be handed over to a foreign adventurer who had ruined a large number of retirees in the United States and had invested that money in bankrupt and abandoned projects in Cancún. He offered to invest \$100 million in the project; a master trust was created that held the sales until he invested the \$100 million. He invested 10 million and reported that he had no more money, but Fonatur was so committed to him, for some reason or other, that it tapped into the funds they had from sales, as the project had been an impressive success. With those funds, the project was finally realized, turning out to be a marvelous work, a combination of marina and golf course, which is, has been, and will be a great success. That foreigner made the mistake of going to St. Petersburg, Florida, for heart care, and the authorities of that country imprisoned him and made it a condition that he sell all his properties in Cancún to compensate for his fraud. Puerto Cancún and all its properties were sold, and the money was given to those defrauded. It is said that he died under house arrest. Puerto Cancún was born through a very painful birth, but it became a wonderful reality. Thus, the tourist area was configured as follows:

1. Oceanfront land, mostly hotels and with a few exceptions, private housing units with golf courses.
2. Puerto Cancún, as a beach-marina-commercial-single-family and condominium with golf course.
3. Pok Ta Pok, a golf course in single-family areas with horizontal condominiums, mainly a hotel zone in the center.
4. The shore of the lagoon and the boulevard overlooking it.
5. The island, as a single-family condominium center, with small marinas, with urbanization of hidden facilities and facing the boulevard, two large condominium lots, on one of which two young Jewish brothers, who were big businessmen, built the La Isla shopping center.
6. The central area of the eastern zone, when the plague of "lethal yellowing" of coconut trees fell on Cancun and they practically became extinct, a very nice little practice golf course was built, as well as the best shopping center in the tourist area called Plaza Kukulcán, where my father-in-law's favorite steakhouse is located, which is Ruth Chris.

7. The southern area, where one of the best hotels in Cancun was built, the Nizuc, which continues with development plans.

Cancún is currently said to have 28,000 hotel rooms, but the exact number is unknown. What is a fact is that it has achieved its goal of creating a unique tourist destination, generating many jobs and developing a population center larger than any of the major cities in southeastern Mexico—Villahermosa, Tuxtla Gutiérrez, Campeche, or Mérida—not to mention Chetumal, some of which are over 400 years old.

The population of Cancún's tourist zone is very difficult to define; of course, its two most obvious categories, floating and resident, are vastly different. The floating population can reach 50,000 during peak season, while the residential population can reach 5,000. Then there are the condominiums, which combine residents with floating residents.

These are the main geographical and demographic characteristics of the tourist area.

Its road characteristics are very simple, a single boulevard, increasingly congested, and four options to improve roads:

1. A bridge over the Bojórquez lagoon to prevent congestion at nightclubs.
2. A large bridge from the eastern part of the island, towards the Tajamar boardwalk.
3. A maritime carrier from Tajamar, to different points on the Island.
4. A monorail that runs along the Kukulcán.

It is the date on which the solution is unknown.

Let's move on to the second urban area, the city planned by Fonatur. My first observation is that I would say it was poorly planned by Fonatur. Some crazed urban planner came up with the most dysfunctional urban layout ever conceived, made up of superblocks with internal roads that are impossible to codify or define, and created central parks that are permanent dumpsters and garbage dumps, with no maintenance. There is only one decent and beautiful park, the one created in block 15 by Cristina, an environmentalist whom my grandfather so admired, who, through pure personal effort and without any help from authorities or neighbors, built a decent and beautiful park that beautifies the superblock and adds value to everything around it.

The avenues that intertwine these superblocks have erratic and tortuous trajectories. In the west, the area has grown indiscriminately between two large avenues.

The urbanized area has developed commercial areas on the avenues that are growing and are declining, such as Yaxchilán, among others.

On larger plots of land, both planned and unplanned, more than five shopping centers and about ten large supermarkets have appeared, all with parking capacity.

Since it did not have a conventional layout, a large central square was not created, as is characteristic of all colonial cities, in flat cities with streets that form a grid and have more or less a main square in the center, with the authorities on one side, the church on the other and portals on the sides, which are the nerve center of the community and have been an ancestral meeting point for the towns.

Although a nondescript city hall was built, with constant parking problems, between two streets, Tulum and Náder. It has two major avenues that cross it: López Portillo, recently renovated and well-planned from the start in the traditional grid of the Puerto Juárez neighborhood, which is the old Mérida–Puerto Juárez highway, and Tulum, which begins with a bottleneck at López Portillo and extends north toward Tulum, hence the name Tulum. It continues straight through the Bonfil neighborhood until it intercepts Airport Boulevard and continues as a highway to Tulum.

In 2012 the Arco Norte was built, and in 2015 the Huayacan, and there are two bypasses-couhgs from López Portillo to Tulum, one already absorbed by the population.

To date, there is no traffic chaos in the city, and it has only three overpasses: in the Bonfil neighborhood, at the intersection of Bonampak and López Portillo, and at the intersection of Bonampak and Tulum.

Puerto Juárez has been absorbed into the city as just another colony.

There is a park with a church known as the Park of the Palapas, which were destroyed by *Gilberto* and never rebuilt.

No one knows the exact population of the city, and its boundaries are indefinite, since to the north it is delimited by the Puerto Juárez neighborhood, but to the west it grows indefinitely on both sides of the Cancún-Mérida highway, up to the height of the airport runway, and further on, with a large number of irregular developments, and to the south it grew absorbing the Bonfil ejido up to the Airport Boulevard.

For more than 20 years, more or less successful housing developments have sprung up on the northern and western fringes of the city, with more than 40,000 Infonavit affordable housing units. These developments originally had sufficient urban infrastructure but have since deteriorated.

The city's street furniture is a disaster, and entertainment options are few. There are two theaters, one on the pier in the tourist area and a smaller one in the center. There's also a once-reputable cultural center, a planetarium, and a gigantic auditorium, whose purpose no one knows, opposite Bonfil, which opened very quietly. It has a small racetrack, primarily for go-karts, and there used to be a venue for the Cancún Fair, which practically disappeared and was a fun alternative. It also had a large arena with variety shows and the classic cockfight.

There is a wonderful project between the lagoon and Tulum, promoted by a committee of altruistic citizens, who without profit motive try to get it going, but when

There are no municipal obstacles; they come from Fonatur or the government. There's no culture of altruism in Mexico; but it seems that with the changes taking place, the project is moving forward.

The most successful community center has been the Las Américas shopping plaza, which features shops, restaurants, supermarkets, movie theaters, and residential towers.

Next, we have Zone 3, the Puerto Juárez neighborhood. This area began as an irregular settlement, the product of people arriving without the resources to buy anything in the urban area. It was a miracle that a group led by people your grandfather knew, and a concerned state government, created a master plan and opened up new horizons. The urban layout was conventional: López Portillo Avenue in the center and cross and parallel streets. It has been a miracle of self-construction and municipal, state, and federal efforts, concentrated on the Quintana Roo Housing Institute, to provide it with services and street furniture. Cancún in general has managed to build the schools required by population growth, with delays, and also the sewage treatment plants, an issue that became truly frightening, since the entire peninsula has underground currents leading to the sea, and if the sewage is not treated properly, it would inevitably contaminate the groundwater, the sea, and its beaches.

Cancún has virtually no stormwater drainage; everything drains naturally and is transferred to the subsoil through absorption wells. It hasn't presented any major problems, other than occasional flooding on some roads during days of heavy rain.

The Puerto Juárez neighborhood and the adjacent Infonavit neighborhoods, along with its northern arch, have gradually become more dignified. It would require immense promotion and management to raise awareness about issues such as littering, painting facades, preserving street furniture, and so on, but it has fulfilled, and continues to fulfill, the role of absorbing the population that arrives in search of opportunities.

Urban transport lines are sufficient, but with the exception of Autocar and Tu-ricun, the rest are independent cooperatives and permit holders struggling to make ends meet, but whose collusion or corruption with the authorities creates an anarchic situation. The city is complemented by a huge number of taxis, a transportation service that still operates but requires reorganization.

Our taxi drivers, for the most part, are good, hard-working people who are constantly under pressure from the authorities. Regarding fares, it's incredible that a national price scale that increases with inflation can't be established.

Every fare discussion is a chaotic mess, rife with corruption, and trucks and taxis are undermined. But we can say that despite all this, it still works.

Now we will talk about the part of the city named by the president who founded it, Ejido Bonfil, in memory of a presidential candidate for Secretary of Agriculture who died in a plane crash.

It begins as an agricultural ejido that never plants anything, and has three perfectly clear stages: in the first, the president sets up chicken and pig farms, which fail, and they eat them all. In the second, they live off the sale of sascab, the powder into which marine limestone degrades and which is used for all roads and for filling buildings, which is a wonderful material. And finally, in the third stage, they live off land speculation, and all the ejidatarios become rich.

The urban layout of Bonfil is traditional: streets that run parallel to and cross Tulum, with a central park that's gradually losing ground; it has water, electricity, and pavement, much of which contaminates the water table; it has virtually no street furniture and is inhabited by approximately 10,000 people.

A huge urban area was created between the town and the airport, which was sold without any services. It has a grid-like urban layout, with sascab streets, and which In-viqroo regularized. It runs from Tulum to Huayacan and possibly has a bright future.

Throughout the state of Quintana Roo, in addition to the cattle ranches, there are seven large private properties, two of which are influencing the development of Cancún and one of which is influencing the development of the Riviera Maya, Akumal.

Those that influence Cancun are Playa Mujeres, which has several kilometers of coastline and capacity for 10,000 hotel rooms, and the Golden Mile, which is located on the left side of the Tulum highway after the airport bypass and can accommodate 5,000 hotel rooms.

And Puerto Aventuras. This property was built by the same lawyer who helped your grandfather, and there, a young, dynamic, and charismatic architect who came with the group to Akumal has completed a large, far-reaching urban project called Puerto Aventuras, which includes hotels, a marina, an urban area, a golf course, a dolphin-swimming area, and a commercial area. This is possibly the best place to live in the Riviera Maya, as it even has its own school. Across the highway, a significant housing development has emerged, which already includes a shopping center, Infonavit housing, etc.

And Playacar. This development was carried out by Situr, next to Playa del Carmen, in an important territorial reserve. It basically consists of three zones. A beachfront tourist zone, where around ten hotels with approximately 4,000 rooms have been developed, which were the first to explode the Riviera Maya. Quinta Avenida, in the second zone, a magnificent golf course; and in the third, an urban zone that has absorbed the high-level economic growth of Playa del Carmen.

And the development of Playa del Carmen, with its wonderful beaches and its Quinta Avenida. The avenue has spawned a large number of *boutique* hotels and restaurants.

We cannot fail to mention Puerto Morelos, a recently designated municipality, which has developed a powerful hotel industry on its northern and southern coasts, along beautiful beaches, with more than 3,500 rooms.



And finally, rounding out the Riviera Maya is the Tulum area, which has also seen significant hotel and urban development, but is problematic because it is where the greatest number of dispossessions by public officials who coveted these properties have occurred.

On the other hand, it should be mentioned that along the 110 kilometers of the Cancun-Tulum highway, between the aforementioned towns, many hotels have been built, to the point that the Riviera Maya, as a whole, has already surpassed the city of Cancun, and currently has more than 38,000 hotel rooms, and it is likely that the combination of all the areas currently under construction and management will add 5,000 more rooms.

The prediction of having more than 100,000 hotel rooms by 2020 is not far off.

The other two affect the Riviera Maya, which are the Akumal properties and the Xel-Há and Caribbean trust reserves, which can accommodate 5,000 hotel rooms.

I consider that the above could be the urban description of the city of Cancun.

Rubén interrupts and tells Tere that there is a second part that talks about the historical evolution of Cancún, but that it would be better to watch it the next day calmly, and they both retire to rest.

The next morning, after breakfast, don Juan picked up Javiercito with the famous Chombo. Don Juan told them they would run a little on the beach, because Javier already knew how to ride well, which was why he was also riding. But he added that they shouldn't worry because Chombo couldn't run much at all, even if they beat him. He led him away, pulling on a leash that he held firmly in his right hand.

Rubén and Tere went to visit Uncle Jacinto, because don Juan had told them he was in poor health, and Rubén was worried. Jacinto was an old man, and when he was sick, he refused to see allopathic doctors. They arrived at his house and found him in his hammock. They greeted him and asked about his health. He answered in Mayan, which Rubén understood well, since Alicia had taught him. When they said goodbye, Rubén told Tere that he had said to her: "Rubencito, don't worry, a bad herb never dies, and I'm taking my herbs to cure myself." When she offered to take him a doctor, even though she knew it would be useless, she replied: "No, Rubencito, thank you, but you see, I don't believe in those quacks." Rubén replied: "They're quacks, but they cure sick people, Uncle." Jacinto just laughed, and they said goodbye.

Arriving at the studio, he put on the second part of the father's monologue.

Once we have located them geographically, we will now talk historically and sociologically.

However, I consider it of great importance to put the birth of Cancún into historical perspective, especially for you, Rubén, so that you understand the true significance of the feat of your grandfather, Don Juan, and your mother, Alicia.

I am going to make a synthesis of the history of Mexico which I divide into four great stages:

1. The pre-Hispanic period with its great indigenous cultures such as the Olmec, the Teotihuacan, the Mixtec-Zapotec, the Toltec and the Mexica, among which the Mayan culture stands out with its cities of Uxmal, Chichén Itzá, Cobá, Tulum, Palenque, Kantunil, Kohun-lich, Ek-Balam, Calakmul, and many others that you have visited several times.

2. The conquest and the colonial era, which was carried out by Spaniards of very low rank in Spain, who divided up the land and the indigenous peoples practically as slaves, and established the colony. The indigenous people were also spiritually subjugated by an outdated religion—modern Christianity is Protestantism—and by one of the cruelest methods of slavery, the Inquisition, to which religious leaders and rulers condemned those they considered impious. This period lasted just over 300 years.

3. Independence with the arrival of the heroes you know, Hidalgo, Allende, Guerrero, Morelos, among others, and which introduces Mexico to liberation and the 19th century, This is an anarchic and desperate century for Mexico, in which it loses half of its territory, partly due to the half-mad dictator Santa Anna, and produces perhaps the president most respected by Mexicans, Benito Juárez, who establishes reform, freeing the country from the yoke that the Church exercised over all Mexicans. It was a century of revolts and caciques, and which includes an attempt by France to turn Mexico into a colony under Emperor Maximilian. This movement divides Mexico into two political currents: the liberals, who fight against the empire, and the conservatives, who support it for their colonial interests and the belief that a foreign, educated emperor could better guide Mexico. You know the story: Juárez takes charge of the country's defense, and with the help of the neighboring country, he defeats the invading army, and the withdrawal of French troops ordered by Napoleon III takes place. During this time, the spirit of independent Mexico was consolidated.

It is important to introduce a more universal concept here: that the 20th **century** is the century of the revolution of revolutions, since all historical revolutions evolved.

The fire (energy) revolution	Atomic energy
The revolution of the wheel	The pneumatic tire
The agricultural revolution	Genetic agriculture
The revolution of medicine	Vaccines, nanotechnology, penicillin, etc.
The communications revolution	The satellites
The transport revolution	The combustion engine (in the air-sea-land)
The mathematics revolution	Computing
The housing revolution	The skyscrapers
The revolution of light bulbs	Electricity
The food revolution	Pasteurization and canning
The leisure revolution	Television, etc.

Then comes the Mexican Revolution, a civil war against a dictator who gives Mexico its first traces of modern culture: he builds the Mexico-Chihuahua train and a rail network that crisscrosses the entire country; he begins construction of the Palace of Fine Arts; he refurbishes and spruces up Mexico City, which is adorned with new palaces and ostentatious homes belonging to the dictator's allies, but he keeps the poor indigenous and mestizo people throughout the country subjugated, enslaved on haciendas with their striped stores.

He is the one who sent General Ignacio A. Bravo to subjugate the Mayans in the caste war, a war in which your grandfather distinguished himself for his courage and audacity, and in which they were on the verge of taking Mérida, and would have done so, if not for the night of the fireflies.

May, which indicated that it was time to sow corn, which was essential and sacred to them, and they withdrew. The general defeated them with great cruelty, and your grandfather and his followers fled south to the coast, which was virgin territory, despite having been the first place the Spaniards set foot on.

When the Revolution triumphed, due to those Mexican twists and turns, a modern but conservative liberal sector rose to power. After the twists and turns you know about, Calles was elevated to power. In addition to modernizing the institutions, he created the National Revolutionary Party (PNR), a party that evolved into the PRI. This marked the beginning of the country's modern period. During those years, what was called "stabilizing development" was established. In theory, a president from the so-called left alternated with one from the so-called right. And so, for 70 years, they alternated in power, always led by the PRI.

It is very important to mention that during this period of institutionalization, several organizations were formed that became the pillars of Mexico's stability, such as the unions:

The Mexican Workers' Central (CTM), which brought together all of the country's workers' unions.

The railway workers' union

The Pemex workers' union

The CFE workers' union

The union of workers of the Light and Power Company The National Union of Education Workers (SNT)

The Federation of Unions of State Workers (FSTE)

The National Confederation of Popular Organizations (CNOP), which controlled groups of independent and informal workers and merchants.

The National Peasant Central (CNC), which controlled all the ejidos in Mexico and managed their papers and credits.

The Employers' Confederation (Coparmex), which was the arm of the upper classes to participate in politics.

And an infinite number of ramifications of all these unions in the states.

All these organizations were controlled by the state through power, money, or force, and were the political foundation of the already established Institutional Revolutionary Party. And in Mexico, what Peruvian Nobel Prize winner Mario Vargas Llosa once called the "perfect dictatorship" was established.

The presidents produced by Calles's party are: Lázaro

Cárdenas del Río. He is the president who embraces Zapata's motto of "Land and Liberty." He first freed himself from Calles and then established agrarian reform, for which he founded the Secretariat of Agrarian Reform.

Manuel Ávila Camacho. A president no one understands why Cárdenas put him in power. He was Catholic, a conservative (with a brother, Maximino, who embodied the classic cacique: arbitrary, abusive, womanizing, and thieving).

Miguel Alemán Valdés. Many consider him the first technocrat. During his six-year term, major civil and institutional projects were consolidated, such as the University City, the Mexican Social Security Institute, the Medical Center, the General Hospital, and the Cardiology Hospital, a Mexican pride. The first superhighway to Cuernavaca was built, among others.

Adolfo Ruiz Cortines. He is an honest president who continues the development works and the creation of new, more modern facilities. He was conservative.

Adolfo López Mateos. He claimed to be a moderate leftist. He was a sympathetic president who continued the stabilizing development.

Gustavo Díaz Ordaz. A conservative president who began to tolerate corruption and got his hands dirty on October 2, 1968. During his term, he approved the project to create Fonatur (National Development Fund) and the development of Cancún.

Luis Echeverría Álvarez. A president who considered himself leftist and who created hundreds of state-owned enterprises with the misguided vision of creating jobs. He supported Cancún and created the Bonfil Ejido with peasants from the north. He once spent Christmas with them. During his time, the rampant corruption that has characterized Mexico to this day began to spread.

José López Portillo. Mexico's biggest disappointment. A university professor who considered himself a conqueror, who cried in Congress blaming the bankers for the economic crisis, and who nationalized the banks. He supported Cancún and held the North-South Summit, which was a great promotion for Cancún.

Miguel de la Madrid Hurtado. The first true technocrat. Under him, the peso was devalued, and the new peso was created by eliminating three zeros. The dollar, which cost 3,000 pesos, would cost 3 new pesos.

Carlos Salinas de Gortari. Technocrat. He was the first to implement major reforms; he eliminated hundreds of companies created by Echeverría and denationalized the banks. The stock market crisis gave rise to several multimillionaires who bought the banks he denationalized, and his friends took over the state-owned companies that were big businesses. His brother ended up in prison for the abuses he committed during his administration. He supported Cancún.

Ernesto Zedillo Ponce de León. He emerged from the assassination of the PRI candidate, Luis Donaldo Colosio. He became an enemy of Carlos Salinas. He stabilized the country's macroeconomy. He was the president who visited Cancún the most. At the beginning of his administration, he devalued the peso, which harmed the country but benefited Cancún. At the time, during Hurricane *Gilberto* supported its reconstruction.

Vicente Fox Quezada. He belonged to the PAN (National Action Party), one of the opposition parties to the PRI, which represents the right wing in Mexico. He was Mexico's first openly demagogic president. He was charismatic, trained in the private sector, and a manager of the multinational Coca-Cola.

Married to a woman who aspired to the presidency. He kept the country's macroeconomy healthy; he supported Fonatur (Foundation of the Revolutionary Armed Forces of Catalonia). He broke the 70-year hegemony of PRI governments.

Felipe Calderón Hinojosa. A serious president. He was known for confronting drug trafficking, which was already penetrating the political structures. But he had to send the army and navy into the streets to fight. He kept the macroeconomy healthy.

Enrique Peña Nieto. With the support of the two main opposition parties, he managed to pass 11 major reforms in one year, ranging from education to others that affected major power structures, such as communications, energy, legal, criminal, transparency, and electoral systems. He opened oral trials and promoted reforms to CFE and Pemex. He limited the power of the teachers' union and closed the Central Light and Power Company, effectively nullifying a powerful and corrupt union. He sought to transform Mexico; however, corruption and violence marked his administration, making him one of the most criticized presidents by the press and media.

I make this entire historical description, which would seem banal, for several reasons.

Throughout this period, the most marginalized sector of the population had been the indigenous population. Since government policy has been to maintain the indigenous peoples' ways and customs, nothing has been done for them, except in 1970, when two events occurred on the Yucatan Peninsula: the intervention of Social Security in the henequen-growing region of Yucatan, and the launch of Cancún.

Cancún has demonstrated that when indigenous peoples are given work with dignity and benefits, they progress and develop. The southeast, Mérida, was connected to Mexico in the 1960s, and Cancún began in the 1970s. In those years, there has been more progress on the peninsula than in the previous five centuries. It took all the aforementioned governments to come to terms with a project designed for globalization, for air communications—since land communications were impossible due to their remoteness. The proof is that in all that time, Mexicans haven't invested in vacation properties, like those on the Pacific coast, because large population centers like Mexico City or Guadalajara have a greater impact due to their proximity to the Pacific. Cancún was planned for international markets with air connections.

This modern concept would be incomprehensible without the country's evolution, without the constant progress it has made. Undoubtedly, there are still enormous gaps, with half the population living in poverty; but at the same time, there is almost 100% school coverage; more than 50% health coverage; and another 30% have access to basic health, vaccination, and hygiene services.

It's very important that you consider this, which was very difficult for me to see. Until I married your mother, I was a leftist nonconformist. I couldn't see the positive side of such disparity. But Mexico is impressively young. At the beginning of the Revolution, we were an impoverished nation, with 17 million inhabitants and 70% illiteracy, with

an exploitative economic elite, inherited from the colony, with abusive bosses, always in collusion with the prevailing economic interests.

Not understanding that is not understanding your own history. Your grandfather, your mother, emerge from the depths of marginalized Mexico, from the last corner of Mexico, to which Cancún gives the opportunity to rise again. Cancún is a spearhead of modernity, a sprawling city, due to its poor urban layout and the constant neglect of its rulers and corruption, with the appropriate exceptions of some of its municipal presidents. But it is a challenge for all of us to ensure that Cancún becomes what it was planned to be: a modern and developed city. You and everyone else must fight for this to happen. And now what happened just 17 years ago in Mexico is happening: the alternation of power. The PRI, which was hegemonic in Quintana Roo since its inception, has been defeated by the terrible leadership of its corrupt rulers, with its exceptions, and now there is hope for change.

The territory of Quintana Roo was born as a state and had its first elected governor, while Cancún had its mayor. Those two people, with Fonatur, gave it a completely new structure: state and municipal legislatures, starting practically from scratch. Fortunately for Quintana Roo, Benito Juárez, and Cancún, those people did their job adequately; let's say the birth to modernity had good midwives. And that's where the great opportunity arose for your grandfather and your mother. It was then that one of the most marginalized communities in the country, and why not say it, in the world, emerged to join, in just two generations, in the span of 30 years, the knowledge and development of any modern city in the world. That's the miracle of Cancún; that's the reason for its historical journey.

With all this historical background, we can now tell the everyday, sociological story of Cancún, and to do so, I've divided it into three stages.

1. Its founding in 1970, until Hurricane *Gilberto* in 1988.
2. Accelerated development, from 1988 to Hurricane *Wilma* in 2005.
3. Stabilizing development, from 2005 to date.

First Stage. Cancún was born in the early 1970s. Contrary to what many believe, it was a difficult birth. The basic infrastructure was built, but for the founders there were no services, schools, markets, much less supermarkets. Domestic supplies were very problematic. When they knew a truck with vegetables or fruit was arriving, people would go directly to it. Later, meat and fish were bought at stalls that sprang up in Puerto Juárez and at some market stalls, but among the few workers there existed a spirit of solidarity, a founding feeling. There was faith, there was hope; it couldn't be that such a beautiful place couldn't

triumph. They said: "There are no vegetables, but the sea is beautiful; there will be no meat, but the sea is beautiful."

There was much suffering due to the shortage of doctors. One of them, one of the most famous and a good one, by the way, set up shop at the intersection of López Portillo Avenue and Tulum Avenue, in a secondary building, where I believe he still practices to this day. No one kept track of the number of people he cured or even saved from death. It took time for the first clinic to be established with the essential medical equipment and services and the necessary doctors. Whenever you got there, you always ran into someone you knew. Everyone knew each other among the residents of the urban area and the emerging tourist zone.

The housing problem was dramatic; everyone spent time living in modest houses in Block 2 and in the low-income housing of a very famous architect at the time who built 200, which were a disaster; floodwaters got in, everything happened to them, but they were a lifeline for many Cancún pioneers. There were no recreation centers; people went to the beach frequently; the first movie theater appeared on the cruise ship; it was like the movie theater in the film *Cinema Paraíso*. One of the first restaurants in Cancún, El Bocado, had a dirt floor. The best fun was going out on a boat, fishing for one or two barracudas in the bay between Cancún and Isla Mujeres, and eating them on a beach in Isla Mujeres, either in ceviche or in *tikin xic*, which was a delight.

And the first schools began to emerge. When your mother arrived in Cancún at age 12, she enrolled in the Británico School in makeshift classrooms, which were built little by little. By then, there were already government-run elementary schools, both in the city and at Yaxchilán and the Tulum extension. In the Puerto Juárez neighborhood, El Cejas, a seafood restaurant, emerged at number 28, which evolved into a large restaurant; and El Calamar, which was very famous, and when it prospered, it added an air-conditioned room, and the menu there was more expensive than outside, where there was no air conditioning. In the middle of that era, other good restaurants emerged, such as L'escargot, run by the French woman from Tabasco, always in love with her husband, Negro, and their wonderful daughters. Later, 100% Natural and Flamingos on the highway to Puerto Juárez; its friendly owner, always angry about everything, was from Veracruz and knew his seafood.

The bullring was also built in partnership between the Akumal engineer and the young, friendly, and kind bullfighters who held formal bullfights on Wednesdays. We all went for entertainment, and tourists were either excited or annoyed when the bull was killed. It wasn't a good business, but it was saved, as the ground floor was converted into a restaurant and bar area. That's where La Guadalupeana was located, a branch of the famous Coyoacán bar in Mexico City, where chickens were raffled off among the diners.

But I remind you that in the absence of entertainment, there was the beach. Restaurants were essential; my parents took me once or twice a month to eat at the ones I mentioned, and we always made friends. El Potrero opened, next to a butcher shop that was

A group of engineers and architects served him, and sometimes a French woman would flambé the meat with an orange peel. El novillo de Huimanguillo was a butcher who sold meat from Villahermosa and closed because a Korean man opened a similar one across the street. The Korean was invincible because he worked 18 hours a day. Later, he opened La Habichuela, the best Yucatecan restaurant, with his signature lobster dish served in a coconut, the coco-habichuela. During that time, Coparmex emerged, the employers' organization that, at the time, was the best organization that private enterprise could have. At the urging of the first municipal president, the CTM and CROC unions were founded, unions that looked after the interests of their members and didn't fight with the bosses. I don't recall a single strike during that time. The Taxi Drivers' Union was also formed. They were all grassroots organizations supporting the PRI, which was then made up of hard-working, trustworthy people who collaborated with the development of Cancún.

The private sector formed groups like Cancún-canta, which consisted of a singing competition among community members, which we all attended and had a lot of fun.

They were all acquaintances and friends; or the Red Cross Committee, where the bearded archer and his wife were always involved. Later, a large organization was founded, the Pioneers of Cancún, made up of people from the neighborhood, the city, and the tourist area. It brought together people who had started in Cancún around 1980 and earlier, and they held joyful gatherings. This was a large organization, very democratic and inclusive, as there were truck drivers, taxi drivers, doctors, and professionals. One of Cancún's most prestigious engineers, Engineer Lara, was perhaps one of the few honest mayors of Cancún. Some of the wives initially opened small restaurants serving regional Yucatecan food for the people from the peninsula; from Veracruz, Oaxaca, Chiapas, and the north. This is an organization that endures to this day.

A group formed that met on Fridays; it was very diverse, consisting of two famous journalists, two engineer friends of Grandpa's, and a group of very friendly Spaniards who loved Cancún, who seemed more Mexican than Spanish, and hotel managers and owners. Sometimes the party ended late.

At the Pok Ta Pok golf course clubhouse, bohemian gatherings were held with the three Bigurra brothers singing. They were all friends; my parents and Aunt Meche always attended them.

And Cancún grew and grew. The Playa Blanca hotels were built, by a very hardworking and intelligent engineer who had a nice family; the Presidente, the Camino Real, which was very nice; the Omni, by a couple from Cancún, and the Krystal, all with national investors. The Hyatt, which was the first hotel in an international chain. The Cancún Beach, which your grandfather built; the Aristos, by a friend of the friend of the engineer who was a friend of yours.

Your grandfather; the *Mediterranée*, the first *all-inclusive hotel*; and the Kukulcán condominium towers, the first vertical condominium, which, along with the Palmira towers and others, were the developments of a large group of Acapulco developers who went bankrupt with the devaluation of the dollar because they had sold ahead and fulfilled all their commitments by selling all their land reserves.

The first Convention Center had folkloric dancing, which we took visiting friends to. We also went out to the island and the coast of Puerto Morelos, Playa and Akumal, and even to Tulum, which was difficult because the road was very narrow and driving at night was dangerous. I remember that one time at night, a lot of tarantulas and scorpions would come out, and we would squash them. The small road to Tulum was always dangerous; we all knew people who died there. El Camino Real had a rumba club, El Azúcar, which was quiet back then, and my parents would visit it from time to time with Aunt Meche.

It was the time when a man from Yucatan, whom my father called an unsung hero, opened a wonderful store, Place Vendome, selling imported clothing and flea markets. It was vital in Cancún's early days, as it became fashionable in Mexico, and the women who sold flea markets in Chetumal waited to do so in Cancún. They also came from Mexico and Guadalajara, filling Mexicana's planes. The first tourists to come to Cancún weren't foreigners, they were Mexican tourists, and that store was crucial.

In addition to having created Place Vendome, this brilliant Yucatecan created *México Mágico*, a recreational park consisting of eight sensational shops and four spectacular theaters, where, it was said, all Mexican folklore would be presented.

The project was modified and opened with 25 or 30 ticket booths, reflecting the optimism surrounding the project. The complex was beautifully decorated with dozens of spectacular vases with paper flowers; the theaters, shops, and walls were wonderfully colorful, but had been painted with non-waterproof paints. There were four unusual shows: a bullfight with a device used by bullfighters to train, and a narrator who described the bullfight as a fight between the bad bull and the good bullfighter. A segment of the rock opera *Don Quixote de la Mancha*, mounted on a wooden horse; the work *A Chorus Line*, with native artists; and, to top it all off, a classical opera, with only fat people dressed in operatic fashion, with *lip-syncing*, and them pretending to sing. Then a downpour fell, destroying all the flowers and washing away all the paint.

They never opened more than four ticket offices, and that was the end of *México Mágico*, a project that, had André Breton known it, would have called the "magnum opus of Mexican surrealism." An incredible marvel destined for failure.

And on Tulum Avenue, all the classic flea markets, like El Teniente, were set up, and everyone would visit them to buy Chetumal-style flea markets, but the Chetumal residents didn't come for that either. The Cancun Hotel Association was also formed, which has been the best business association to date, and held meals and dances with great social integration.

During this time, other businesses also began to develop on the cruise ship, such as: the auto parts store owned by a close friend of ours, Adib, which was the first in Cancún, since when a truck broke down, it took more than a week for the parts to arrive; the first truck repair shops; the fish market in Market 23; the La Mexicana supermarket, owned by the manager of Mexicana de Aviación, who brought the vegetables on the plane; and the first Ultrafemme, on Tulum Avenue, a perfume and beauty store for women.

The first luxury shopping center, Plaza Caracol, was also opened, which was very successful for those who settled there, and particularly for silver jewelers.

And finally the first passenger truck from Mérida arrived.

Around this time, the tradition of Rocío's chiles en nogada (rogue-style chiles en nogada) was established, a wonderful recipe that continues to this day, benefiting the Cancún fire department, long forgotten by the authorities and staffed by hardworking citizens with a great vocation.

During that time, the great Cancún-Tulum highway was finally built, which sparked what became known as the "Riviera Maya," which today has more hotels than Cancún. It was built by a very controversial governor; your grandfather called him "tough governor," and in Cancún, he destroyed a group of professionals who owned the Convention Center project, believing they were partners of the previous governor, whom he neither liked nor respected. Unfortunately, he also destroyed the project for the great Cancún tower. Anecdotes such as the following were told about him:

The highly regarded chronicler of Cancún founded a newspaper that criticized the governor. The governor invited all the members, including the chronicler, to a dinner and told them: "You're attacking me a lot in your newspaper, and there's no economic way to settle with your editor. I want to tell you that I help my friends and I screw my enemies. Which side do you want to be on now? You're my friends now; you choose." They all gave him their shares in the newspaper.

On another occasion, at a meeting of the Business Coordinating Council, he said: "I gladly come to your lunches because you are my friends, but not because you represent so many people. You in the private sector do nothing but fight; you will never have the unity you need to be a political pressure group."

There are people who think he was a good governor, because during his term there was a degree of peace, the development of the Riviera Maya was triggered, and work was allowed.

In the end, he did not finish his term because he hid in Bonfil, where he was arrested, and Years later he was extradited to the United States on drug trafficking charges.

Everyone who went to jail with him was released. We never heard of any charges being brought against him, and although everyone speculated that his arrest was politically motivated, he was sentenced for money laundering for the Juárez Cartel, a charge he confessed to in New York.

Everything was difficult: there was only one gas station in Cancún, at the intersection of Kukulcán and Bonampak, which was insufficient. My dad says he had to wait in line for half an hour. The same thing happened to go to Tulum; there was only one gas station in Puerto Morelos. People said it belonged to Cozumeleños, and that's why they didn't allow another one.

It's important to note that Cancún was populated by couples who came with or without children, single men, and women who didn't come with families. Almost no one came with their parents, siblings, uncles, cousins, or friends. It was very difficult for the wives because they felt, and were, very alone. That's why they were so active in the committees; over time, friends began to replace the absence of close love and affection. The wives became friends with the mothers of their classmates, the husbands of their coworkers. It was undoubtedly a time of great integration.

It's also worth noting that they had no assets; they came with the hope of building one. Most succeeded, modest or not; but those who failed, those who returned with nothing, are almost never discussed. There were painful processes, and to this day, the Cancun middle class isn't very wealthy. But there's always work for everyone.

A phenomenon that reflects the great spirit that prevailed in Cancún in those years is the presence of two of the three major universities now located in Cancún.

The Lasallians organized a meeting of parents in which they were informed that La Salle University was interested in founding a high school in Cancún (at that time, there was no prestigious private university), but that they required land and seed capital for their continued investment. The community received the message and formed a committee of citizens willing to secure the land and raise the necessary funds. It is important to note that at that time, there was very little established local capital, and the middle class was just beginning to secure its jobs, businesses, and personal assets, but everyone made a tremendous effort. Through fairs, raffles, and various events, the goals were achieved, and now they enjoy not just one, but several universities for their children to study in Cancún. Anáhuac University followed a similar process, which speaks to the enormous spirit of unity and collaboration that existed at that time.

Not everything was easy for local investors; an example of this was the Nautibeach episode. Surely your grandfather told you the anecdote. The group of the engineer, a friend of your grandfather, built a very nice condominium on Isla Mujeres and on the day of the inauguration, the mayor of the island, who belonged to a very prominent family and owned a nightclub adjacent to Nautibeach—which was the name of the condominium—put some speakers on the roof at full volume and directed them toward the condominium. He kept them on for a week. The noise was unbearable; it was impossible to sleep or be in the building; a week later, the umbrellas on the palapas they had put up on the beach were burned. One day, your grandfather's engineer friend, talking with a group of fishermen, asked them why Isla Mujeres was so reluctant to develop, and one of them replied: "Engineer, we have nothing against development, but you must understand that we are poor, that we don't

"We can't participate as investors in any development, and I have no interest in my son becoming a gardener or a hotel waiter. I prefer him to be a fisherman, as it's a much more free profession. I believe it's better to be independent than to be subject to hierarchies that aren't always fair."

The argument omitted other factors that development brings with it, but its argument was certainly sound.

My parents were very happy during that time and miss it a lot; they say Cancún was "true paradise." It still seems that way to me, but they must have a reason to think that way.

Next to Market 28, a shopping center, La Fiesta, opened. It was made up of small houses. It was built by a very nice and friendly couple who knew everyone. They also opened Mauna Loa, a restaurant in the center of the tourist area where very pretty girls danced Hawaiian. One of them, incidentally, married the owner of the famous Ronaldi restaurant.

By this time, massive land speculation had already erupted. There was no way to buy land through Fonatur. If you applied for land, you were told there wasn't any, but that there were people who had applied for land and, since they couldn't meet the Fonatur deadline, they wanted to transfer their rights to purchase, because if they didn't comply, they would be fined. And they did transfer them, but if the official price was \$300 per square meter, they sold it for \$600, so a plot of land that a year earlier had cost \$6 million now cost \$12 million. And that was happening with land everywhere, as would soon happen with land throughout the Riviera Maya. The people who made money, in addition to their labor, actually earned from land speculation, which they bought cheaply at the time, and which multiplied its value—not as much as in Cancún, double, but much more. Later, buildings of more than five stories appeared, which was a very strict restriction; Nobody explained to us why those permits were issued to some and not to others.

When it emerged from the Hurricane *Gilberto crisis*, Cancún had just over 8,000 rooms and 200,000 inhabitants, not bad for a development that was barely 15 years old.

This is when the second stage of Cancun begins, which I call development and polarization, which goes from after *Gilberto* to the arrival of Hurricane *Wilma* (1988-2005). I remember, for some reason, going to a talk given by an engineer at a Coparmex luncheon. Your grandfather knew him, and he also attended. I think that's where I even saw him for the first time. The engineer said that Cancún had been created to generate jobs and that he predicted that by 2020 there would be 100,000 hotel rooms in the northern part of the state. It was a scandal; everyone thought it was impossible. It's 2017, and I think it's going to be possible.

Isla Mujeres has finally exploded and is booming. Cozumel has developed primarily through cruise ships, but since it doesn't generate many jobs, it has remained with a small population. What's failing to take off is the northern zone, because it can't break the vicious cycle of a lack of flights because there are no rooms, and no rooms because there are no flights, and they haven't been able to modernize the airport due to a long-standing communal land problem.

There was talk of an airport for Tulum, but due to conflicts of interest within the state's political sector, the idea was postponed and disappeared; in reality, it's not necessary today; perhaps it will be in the future.

During this period, infrastructure development was sensational. The airport grew and continues to grow, and work is underway to accommodate 30 million tourists a year. There has been no shortage of water or electricity; drainage and wastewater treatment coverage has been achieved.

Much of the Puerto Juárez neighborhood has been paved. Education coverage reaches 99%; private schools and universities have multiplied. There are nearly 20 large shopping centers and supermarkets. Puerto Cancún and the island's residential development have become more established. Between the tourist area and the city, there are no fewer than 3,000 high-end apartment condominiums. After *Wilma*, there are 400 daily flights during peak season.

By 2005, generations born in Cancún began participating in the economy. But a new problem arose for the founders: university students, whether they graduate here, from the Monterrey Institute of Technology, or the University of Puebla, are unable to find jobs, and many never return. Ninety percent of Cancún's income is linked to tourism, which is a major generator of employment, but not at a high level of technical level. There is no agriculture, livestock, or industry in Cancún, only tourism and services.

Polarization. This is perhaps Cancún's most painful problem, as it's a very noticeable phenomenon. We'll start by mentioning some of the "arguments" that have contributed to polarization.

1. The dispute between those who wanted to keep Cancun as a private preserve—and in 1988, before I met your grandfather, I was one of them—and those who wanted development.

2. The truckers. In the very beginning, there was a single transport company, Turicun, which held a monopoly on transportation. A group of Yucatecans invited morally sound people from the community to try to break Turicun's monopoly—the trucks that circulated there were a disgrace, dirty and old. The authorities granted permission, and the day the trucks tried to enter Kukulcán Avenue, the Turicun cooperative blocked the boulevard, and the police had to beat them out. It was the only time I saw the police act like that, but blocking the tourist zone is a mortal sin; we all live off it.

3. The dispute between *all-inclusive* hotels and restaurateurs. It turns out that many hotels suddenly became *all-inclusive*, like the Méditerranée, and it obviously included

Food was a universal trend in beach tourism, which, for tourists, represents a perfectly planned vacation at its best. It was a constant battle in the newspapers, which love lawsuits, because everyone wanted to know what was going on.

4. The *home port dispute*. A park group is approved to do a *home port*.

All the environmental studies had been approved, but the municipal permit for the earthworks, such as the waiting room, immigration, etc., was missing. Then, a very brilliant hotelier, who was doing great work in the City of Joy, which gave him great prestige, and a Yucatecan, who owned several hotels, launched a radio, television, and press campaign claiming that the cruise ship docks were destroying the hotel industry. Those who wanted to build the dock, and the shipping company, organized a trip to Miami, Puerto Rico, and three other Caribbean countries, which all three groups went to: those who wanted the dock, those who didn't, and the authorities at the time. All five countries raved about the benefits of the docks. Upon their return, the group that didn't want it published that the shipping company had bribed the authorities in those countries. From that moment on, the group that wanted it published a daily article entitled "*The Lie of the Day*," in which they refuted everything that had been published against them. In the end, those who didn't want to win won. And they won because those who didn't want to were those from Cozumel, who are very powerful and feared competition, which wasn't realistic. But those who were most affected were those on Fifth Avenue, as they would have many visitors, as well as the restaurants, taxi drivers, and the archaeological sites of Chichen and Tulum, since tourists get off in Cozumel and from there have to cross to visit them, but there are few because the sea crossing is very long. One has to imagine how many excursions there would be if the *home port had been built*.

5. The airport taxi drivers. The first dispute was with the vans, as the taxi drivers claimed it was unfair competition because the vans could accommodate eight people, not four as in each taxi. Then there were disputes with the trucks, and finally with the vehicles of the receiving companies, which wanted to receive individuals and groups with better service than that of the taxis. It was a classic dispute between a monopoly that refuses to give up its grip on power. The issue of taxi drivers in Cancún is complex. They are good people, but they are at the mercy of the authorities, who do not regulate fares because it is the best way to exploit their members. They are heavily exploited politically, and they also suffer the abuses of the fleets owned by the politicians in power.

6. During the polarization, a very controversial issue arose. A Mexican investor announced the multi-million dollar investment of a Chinese group in what was called Dragon Mart, which consisted of an immense shopping center, with stores that would display Chinese merchandise, directly from the manufacturers, and that would have a housing unit, for the five hundred or thousand Chinese who would come to manage the representations. These would exhibit not only for the Cancún markets, but also for Latin America and the United States. And the controversy erupted. The first reason they stopped them was ecological, which was totally unfair since that was land already affected by sascab mines and other exploitations. But the most curious thing was that there was no true analysis of pros and cons from the poi

from a sociological-migratory point of view, nor from an economic point of view for Cancun, since this project could have opened an immense market of tourist-entrepreneurs who, instead of going to China, would come to Cancun to locate the producers of the items they required.

It became, therefore, an environmental dispute.

7. Suddenly, news appears that Uber, the company that uses private taxi drivers and whose methodology allows for lower costs and increased safety, will open in Cancún.

The various taxi unions immediately reacted, arguing that they were both right and wrong: due to established vices, politicians who own fleets, bribes for inspections, union dues, license plate costs, bribes for infractions, problems with the spread of crime, etc., the cost of taxis, without fare controls, is very high. The beneficiaries are not the drivers, but the mafias that surround them, who do not allow reasonable prices. But for one reason or another, the drivers saw their source of income threatened, and vested interests mobilized them against the modernity that Uber represents, harming consumers.

One of the most complicated conflicts of all has been that of environmental groups against developments. Environmental fanaticism has halted many developments—in my opinion, unjustifiably, as it has never been supported with real studies, but rather with emotional judgments. I believe this is what has done the most harm to Cancún, and it has unconditional support from the press in Cancún, Mexico, and around the world.

By the time Hurricane *Wilma* hit, Cancún already had 20,000 rooms, and the most painful social phenomenon in Cancún occurred. During the lull in the hurricane's eye, which lasted for two days as the storm lingered, there was looting of businesses that had suffered damage. This was the "new Cancún." For Cancún's early founders, it was an awakening to a reality no one wanted to accept; what *Gilberto* saw as solidarity and unity, *Wilma* saw **fear and abuse**. *Wilma*'s damage was less severe, but the moral damage was much greater; there was nothing left but to accept the "new Cancún."

I call the third stage that of stabilization in progress.

For me, the old, middle, and new Cancún have always been beautiful: my beach days with my parents, my school friends, my wonderful fishing trips with my friend on Isla Mujeres, the happiness of my marriage to your mother, my wonderful honeymoon and graduate studies and my teaching at the University of the Caribbean, my life on your grandfather's ranch... everything has been a dream of a life. I have no nostalgia for the past; I have grown alongside Cancún, and the process has seemed logical and natural to me. The experiences and conversations with your grandfather matured and tempered my worldview and brought me the spiritual peace I lacked when I was young. I think that being born here, I didn't have as many expectations as those who arrived had; my development process has been more natural.

Cancún's development has continued, but this area has been characterized by rampant corruption among the politicians in power. I never believed it could reach such limits, but it's true of the entire country. The national press is filled with news of former governors being persecuted; there's talk of thefts amounting to hundreds of millions, and our state is among the five most named. These days, an internal trial has begun within the PRI, which, with the elections approaching, wants to cleanse its image of corrupt politicians. The same thing is happening within the PAN and the PRD, which view their party members as lepers, who "catch them," as my father used to say, in everything they do. He also used to say that leprosy is contagious; everyone is infected.

Development has continued, and the best new restaurant to open is Harris. I would say the Riviera Maya and Playa del Carmen phenomenon has been the dominant theme of that period. What's happened there is fascinating. 38,000 rooms have been built, more than 10 parks have been opened to tourism, and 20 or more cenote sites, including Pac Chen, which is run by a group of young people led by an uncle and nephew who have offered **very ecological tours**. Your grandfather liked them, because in Pac Chen they offered a *tour* in which the Mayans participated. But perhaps the most characteristic phenomenon is Playa del Carmen's Fifth Avenue, which began with a few restaurants and craft shops and has evolved into a street with magnificent shops and restaurants, increasingly sophisticated; from covering two blocks to more than 20, crossing Constituyentes to the south. It's impossible to describe that evolution; Every time I went, there was something new, or something old had been torn down to make way for something new. This street will become famous in the tourism world, and the wonderful thing is that no one planned it, no one designed it. Little by little, as the hotels grew, it developed. I recently went on a Sunday and ate at the new Harris, which, despite being on the second floor and expensive, was packed. Playa del Carmen is growing today at rates comparable to or greater than those of Cancún, and today I read in the newspaper that a new electoral district has been opened, meaning northern Quintana Roo will have four representatives, since the Cancún-Playa metropolitan area already has 1,050,000 inhabitants.

The other exciting phenomenon is that of affordable housing, Infonavit. Your grandfather worked on a development built by a family from Cancun, the same owners of the school where I attended high school, who are very hard-working and well-known people in Cancun. Up to 20,000 homes are built in the state each year, the majority in Cancun, but also in Puerto Morelos, Playa del Carmen, Akumal, Tulum, Carrillo Puerto, Chetumal, Cozumel, and Isla Mujeres. Aside from being an activity that generates jobs, it's a very important element of justice and social stability. The houses are sold very cheaply and the government subsidizes them at no cost to the buyer by 20%. These developments have urbanization: sidewalks, water, sewage, electricity, and they are required to have water treatment or be connected to existing plants. Infonavit has been a national miracle, having built 15 million homes in the last 50 years. If it weren't for that, we wouldn't have any.

I have an idea of what Mexico would be like. I believe that, along with Social Security, they are the two great national institutions that have given stability to Mexico and our state. These benefits and sources of employment are what can help Mexico and Quintana Roo move forward without social problems, despite the lacerating 50% poverty rate that has almost disappeared in Quintana Roo. Starting with your grandfather's town, which your mother says she barely recognizes anymore. All workers in Mexico have the right to these benefits. The tourist area is almost at capacity, fortunately, because Kukulcán Boulevard is already at its limit.

We must also mention the four major crises that Cancun faced:

- *Cyclone Gilberto.*
- On September 11, with the collapse of the Twin Towers.
- *Cyclone Wilma.*
- Bird flu.

In all four cases, Cancún was left without tourists. These were difficult crises. Negotiating with insurance companies over the consequential costs during the hurricanes was very tough. But the biggest problem arose with the avian flu, which practically emptied Cancún. Furthermore, there were two aspects to this: it was a case not covered by insurance, and secondly, banks were unwilling to lend, as there was a risk of an uncontrollable pandemic that would disrupt the global economy.

Your grandfather told me that at that time he was doing some work in the park of the group of the engineer, his friend, and one day when only two tourists arrived, he called a meeting with all the collaborators of the company, and told them the following: "As you know, yesterday two tourists arrived, and we are facing a very big crisis: first, because nobody knows how long it will last, there are all kinds of versions and uncertainties. Second, the banks don't want to strengthen the business, because they have the same doubts we do. Third, the company has to reduce its costs and expenses as much as possible to withstand the crisis. The partners' will is not to close the park and lay off staff, which, according to the law, could be done under emergency circumstances, but the partners' will is to withstand the crisis, if necessary, even with their own assets. But the only way to do this is to reduce the payroll by half, at all levels, while maintaining full payment of benefits, and anyone who, for personal reasons, cannot afford it can resign and will be paid according to the law." Everyone's reaction was to stand and applaud; not a single resignation occurred. Your grandfather told me that his engineer friend, with tears in his eyes, told him: "The solidarity of the employees is incredible. They are people who have commitments with their mortgage, with their car loan, with school tuition, some of them help their parents. Their salaries are being cut."

in half and applaud the decision,” to which Don Juan replied: “Engineer, don’t forget that some companies, faced with uncertainty, are laying off their workforce. People didn’t expect the company to show such solidarity with them. People understand, and they applaud this effort.”

The crisis lasted only three fortnights and full payments were restored.

All these crises should be seen as proof that Cancún can withstand all kinds of eventualities, and that each crisis has not only not sunk us, but rather we have emerged with much greater vigor.

In Cancún, the months of September, October, and November were known as *septiembre*, *octubre*, and *noviembre* when the season was low. Today, that trend has disappeared, and Cancún has four seasons: January-April, mid-high season with 90% occupancy; May-June, mid-season with 70% occupancy; July-August, high season with 95% occupancy; and September-December, mid-season with 70% occupancy.

We now know that the incorporation of 200 million Chinese and 150 million Indians has generated a current cross-border and overnight tourism rate of 1 billion tourists per year. Mexico receives 24 million, which is 2.4% of global tourism, and Cancún receives 10 million tourists per year, generating \$10 billion annually, which means Cancún must retain that 1% of global tourism and grow accordingly, which has been between 4 and 5% annually. But if it aspires to more, it must take into account that global competition for sea and beach tourism, as well as general tourism, has intensified. Mass tourism, in which Cancún is already immersed— *all-inclusive* hotels and other areas—has become universal, and now one finds it in every means of communication, such as subway billboards, advertising week-long *all-inclusive* trips to the beaches of Thailand, Vietnam, the Seychelles, Bali, Egypt, and in the Caribbean to the Dominican Republic, Punta Cana, Jamaica, Puerto Rico, Costa Rica, and the new addition to Cuba, which will be tremendous due to its novelty. All this, combined with the evolution of 300- and 600-passenger planes, allows these trips, including Cancún, to be offered for between \$700 and \$1,200 for a week, all expenses paid. This competition requires us to do two fundamental things: first, to increasingly offer superior service to tourism, and to constantly reinvest in innovation and provide the maximum number of services in trends, for example, adventure tourism, participatory tourism, eco-tourism, etc., and to elevate gastronomy, medical services, and other services, and to protect the destination from crime so that it doesn’t affect tourism. All of this is a permanent challenge for everyone: government officials, business owners, and workers.

A new agreement with the United States was recently implemented, which immediately liberalizes more air routes between that country and Mexico, and vice versa. New routes are being opened from American cities that did not previously serve Cancún and the airport.

is building what will become Terminal 4 to accommodate more planes, which will surely increase tourism from the main source, which is the USA.

And it is essential to invest increasingly in promotion, for which the funds from the Cancún Convention and Visitors Bureau, which collects a 3% lodging tax, should be allocated solely and exclusively to promoting the destination, and not left to the discretion of either the state or federal government. Furthermore, the federal government should consider that if tourism generates \$20 billion in foreign currency, 1% should be allocated to promoting and advertising Mexico, \$200 million, of which 1%, \$100 million, should be allocated to promoting and advertising Cancún, given that many competitive countries are doing so to promote their tourist destinations.

Fernando Martí, the city's chronicler, once told me that he believed Cancún had a very promising future as a "city of knowledge," as it already had the seeds of very important universities and growing connections with Latin America and the world, and that tourism and gastronomy had a bright future. This is confirmed: some universities are seeking investors to build their first developments for foreign student housing.

Servando Acuña has also been a major promoter of medical tourism to Cancún, both from the United States, due to its highly competitive prices, and from Central and South America; so there's another great market niche there.

One hospital has already begun this process. Galenia Hospital, in addition to being a high-level oncology center, built a hotel attached to the hospital with a focus on medical tourism.

On the other hand, Cancun can be a tourist base for Central America and for the Route Maya, which sooner or later will be a great tourist product.

After her father finished his presentation, Tere said:

'It seems incredible to me that in just one afternoon I could get such a clear picture of Cancún's history and the historical context in which it emerged. And with all the photographic archive you have and projected alongside your father's explanation, I not only have a mental image of how Cancún developed, but also a visual one.'

Ruben answered him:

"No more stories for this week, and tomorrow we're off on our big adventure off the ranch."

Turning to Javiercito, he said, "I'm going to take you to meet the whale shark."

Javier asked, "Is it a shark or a whale?"

—It's a combination. It's a shark because it's a fish, not a mammal like whales, and it's the size of a whale and eats like whales.

—And he doesn't eat men?

—No, it only eats plankton and is very gentle, it doesn't attack anyone.

"What's a mammal?" Javiercito asked, and his mother answered:

—Mammals are animals to which their mother gives milk.

—So we are also mammals like whales?

Ruben added:

"We're going to leave early on Friday on the ferry to Isla Mujeres. We're going to sleep there."

And the next day we are going to visit Contoy Island, where there are many birds.

"How many?" Javiercito asked.

Ruben replied: —I don't know.

Tere told Javiercito to let him finish.

"Well," said Javiercito, making a gesture.

Rubén laughed with pleasure; he was fascinated by Javier's gestures.

—Then we're going to swim with the whale shark.

Javiercito, who had already grown to trust Rubén enormously, said he wasn't going to swim with the whale shark because he was scared of it. Rubén reassured him by telling them he wasn't doing anything. He continued:

—Then we'll return to Isla Mujeres. We'll bring sandwiches to eat on the boat, but we'll have dinner at my favorite restaurant.

Javercito said without asking:

—Rolandi again —and Javier smiled.

—On Sunday we're going to tour the tourist area of Cancún, we'll go to the island and eat at Kukulcán, and on the way out, even if we make a slight detour, we'll visit the house where my grandparents and my mother lived.

"How cool," Javercito exclaimed.

—And to finish the trip, we will pass through Xoximilco Park, which after Xcaret is the most Mexican park in the southeast, and perhaps both are in all of Mexico, except, of course, the real Xochimilco and the archaeological sites and colonial monuments.

Tere smiled and again, as she said goodbye to Rubén, she kissed him on the cheek.

Early the next day, they left for Isla Mujeres on the ferry. Don Juan had agreed to wait for them early Sunday to go to Cancún and return them to the ranch. On the ferry, Rubén told them that they were going to be fishing with whale sharks by a fisherman who had participated in the Sailfish Tournament—along with someone known as "the Captain" and an engineer—and that they had won the tournament due to a mistake by the judges, who had given very high scores to the bonito, and they had caught dozens of bonitos and not a single sailfish. Rubén was very fond of him because his father sometimes took him fishing on the island.

They stayed in a condominium in Playa Norte, which he told Tere his grandfather had built. It had wonderful views and a wonderful beach. Tere thought it might be prettier than the ranch. She couldn't help but be amazed by so many wonders.

They rented a golf cart to, as Rubén told them, perform a ritual.

—Whenever I come to Isla I take a look around to see what's happened. From the first time I came with my dad to now is another world, but it has never lost its charm.

They headed south, and just past the inner bay of Isla, packed with boats, they turned right and Rubén told them: "You're going to see the restaurant that has one of the most beautiful views in the area."

They arrived at a nice little hotel and entered the restaurant. The view was indeed beautiful. As he took the menu, Javier said, "Rubén, his name is Rolandi!"

—That's right, Javier —Rubén replied—, and tonight you're going to meet another one with the same name, but right in the center of the island. We're going to walk to that one, since it's close to where we're going to sleep.

During lunch, Rubén told them that when he turned 18, his grandfather invited him to a seafood restaurant in the tourist area called Mocambo.

Grandpa ordered two cheladas, and when they arrived he put one in front of Rubén. Alicia

He said, "Dad, Rubén has never had anything to drink." And his grandfather replied, "That's why I'm giving it to him, so he can have his first drink now that he's of age, and so it can be with his parents, not with some lazy people who might get him drunk."

They left the restaurant and headed south. The entire road was lined with small hotels and one or two large ones. They arrived at what is called Garrafon, in Punta Sur; they got out and went into some Caribbean-style shops and then wandered around the sculpture garden. When they reached Punta Sur, Rubén told them: "This is the place in Mexico where the sun rises first. On the first

day of the year, many esotericists come here, they are like Uncle Jacinto. In all of the Mexican Caribbean, only here and in Tulum, which we'll get to know later, can you see the ocean from such a high mound."

They returned to the golf cart and continued north. They passed a subdivision of very nice houses on a hillside and Ruben told them:

—The first time I came to Isla, as a child, there was almost nothing here, just a sascab pit and a garbage dump.

They continued on and entered a simple town with colorful houses. They passed a pond with ducks, surrounded by a garden, and then an airport.

Rubén told them it had been abandoned for almost 50 years and had just opened for small private planes. They entered the town and swam at the wonderful beach. That night they went for an early dinner. Tere and Javier loved it. There were hundreds of incredibly colorful shops. Javier was amazed by all the handicrafts.

—Since the government named Isla a magical town, it has been a success —they Ruben commented.

"No wonder so many magicians see the sun rise," said Javiercito, and Tere and Rubén laughed.

They had dinner, discussing the day, and Javiercito tried the calzón and said, "I didn't know it was a big pizza empanada," and everyone laughed.

Suddenly a tall, blonde woman with very light blue eyes appeared, accompanied of two small children. Ruben greeted her with great affection and when he left he said to them:

—My dad told me that when Kaiulani was born—that's what this lady is called—her mother breastfed her for over four years. The waiter, an old man who had been working at the restaurant for over forty years, overheard the comment while serving the table and dared to say: —That's true. When Mr. Mike and his wife came to eat, the little

girl would run in, lift up her mother's blouse, and start breastfeeding in front of whoever was there.

Everyone laughed heartily.

They went to the hotel and Javiercito fell asleep quickly.

They looked out onto the balcony, there was a wonderful moon and the breeze was splendid.

Tere told him about Nicaragua, her parents, her husband, a guerrilla and hero, her

great friend Ortega, about how the revolution triumphed with the help of the United States and told him: "Now I realize that even though I lived with Javier for only two months, even though I knew him throughout my school years, I never felt like I knew him the way I feel like I know you. And then four years of absence from the United States were a long time."

In these beautiful days I have almost forgotten it and I feel no remorse for it.

For the first time he put his arm around her shoulders and said:

—Tere, life is full of surprises and changes, and my mother used to say that we have to learn that the past doesn't exist, it's already gone, it's only in our memories, and neither does the future, it's only in our dreams. That the only real thing is the present, and that's here and now, you, me, the child, and this wonderful night.

They stood silently contemplating the beautiful panorama, with the silver sea, and they went to sleep, she with Javiercito and he to his room.

Early the next day, Filiberto Sache, his friend, came by, and to Rubén's surprise, he was with his two sons, dark-skinned twins with hair bleached white by the sun, and sharp eyes. They immediately greeted Javier and began to play with him. Rubén said to him:

—I want to see Contoy. Which way do you think is best, going or returning?

—On our way back, because the birds have already left and in the afternoon we can see them returning to their nests.

And he added:

— I have ceviche and in the cooler I have tikin xic, so we can eat it in Contoy on the way back.

They went out and sailed past Contoy, and an hour later, as they saw Holbox in the distance, the first whale shark appeared, right next to the boat. Javiercito was scared stiff, but he didn't say anything because the kids were happy and he felt sorry for them. But he approached his mother and whispered, "I don't swim with those."

Minutes later, there were several sharks around, and the two boys jumped into the water and began swimming, filled with joy and happiness. Rubén realized why Filiberto had brought his children, because he saw how interested Javiercito was and watched, first seriously, then smiling, the friends playing and darting through the whale sharks. When Javiercito, now relaxed and smiling, said to Tere and the boy:

—I'm going swimming, are you coming with me?

"If you're going to swim, I'm going too," Javiercito replied.

The three of them jumped into the water, and moments later, Javiercito was with his friends, happy. He was a very good swimmer and wanted to touch them, but Filiberto had told them it wasn't possible, that the law prohibited it, and he didn't. An hour later, Filiberto, who had remained in the boat watching and looking after everyone, shouted to them:

—Let's go now. The time we could swim with them is up. The law doesn't allow more time.

"I see a lot of boats in the distance," Ruben said.

"They recently tightened the swimming laws, restricting proximity to only 40 boats. When one leaves, the other enters, so you can't stay for more than an hour, and only from 6 a.m. to 6 p.m. Night swimming with lights is prohibited, as it can disturb the sharks," Filiberto explained.

On the way back, he told them how they divided the boat permits: for Puerto Juárez, Isla Mujeres, and Holbox, 480 licenses, 40 per hour, 12 hours, since visiting whale sharks in one season was more productive for them than fishing all year round, and that helped improve sport fishing in the region. With good conservation management, everyone wins.

They arrived in Contoy with the proper permit and got off at the beach to eat. Filiberto prepared *tikin xic*, grilled fish on a double grill, and the ceviche he had brought. It was a wonderful day. The food was magnificent; the *tikin xic* was delicious, and Tere asked Filiberto what the sauce was made of. Like a good cook, he replied that it was made of annatto, olive oil, lemon, and other ingredients. She smiled and thought, "He's a good chef!"

Suddenly, hundreds of birds began to arrive. The children screamed and danced with joy. The birds made a great racket, and suddenly silence fell. Filiberto said, "It's time to go," and everyone returned almost silently, except for the children who were playing with the tablet Filiberto had brought. They arrived at Isla, said a fond farewell to Filiberto and the children, had dinner in their room, and went to sleep.

The next day they crossed on the ferry; Uncle Juan was already waiting for them. Rubén took them to Cancún. As they drove past, he explained: this is El Niño Beach; this is Puerto Juárez; this is Puerto Cancún. He showed them the first hotel in Cancún, where his grandfather worked, which at that time was called Playa Blanca, as well as the Villa de Pescadores and the Bahía. Javiercito commented that his grandfather had worked hard, and Rubén replied that he had worked for more than fifty years.

They arrived at La Isla Plaza and began to explore. They entered the aquarium, and Javiercito saw that there was swimming with dolphins and told Rubén he wanted to swim. Since they had left their swimsuits in the truck, they bought some at the store and went swimming.

Rubén felt the same way about dolphins as his grandfather; they approached him more than the others.

Javier asked:

"Why do they go with you more?"

And he said to him, smiling:

—Because I'm cool.

To which Javier replied:

—And me too.

Ruben added:

—Yes, but you're still little. If you keep your cool, when you grow up the dolphins will—
They will love you like they love me.

The coach, who heard the conversation, said:

— That's true, dolphins approach cool adults more often. There have been people who have to swim alone because the dolphins won't leave their side and ignore the others.

"That's what my grandfather was like. They wouldn't let go of him, and he had to arrive very early so they would let him swim with the dolphins alone," Rubén said.

The coach said to him:

"Hey, are you Don Juan's grandson?"

"The same," he replied.

—Your grandfather was a great guy. We all knew him, because he also delivered Dolphinarium II and other projects. It was at Dolphinarium II that we discovered that the dolphins loved him more than anyone. After finishing his projects, he would swim with the dolphins every day and say that nothing calmed him more.

Javercito said: —

When I grow up I'm going to be like your grandfather, I'm going to work hard and I'm going to swim with the dolphins every day.

The coach was confused, because he thought Javier was Rubén's son.

—Those of us who knew your grandfather have not forgotten him; he was a great man.

Ruben thanked him and said:

—Thank you, yes it was.

After The Island, Ruben said:

—Now we're going to the Kukulcán shopping center. For me, before they built the one in Puerto Cancún, it was the prettiest. It's also home to the restaurant where my grandfather ate the best steak in Cancún, according to him.

After eating, they continued their tour, and he continued showing Tere the hotels his grandfather had built: the Cancún Beach, the Cancún Palace, the Sun Palace, among others. As they crossed the Nizuc Bridge, he explained that at the beginning, water flowed in and out of the lagoon. When they reached the airport bypass, he told them he was going to show them the house where his mother lived with his grandfather. He arrived at a gate and honked his horn in a special way. A tall, dark-skinned man came out, opened the door, approached the window, and said, "Nice to meet you, Ruben, it's been a while. Come in."

Tere was surprised by a huge, very well-kept garden with many fruit trees.

—My mom really liked fruit trees, Rubén said.

They entered the house, which was much simpler than the ranch, but very pretty and full of photographs.

—Did I tell you she was very fond of photography?

"Yes," Tere replied, "but I didn't imagine it would be that big."

—He took thousands of photos, so many that they had to be digitized. He has 40 discs containing about 40,000 photographs. It seems like he took 10 photos a day his entire life. On the trip he took to Europe with my dad, before completing his graduate studies, he took 4,000 photographs in four months. It's incredible: 1,000 a month, more than 30 a day, and many of them very good.

They walked through them and she saw many of the town's characters. Rubén knew the names of all the people. It seemed to her that Rubén had a prodigious memory. He told Tere that when he went to town with his grandfather, he would introduce him to everyone, uncles, aunts, or cousins. He also asked him why he had so many relatives, and he replied that his grandfather had founded the ranch with the entire family named Chi. They walked around the house, looking at photographs, and then left. The dark-skinned man approached, and Rubén said to him:

—I didn't introduce you to Mrs. Tere and her son Javier.

"You're very pretty," he said, kissing her hand. "My nephew has good taste."

And you Javier, how old are you?

"Seven," he said very seriously.

—Rubén, come more often, you know you are loved.

—That's right, uncle; greetings to the aunt I didn't see.

Tere was surprised by the affection the old man had for her.

Already in the car, Rubén told him that he rarely saw him, only when he went to Cancún with his parents or his grandfather.

In the car Ruben said: —Well,

one last surprise.

"Which is it?" Javiereito asked.

—Xoximilco —Ruben replied.

Frowning, Javier asked, "What is that?"

—A surprise.

They arrived at the park just in time to board the last trajinera, and the party began. It was all music and joy. There was Veracruz mariachi music. Javiereito got excited and started dancing zapateado norteno with the boatman. They approached the food trajinera and were given Mexican snacks, and the trajineras continued. In each one, there was joy and celebration, and a wild drinking spree. Tere noticed that Rubén didn't have a single drink, but she happily drank two glasses of tequila. Rubén and Javiereito drank agua de Jamaica, which they liked a lot. It was a warm night, and they happily finished the pitcher between the two of them. The ride ended, and the boat arrived at the dock. They got out and got into the car, and Javiereito said:

"Now I really had fun!"

Tere and Rubén smiled with pleasure.

They returned to the ranch at night. It had been a long trip.

Javercito, excited, said:

—What a time I've had: I swam with whale sharks, with dolphins. How amazing, I can't believe it.

Tere added: "It

was two wonderful days, Rubén."

And giving him a kiss on the cheek, as was their custom, they went to sleep.

The next day, Rubén left early and returned at dusk. They had dinner and Javercito went to sleep.

Ruben said to Tere:

—The night is wonderful with the moon still bright. Let's go for a walk. There's something I want to tell you.

They walked south along the beach and back north. The breeze was gentle and cooled the night. Rubén walked back and forth in silence, and she respected that silence, sensing something important was about to happen. When they reached the southern mound, where the remains of her grandfather and mother lay, Rubén took her hands and said, "Teresa, will you be my wife?"

And Tere, without saying anything, hugged him and kissed him passionately, and said:

—There's nothing I want more in the world than that!

She didn't know she had given Rubén the first kiss on the mouth she had ever received. She saw Rubén turn toward the grave of his grandfather and parents, and crossing himself, he said, "Thank you, Lord, for this gift."

Tears flowed from both of them. They returned home in a state of bliss. Both of them were silent, not knowing what to say to each other.

When she arrived home she said:

—I'm going to tell Javercito. He replied:

—Don't wake him up, I don't want to scare him. Wait and we'll tell him tomorrow.

The next day they got up early and sat at the table. Tere, with a calm look, said to Javier: "My son, I want to tell you with all my love that

Rubén and I have thought about
get married.

Javercito turned to see Rubén and threw himself into his arms.

—So I'm going to be able to call you dad now?

Ruben answered him:

—It would be a great happiness for me if you did so.

Javercito ran out to the beach, where his gang of friends were waiting for him to play soccer, and shouted, "Rubén is going to be my dad! He's marrying my mom, and you're going to be my cousins." A commotion and shouting erupted, and they said, "Javier is now our cousin," and everyone ran out shouting to tell their parents. Half an hour later, there was a parade of uncles and cousins. Don Juan and Jacinto were happy, saying, "Little Tere is going to be my granddaughter."

Everyone was asking Rubén, "When is the wedding going to be?" To which Rubén replied, "Friday!" Tere asked, "So fast?" And he said, "Unless you don't want to." And she said, "Of course I do!" And Javercito shouted, "Of course he does, of course he does!" And Rubén added, "In the town of Ma'y Tab!" And seeing Tere, he said, "Unless you don't want to!" And she replied, "Of course I do!" And Javercito shouted again, "Of course he does! Of course he does!" And everyone clapped happily.

Over the next two days, Tere hardly saw Rubén at all. He was with Uncle Juan and Aunt Meche, completely tied up with preparations for the wedding at Ma'y Tab. On Tuesday night he came back happy because a well-known woman in the wedding services business had accepted the challenge, and although it was a bit expensive, it was worth it. Tere began to picture what it would be like when Rubén explained that it would be easy since they planned to roast 30 suckling pigs in barbacoa style —which would be the main dish—, along with 100 kilos of rice and the same amount of beans, also cooked with pork; 100 cartons of beer with 20 bottles each, and 100 cases of soft drinks; 100 bottles of aguardiente; 100 of tequila and 100 of rum, all of which would be set on the tables. Although no one really knew how many people would show up, they estimated 100 tables of 10 people each. The entire town was going to attend, and Rubén was worried that people from another town might 'crash' the party.

Aunt Meche ordered two tour buses, and Uncle Juan ordered two more for friends and relatives in Puerto Juárez, and another to transport uncles and cousins from the ranch. He rented the buses from a friend who founded one of the first, if not the first, travel agencies in Cancún.

Rubén told Tere, "I'm going to town early tomorrow and I'll come back for you in the afternoon, because the judge who's going to marry us, who's a cousin from the town who's older than me, asked me to bring all your papers. And I have good news for you: he agreed to let Javiercito sign as a witness despite his age."

When Javiercito was told at home that he was going to be a "witness" at the wedding, he asked, "What's that?" Rubén told him it meant he agreed to let his mother marry him. The boy exclaimed, "Yes, I agree, and I'm very happy!" Everyone laughed. The wedding was scheduled for Friday at one in the afternoon.

Early Thursday, Rubén gave everyone homework, and at breakfast he said to Tere:

I want to dedicate this day to the memory of my mother. I wanted you to first have the vision of my grandfather and my father so that you could understand my mother's vision more clearly, since she speaks of more everyday and feminine themes, of women and mothers. And they settled into the study. That day Javiercito, although he ate with them, spent most of it with Jacinto, whom he began to call great-uncle—which Jacinto loved. And in the

afternoon, as was his custom, playing soccer and swimming in the sea. He even fished a little and caught a barracuda, which he ran to show them.

Ruben's mother began by saying:

When I saw the recording your father wanted to give you when you were 18, I thought it would be right for you to also have my story so you could complement your family's life. I know that living together, being together almost every day for these 18 years, has given you a glimpse into my entire life, but I'll do my best to describe the time before your arrival and also the time we have happily spent together.

You know that my mother died when I was born, and that I was raised by Jacinto and Lencha and breastfed by Lucía, who became my nanny and later helped Uncle Jacinto and Lencha.

Until I was two, I have only vague memories, but even then, the heat of the windless nights bothered me. My first memories began to manifest in the arms of my father, who came to see me every Saturday. Later, I learned that to come on Saturdays, sometimes arriving at night when I was already asleep, he had to ride horseback from the gap that connected Cancún to Tulum, and that he would travel the 30 kilometers for up to six hours. Since he would detain people on Saturdays, I couldn't leave before 3:00 p.m.

My first clear memory is when I was three years old, when my father took me to the cenote to teach me how to swim. More than one person had drowned there, and he was terrified that something might happen to me. There were three cenotes in town; the largest and most beautiful was the one where everyone swam, even the children. Then there was the one with running water, smaller, where the women washed clothes and bathed with soap once a week, and where the children four and older went swimming almost daily. And the third, a small one near the river, but upstream. My father said it was the one where we drew water. My aunt Lencha brought the water early in the morning, and from the age of four, I brought it in the afternoon, after swimming in the cenote. That one was only for washing dishes. I also threw corn to the chickens in the afternoon, in the backyard. On Sundays we spent the entire morning in the cenote, until I learned to cross it and back, alone, and to dive in for ten seconds.

I remember that I was afraid of vipers, scorpions, and bats. Since we were children, we were taught to stay away from them, but it wasn't long before someone was stung or bitten by some vermin. Uncle Jacinto sucked their wounds and gave them herbs, but a little friend of mine died from a viper bite. These were the nauyaca, which we called four noses because of the little beaks sticking out of its snout, and the rattlesnake, which was less dangerous, because when we got close, it would just twitch its tail and rattle, and we would run out to warn our parents, who would come quickly to kill it with

machete; sometimes they found it and sometimes they didn't, but the nauyaca didn't make any noise and went into backyards, and the parents killed it. One bit my dog, whom my uncle Jacinto called Firulais. That's when I realized how dangerous it was.

There were many children in the village; each family had more than four, not counting those who died of dysentery, but also from many infections.

Another very unpleasant memory I have is that once, while some friends and I were playing near Don Beto's store, two men started fighting with machetes. The clashing sounds were so loud that the children ran into their houses. I remember the noise could be heard in the distance. My father said it was a fight over women.

At six years old, I started elementary school, which had two classrooms: one had grades 1, 2, and 3, and the other had grades 4, 5, and 6, so one had children from 6 to 9 years old and the other from 9 to 12. I was there for the entire first year, as soon as they added four more classrooms, meaning we had six, a principal's office, and bathrooms for boys and others for girls.

Also that year, the first motor vehicle we ever saw entered the town: my dad's pickup truck. The dirt road from Puerto Morelos to the Mérida-Cancún highway, and the one-kilometer stretch of dirt road from the town to the highway, had been built.

From then on, my dad came almost every weekend. Then they installed the light poles and put lamps in the streets, and the houses were connected. That weekend, when they connected the electricity, my dad brought a television. We loved it, but we didn't understand it because we didn't speak Spanish, but Mayan, and there were no programs in Mayan, but my aunt Len-cha and I loved the cartoons.

Then they introduced drinking water and installed a tap in every house. We no longer had to carry water in the morning and afternoon. My aunt and I were happy; they also built a "communal laundry," since the women loved to gossip while doing laundry. In the afternoon, after eating, even though they had basins in the house, they preferred to wash in the communal laundry.

Then my dad brought a concrete mixer, and he sent a truckload of gravel and one of sand with his friend Legislaio, as he was called. He bought material from him with his trucks from the construction sites, and he asked for one of each item a week. Legislaio was from the town and did it with pleasure, and my dad hired an officer, who organized with the town to build sidewalks.

And then my dad would bring two large water tanks in his pickup truck every week. He called them septic tanks, and they were placed there to receive water for the bathrooms many of us were starting to build. My dad built a very nice one, which had a shower, toilet, sink, and hot water, since he put a heater and a water tank above the bathroom. The water workers built a very tall water tank, into which they poured water from one of the cenotes, and they installed an electric pump that brought it up to the tall tank, and that's how water reached many homes, albeit with difficulty. He also bought a gas heater and some tanks, which he carried back and forth in his pickup truck.

Our house was the first to have everything, along with Don Beto's and the school. Since then I bathed every day before going to school, and I liked it very much,

Even though I sometimes wore the same clothes, my aunt said there was no way I was going to wash them every day. At first, she didn't want to use the stove, but she learned how to use it. When my dad came, he would still sometimes light the stove, because he said tortillas made with anafre tasted different, and it was true. To this day, I can taste the difference.

The day after the breach was opened, three trucks arrived: the one with beer, the one with soft drinks, and the one with Bimbo bread and the gansitos. The next day, Don Beto announced that everything would cost half as much as before; it wasn't half as much, but the price did go down.

In just one year, in 1977, everything in town was different, and it seemed to me that everything was better. Some things had changed: we children hardly ever played in the street at night because we watched television; we went to the cenote less, only to play and swim, because we now bathed at home; my father came earlier each week, and sometimes he wouldn't leave until dawn on Monday morning, since he arrived in Cancún in a little less than an hour. Don Beto complained because a van had arrived that took women to the market in Cancún every week, and he sold less, and he had to lower his prices on canned goods and preserves. A fruit and vegetable stand appeared, which hadn't been there before. That's also why the food changed a bit.

Many people said that everything had changed, those who worked outside came more followed, and although it is true that there were more fights, I never heard of another one with machetes.

Today I think civilization arrived suddenly: in one year, the town changed from being an indigenous Mayan village to a modern town. It's incredible that this could happen, and that things that hadn't changed for hundreds or thousands of years could change from one moment to the next. My father used to say this was because of the miracle of Cancún.

School was a lot easier for me, as it basically involved learning how to write, read, some arithmetic, and Mexican history. It was easy, and my childhood passed quickly and happily in the village. I learned to speak Spanish, which I loved, and I liked understanding television. I explained the programs to my Aunt Lencha; she never learned Spanish. Uncle Jacinto learned a little, but he didn't like speaking it and never liked television. He said it put too many ideas in his head that disturbed him, and that it aired a lot of news that didn't interest him. He was the opposite of my dad, who always listened to the news. Of course, on Saturday nights he would go have a beer with Don Beto, except now, instead of a battery-powered radio, he had a television. My dad said that with Don Beto on his radio, he began to understand that there was a very interesting world outside the village. He learned Spanish at the little school the government had built for him, prefabricated, they said, in 1950.

One day, when I was about 8 years old, I visited Cancún. It turns out I had a stomach ache and my uncle was giving me a cold. When my dad arrived and saw me lying down, he didn't say anything, he picked me up and said to Don Juan: "Juan, let's go to Cancún quickly, to see the doctor with the girl"—it was in 1978, on vacation—and we arrived at the doctor's in downtown Cancún, which seemed like a huge city to me. The doctor examined me, gave me something to drink, and said to my dad: "Take these pills for four days, and don't worry, Don Juan, you'll be fine." Later I found out that he knew him, because he used to take his children to him when they were sick or had accidents. He was a doctor for both the poor and the rich.

The same. My dad didn't leave town during those days, because he said his brother Jacinto was capable of not giving me the pills. On Tuesday, he had to leave, but not before telling Uncle Juan not to leave, "Until the girl takes the fourth pill." I was already fine when he left.

During those years, we went to the ranch with my grandfather almost every other weekend. I'll never forget the first time he took me and I saw the ocean. I remember staring at it for I don't know how long, and my dad wouldn't let anyone near me: "Leave her alone, she's contemplating the ocean, she'll never forget this moment." And so it was. I was pulled out of my contemplation when some dolphins started jumping. When I turned around, my dad was standing next to me, and I asked him what they were, and he said, "They're dolphins, my little girl, the most beautiful and friendly animals in the sea."

Then, during the fourth-grade school break, my dad came over one day with a lady called Meche and said, "This is Professor Meche. She's a teacher at the school where I want you to go to for your secondary school, called Británico. She's going to start coming here on Tuesdays and Thursdays to keep you updated on your studies so that when you get to Cancún you won't be behind." She hugged me and kissed me. I loved her from the start, and she said, "Call me Meche," and I called her Aunt Meche.

My dad told me to show Aunt Meche around town, and we set off happily, hand in hand. I took her first to the cenote, which was my favorite thing, then to the laundry, then to school, and she asked me, "Do you like it?" I replied, "Yes, a lot. I love studying." She said we'd gotten along really well, and then I took her to Don Beto's store. We ordered a popsicle, which they'd never had before, and a soda. We sat at a table with an umbrella that Don Beto had set up. The weather was beautiful, and we started talking. She told me she was from Mérida, that her parents lived there, that she lived alone in Cancún, and that my dad had helped her get started in Cancún. Then she said to my dad: "So that she becomes more familiar and loses her fear, I suggest you take her out to eat on Sundays," to which my dad replied that not every Sunday because he wanted her to see her grandfather, the cousins from the ranch at least once, but he told her that when he could, he would do what she suggested.

From that day on, my dad would take me to lunch with Aunt Meche on some Sundays. Sometimes my aunt would invite a friend who had a daughter so I could meet other girls, and she also took me to the girls' parties she was invited to. We would go to the movies and she would meet up with friends; we would go to the Cancún Fair, and I would also meet up with friends who had children. Sometimes she would invite married couples with children to my grandfather's ranch, where everyone had a great time at the ocean and the beach, and my dad would prepare delicious meals of lobster, shrimp, and fish, which he bought at Pelícanos in Puerto Morelos. We would go to Cancún to eat at Chokos & Tere for lobster, and Calamar for seafood. One night, she took some of Aunt Meche's friends and I to Maxim's. We ate Yucatecan food at La Habichuela. We also went to the Blanquita movie theater and to Parque de las Palapas. That's where my Aunt Meche asked my dad's permission for the first time and took me to church. It was Sunday and there was mass and we heard it. I didn't understand anything, but I liked seeing the

People who were silent and knelt like Uncle Jacinto when he asked for rain, and made the sign of the cross like he did. I knew how to do it like him and imitated the others.

I told her that my dad had never told me I was going to Cancún until that day, and that I was a little worried because I'd already been to Cancún, that I'd been to the doctor once, and that it seemed too big and that all the cars and trucks scared me a little. She told me, "Don't worry, we'll talk about it later, and I'm sure you're going to love it." That was how it went through the whole of fifth year, but about halfway through, she asked my dad if she wanted to go three times a week. Towards the end of the year, one day while we were eating at home, Aunt Meche asked my dad why he had decided that I should study all of primary school in the town instead of taking me to Cancún for elementary school. He said quite naturally, taking my hand: "I wanted to keep her here for 12 years, because I wanted all the families of the town, their Mayan language, and the customs of good people to be engraved in her heart. So that she will never forget, so that she will always remember the town where her mother died and that was founded by her grandfather and where I was born. I want her to feel that her roots are from here, even though the trunk and branches are already growing elsewhere." Aunt Meche said: "I understand, Don Juan," and she smiled at me and said: "Did you hear your father?" Over the years, she has reminded me of those words on more than one occasion. Then she said to my father: "Don Juan, I am going to suggest that this year, my little girl Alicia's last—it was the first time he told me, and he would always call me my dad, my little girl—she go to Cancún every week."

When we were leaving Mass, my father was waiting for us and said to Aunt Meche, "Just don't give me a hard time." And she replied, "What do you think, Don Juan?" And they laughed. I didn't understand, but I didn't care.

That's how the months of my senior year passed, living in the town and going to the ranch and Cancún, which I had completely lost my fear of. I learned Spanish perfectly, spoke it like a Mayan, and had no particular accent. One day, returning from Cancún, passing through the Bonfil neighborhood, my father pointed to a long fence and said, "This is going to be your home, my daughter, now that you come live here." I told him I wanted to see it, but he said it wasn't ready yet. I knew my father's tone of voice when he said something definitive, and I didn't insist. I said, "Okay, Dad, whenever you want."

At school, we studied the conquest, and that was a problem for Don Beto at the store, because everyone started calling him "gachupín." Especially the children. I never told him because he got really upset and said he was more Mexican than pulque, but we didn't understand him, because in the village, even after the progress, we didn't even know about pulque. What did arrive were some delicious little cans of coconut water, but they were expensive.

It wasn't until I started going to Cancún that I realized how poor my town was, especially before all the benefits of civilization came in. How many malnourished children there were, how many died. But then, since the townspeople worked in construction and gardening, they and their families had Social Security, and when

When they got sick, they were taken to the hospital. They also went to the hospital to give birth. I thought: "If that had existed when I was born, my mother would still be alive today, and I would have so many siblings, like everyone else in town. How lucky those who have siblings to take care of each other are."

At that time, we all had sores from mosquito bites, which became infected and were treated well by Uncle Jacinto. Also, the children who didn't eat well were fat, so sometimes my dad would give some food to their parents to give to them. Later, in the village, they started giving us school breakfasts. I had breakfast at home because Aunt Lencha made me a delicious breakfast, and I gave my school breakfast to Lupita, my friend with whom I played the most, so she could give it to her little brothers who were fat. They were very poor; she didn't have a fat belly, so my dad allowed me to eat with her at home, and I would give her something for her little brothers, who didn't go to school. Later, the government opened a store called Conasupo, which sold things much cheaper than Don Beto, but it didn't have everything. Don Beto stopped selling what Conasupo sold because he said it was "unfair competition." Then they told him he was a Spanish loan shark, and he would get very angry and say, "Let's see if that store gives you credit like I do." They responded, among many other things, that he only gave credit to rich people, but we all appreciated Don Beto.

And the long-awaited day of moving to Cancún arrived. It was a Sunday, and I spent all Saturday saying goodbye to my uncles, cousins, and friends, as well as to Uncle Jacinto and Lencha, who were going to live with Grandpa Jacinto, who was already quite old and needed some care, since Uncle Jacinto had less work due to the progress he made. So that day we all left, and a widowed aunt with her two older daughters stayed at the house. They said her husband had been killed by a jaguar in the cornfield, but Jacinto said no, that when he saw the body, the wounds weren't from a jaguar but from a machete, and that it had probably been some kind of revenge for a fight between women.

Some time after I told my dad what I thought about the changes in the town with progress, he said to me: "Look, my daughter, that's why you see me angry when people complain about the growth of Cancún and environmentalists block and impede projects that bring progress; progress generates jobs, and work is the only way to dignify human beings. Never listen to the demagogues and liars who talk about solving the problem by taking from the rich and giving to the poor, because those who work can become rich, and those who don't, can't. Where do you think all the money that brought progress to our people came from? It came from the taxes of all of us who work, not from the pockets of politicians who boast with their phrases 'in my government we will bring social justice,' as if they put the money out of their pockets; we even pay their salaries. You must be careful, my little girl. Power and money, when you don't understand what they're for, pervert people, and unfortunately It happens all the time. Don't let it happen to you."

We left Uncle Jacinto in a small house just like the ones in town, because that's what he'd asked my dad to do. He said Uncle Jacinto had said, "If you come out with your progressive stuff and it doesn't work the same way, I won't move."

We said goodbye to Grandpa and Uncle, and Grandpa said, "I hope that now that you're going to the big city, you don't forget about us." I responded, crying, "Grandpa, I swear that never happened, and never will." We were always there for him until his death, as were Uncle Jacinto and the uncles and cousins in the village.

We arrived at the house in Bonfil, which I hadn't seen before, and I had a wonderful surprise: it had a huge garden. "It's like two hectares," my father said, "that's why I didn't build it in the city, because land there was very expensive and there weren't any large spaces. Here I bought cheap and I feel like I'm at my father's ranch, but without the ocean." My Aunt Meche was waiting for us and had prepared a delicious meal for us; the cook was my Aunt Tencha, who had opened a small restaurant in town, but later left because she wanted her children to study in Cancún, and she, her husband, and their children lived in one of the small houses my father built at the entrance to the property. Tencha's husband, my uncle, was the night watchman; my father said that with him at the gate, no scoundrel would get through. My dad had put up a roll of barbed wire on the fence, which was about three meters long, and when I told him I didn't like it, he said, "Me neither, but I want to protect my greatest treasure." I knew what he meant, and I hugged him and kissed him.

I loved the house; it was simple but beautiful, with an arched terrace in front, and six bedrooms with bathrooms. I asked him, "Why six, Dad?" and he replied, "Whatever comes up, daughter." Uncle Vladimir's oldest daughter, the other night watchman at the door, was also in the house. She hadn't wanted to study; she was 18, and she cleaned the house, and my dad gave her a bedroom to sleep in with me. She spoke Mayan and very little Spanish, and that was a good thing, because she and I always spoke Mayan.

Aunt Meche told me one day: "Tomorrow is your first day of school. Your dad decided that you would attend secondary school with me at the Británico High School—something I already knew. She had even taken me to meet him beforehand so I could get a feel for what he was like. I'm coming to get you, and I'm also going to bring you back." That lasted six years of middle school and high school.

My adaptation to school was very fast; my Spanish was like any other child's, and I loved studying. In one of the bedrooms, my father built me a private study with a television, cassette player, CD player, radio, computer, everything, and I was happy studying there. My aunt began taking me to friends' parties with her; some thought she was my mother because she took me everywhere, and my father divided the weekends, one with my grandfather, whom he let me bring one or two school friends who loved the ocean. When my grandfather died, Aunt Meche invited some married couples with schoolchildren to the ranch. They were happy and were always surprised to learn about my Mayan roots, along with Don Jacinto and the uncles and cousins who came with us to swim in the cenote and the ocean.

During that time, I started getting to know the people of Cancún, especially the parents of my school friends. I always got first place in school, and the principal

He used to use me as an example, which I didn't like, but no one bothered me because my uncle Juan waited for me at the school gate and I scared them. They told me I was the only one who had a bodyguard, and I got upset and told them I wasn't a bodyguard, that he was my uncle. One day a boy said to me: "Don't tell me that Indian patarrajada is your uncle." I wanted to hit him, but I didn't because Aunt Meche and my dad had told me that a girl should never fight with anyone. Although I didn't really understand what "Indian patarrajada" meant, until one day I asked my dad. He asked me: "Where did you hear that?" I never told lies, but I knew that if I told him the truth, he would do something, and I answered: "I heard a boy say it," which was true. My dad told me: "Look, my little girl, many people have what are called 'complexes.' They feel inferior because they are less intelligent than others and they look down on others, and believing themselves superior makes them feel good. Never listen to them and try to stay away from them."

I also liked to play basketball; there was only one court and we played kids and girls together, because the school was what they called mixed and we were all very happy.

When I finished high school, I got very good grades, and it was my 15th birthday party. My dad didn't want to have it in town because he said town parties always ended in chaos. It was very rare for my dad to use rude or vulgar words, which my aunt Meche did, but my dad used that expression a lot. He would say, for example, "Our problem is that all Mexicans, without exception, are a mess," and he would laugh.

My 15th birthday party was at the ranch. Some of Aunt Meche's friends from Cancún attended, because my dad decided not to tell the town, saying that if he invited one person, he had to invite 300. But all my uncles and cousins from the ranch did come. He set up a big tent on the soccer field and brought two very nice little restroom vans; there were about 30 tables of 10 people each. I told him I didn't want a waltz, but I said that for two reasons: I didn't like it, and my dad didn't know how to dance; he loved the idea.

It was a great party; some ended up in the pool dressed, and those who brought swimsuits—my aunt warned them—went into the ocean. Everyone was amazed by the palm-lined causeway and the beauty of the sea. It was 1985.

When everyone had left, my dad told me, "Your Aunt Meche and I have a surprise gift for you for your grades. Your Aunt Meche is taking you to Disneyland." I was happy; I watched Disney movies in my study. He also told me, "My daughter, since your school doesn't have high school yet, you're going to study at La Salle, which I think is the best—and they were opening classes that year. With your grades, there was no problem getting you in."

I was fine with it, but what really hurt was that I wouldn't be with Aunt Meche, who was like my mom, the sister I never had, and my friend. She noticed and said, "Don't worry, I'll see you every day one way or another; and besides, the two weekends you're in Cancún, I'll spend them with you, your dad, and Don Juan." "Three weekends," my dad interrupted, "the girl has to spend more time in Cancún to get over her country bumpkin vibe." And we all laughed.

The trip to Miami and Disney was wonderful. My Aunt Meche was already familiar with the city because she had gone with some friends who used to go shopping in Miami. She wasn't able to buy much on that trip, but for ours, my dad gave her a lot of money and said, "Buy the girl everything she wants. I want her to be the best-dressed girl in high school." The day arrived, and Dad and Uncle Juan took us to the airport. My dad had arranged my passport and travel papers, and there were no problems. We brought two suitcases, one very large and one a little smaller, and a few clothes, since Aunt Meche had told me not to bring much, saying we'd buy only the bare necessities there.

Miami seemed like the greatest city in the world to me; it was my first trip abroad, and I'd only been to Mérida and Campeche, where my dad took me on a vacation Aunt Meche didn't want to go on. But we didn't see much of Miami, since we spent the four days shopping. We visited Bar Harbour, which was the most beautiful mall we'd ever seen, and Aventura Mall; we spent a whole day in each of them, although one day we went to Parrot Jungle, which I loved and reminded me of a park in Cancún because of the macaws. It was hilarious. My aunt bought me everything, from shoes to hair accessories. My dad had built a huge closet in my bedroom, and I wondered why it was so big; now I understood. We had to buy another suitcase because the ones we had weren't enough. Aunt Meche told me, "Now, like my friends, the ricottas from Cancún, I'm going to let loose." When I asked her how much my dad had given her to spend, she smiled and said, "Everything." We left our suitcases at the hotel and

went to Disney with just one. My first impression was wonderful, because my dad asked my aunt if we could stay at the hotel where the train passed. I thought it was wonderful. He also asked my aunt if the first park we visited would be Epcot and its pavilions of the future, especially the sphere. I don't know how my dad knew so much about Disney. But he did; he knew everything without ever having left Mexico. At Epcot, I was amazed and couldn't stop contrasting that wonderful world, with all its images etched in my mind, before that year of progress, and I thought: "How happy all my little cousins would be if they could travel and visit this."

The next day we went to the magical world; we went on all the rides and we both screamed like little girls. My aunt liked Pirates of the Caribbean the most, and she told me about when her parents took her to Campeche, precisely for her 15th birthday celebration. That city had a fort to defend against pirates, and that it sparked her imagination, and she'd read a lot about them. It was strange that she talked about it because she never talked about her past. My favorite was Aku Tiki, a small pavilion where all kinds of bird-like dolls talked and sang songs. Despite the lines, I wanted to see it twice. Then we saw the parade, where Mickey Mouse and Mimi appeared, I never knew if she was his girlfriend, his wife or what, and Donald Duck and his nephews, and Pluto and all the characters that in the town, when progress came, we saw on the television that my dad brought us and on Don Beto's, at night, with all our friends.

We would gather around to watch it, since many didn't have a television, and Don Beto would say to us: "As soon as the drunks arrive, they'll leave, because they're the ones I live off of," and he would laugh. But the one I liked the most was the park called Animal Kingdom, and especially a safari in a truck. When your dad and I visited Africa on that wonderful honeymoon trip your grandfather gave us, I would tell your dad, who had never been to Disney, that the photo safari we took in Africa was just like the one at Disney.

Another park I loved was Sea World, which had all the sea animals.

We had a blast, as Aunt Meche would say, and we returned to Miami, slept, and the next day we took the plane back. At the airport, I saw her arguing at the counter; in the end, she took out some money and paid. I asked her what was wrong, and she angrily replied that they had charged me excess baggage. On the plane, I was nervous about going through customs, but when I arrived, a cousin from the town was at customs—one of the first to leave, and who knows how he got to be a customs officer—and he winked at me and let us through without a problem. When my dad greeted us, he said, "Yes, he's the son of your uncle Gilberto Chi, who was one of the first I took from town, and he left with his son too, Gilberto, who studied and became a customs officer. I told his dad you were coming and recommended you." And I thought, "My dad is involved in everything." Once we got home, even with all the clothes I bought, the closet wasn't full, and my dad said, "You'll see."

High school was sensational; I enjoyed it immensely. Many of my classmates came from the British School. The school was on the edge of the jungle, and packs of monkeys would arrive and make a huge fuss. It was a time when we were all friends, all the parents knew each other, and Aunt Meche knew everyone. We went to everyone's parties, in the tourist area and in the city. At the end of high school, one Sunday when my dad had a difficult job at a construction site, my Aunt Meche took Uncle Juan and me to dance at the Terraza Peraza. The whole of Cancún went there, and it was a great atmosphere. My uncle was attentive the whole time; he didn't dance, like my dad. My aunt and I danced all the time, and if they didn't kick us out, she and I would dance. It was a lot of fun. But my dad wasn't entirely convinced and said it was great that we had taken Juan. I shared first place in school with a young man who was always like me, first in his class. **They said that a 9, given to him by a second-grade teacher who said he only gave a 10 to God, was the only 9 in his entire academic career since kindergarten.** He'd always gotten 10s. He had a sister I really liked because she was very mischievous; he was very serious and quiet, unlike his sister.

From there, I continued studying at the university. I studied Systems Engineering because everything related to computing fascinated me. History repeated itself, and I was the best student. That time was different. When I turned 18, my dad bought me a car, and Uncle Juan taught me how to drive. He said I was the best apprentice he'd ever had, because he taught all his nephews and nieces who didn't want to study. From then on, I went to school in my car, and when I went out with Aunt Meche, I drove. When I went out with my dad, I didn't, because Uncle Juan always drove. The car didn't change my life much, because I liked it.

I spent a lot of time at home and studying in the afternoons, but it allowed me to see Aunt Meche more and sometimes go out with her for coffee or to visit some friends.

I consider myself to have chosen a very good profession, and my life during that time was very peaceful. Many of the things I experienced from the age of 18 to 23, when I graduated, and from the age of 23 to 25, when I completed my master's and doctorate degrees, from 1988 to 1995, are also described in the writings you have from your grandfather and your father. It was during that time that I became aware of your grandfather's moral strength and will to work, whom I admire and respect.

For him, as for me, the change was wonderful and truly dramatic.

For most people in Cancún, being here was the great adventure of creating a new city, but they came from already established, modern cities. My father and I, and many others from the Puerto Juárez neighborhood, came from towns where the way of life was almost medieval, and in a single generation, we almost entered the 21st century. The century in which all the revolutions of revolutions had already passed. It was like a miracle, and I loved studying as he loved work, as he did my town and the entire Chi family. Your father said that of the teachings of Christ, whom he admired as a prophet, the one he liked most was to love your neighbor as yourself, because he found it difficult to love those he didn't know, although he also understood that the teaching meant that the other is like you.

When it came to religion, I wasn't like my father or my Aunt Meche. I never had any worries about it. I found peace and tranquility in church, even though I was Protestant. As your father said, I understood God as something internal, and I realized that my father was a man of profound peace. Your father, being the idealist that he was, loved all of humanity, perhaps less so politicians. My father loved his entire family and helped anyone he encountered. They both enjoyed great spiritual peace in their adult lives, like me. In my moments of doubt, I went to church like Aunt Meche and prayed to the Virgin of Carmen, who was always my favorite, or I asked my father and later my husband, and I also learned to ask my computer, where I found answers to everything.

Of the modern world I suddenly discovered that year in 1976, when civilization suddenly arrived in the town, and then in 1982, when I came to Cancún, what amazed me most was the air conditioning everywhere; I was fascinated, and am fascinated, by the fact that with the touch of a button I can change the atmosphere around me from hostile to pleasant and comfortable. I still remember my sleepy nights as a child during the summer months in the village, and almost all year round because of our tropical climate; it's wonderful.

I learned to love knowledge and culture, reading and computer research.

I was amazed by Google and its maps of the world and its cities. In the latest update of

In 2015, the town and its streets appeared for the first time. I couldn't believe seeing my house in a photograph from space. It had grown a lot, but I recognized it perfectly, as to this day we spend some weekends in the town with the family. It made me laugh a little when people would say, "I'm proudly from Quintana Roo," and I was pleased they said it, but we, the Chi family, were truly proud to be natives of Quintana Roo. My father said it was with great honor.

What can I tell you about restaurants? Every month a new one opened, and they were always better. My father, Aunt Meche, Don Juan, and I were all big eaters, and we discovered that the hotels had wonderful restaurants that locals don't normally visit. The breakfasts at the Ritz, the *brunch* at the Fiesta Americana, the dinners at the Marriott, were and are delicious. I don't know why, except for my Aunt Meche, who had gained a little weight, the Chis, no matter what we ate, we didn't gain weight. I hope the same thing happens to you, because I never exercised or dieted. I don't know where we Mayans' food goes. Your dad said that since the Mayans never had food, the body hadn't learned to assimilate it, that it was a genetic issue, and we were dying of laughter.

I liked parties, friends, gossip, and shopping. My dad would say, "How lucky you have a rich dad, woe betide your husband," and laugh. I thought it was wonderful that my Aunt Meche knew everything about everyone, even Mérida, which she never visited. Your dad said he had intergalactic radar antennas, that he picked up even the slightest gossip, and my Aunt Meche would laugh.

At 28, I married your father, and we had that wonderful honeymoon that lasted almost a year, all over the world. I was amazed to see the reality of everything I read in books. Despite the distance from our family, whom we rarely saw, only every university vacation, these were years of intense happiness. And then your birth arrived, the happiest event I've ever seen for the entire family. Your grandfather was overjoyed. He said the heir to the Chi family had been born, and that he would be brilliant like his parents; well, like his paternal grandparents; a hard worker like his maternal grandfather, and a leader like his great-grandfather. He bragged to everyone; he couldn't contain his happiness.

When you arrived in 2000, everything was bliss. We went to live on the ranch because we wanted you to have a healthy country life. For me, there was no greater joy than being with you and the family. Your father left early for college and returned at night to spend, like my father, every weekend there, except for one Sunday a month, when he went fishing with his friend. It was a blessing that your father got along so wonderfully with my father. Your grandfather was normally reserved and spoke little, but with Rubén, he would talk for hours. I wondered how much they could talk.

Weekends were wonderful; for the first five years, we hardly ever went into the city; sometimes to a new restaurant, but nothing more, and sometimes we took you to the parks. Aunt Meche would visit us and joke that we'd become Mayans.

Once again, locked away in our town, he really enjoyed playing with you. When I told him I'd *homeschool you*, he said, "That's a nice idea, but be careful, you might get lonely and unsociable." I told him you had a lot of little cousins back at the ranch, and he said yes, even though they were a little wild, and we laughed.

One weekend my dad, Rubén's dad, and your dad were spending the night talking. At night, Rubén said to me, "I don't know how your dad knows so much about so many things, and he deduces many of them intuitively. It's incredible." And I replied, "You know, Rubén, my dad only sleeps six hours a day, from 12:00 pm to 6:00 pm. He's never needed more sleep and always went to bed at 10:00 pm. He's read two hours a day his entire life. If you calculate that he's 60 years old now, and that he probably started reading when he was 10, because he always told me he loved reading anywhere and with any book. He's been reading for 50 years, which is 700 hours a year and 35,000 hours of reading. And if you add to that the fact that he has a prodigious memory, how come you don't understand? How many people do you know who've read that many hours?" He smiled and said, "You're right, I'm a fool not to understand."

Hurricane *Wilma* in 2005 was a turning point for many people; the old residents said everything was different and bad. I didn't believe that; I loved the development; I loved the growth of Cancún. Everything I liked—the ocean, the beach, the cenotes for swimming, the parks—everything was getting better every day; better restaurants, better transportation, better hospitals, better and more movie theaters. We loved going to the VIP rooms and getting something to eat while watching a movie. I recognize and accept that our situation was privileged, thanks to the efforts of my dad and yours, but I still liked it. Sometimes I even went alone in the car to see the construction projects, the new hotels, and I thought that thanks to that there would be more fortunate people like me. I loved watching them grow; we never had a boat; your grandfather wasn't very fond of the sea, and your dad said there was no better boat than his friend's.

I liked Aunt Meche's meetings, especially those that prepared for the Red Cross campaign and the Carnival. Those who know others say that the Cancún Red Cross and the state meetings are among the best in the country, but since we started homeschooling, I stopped attending them. I spent every weekday with you in your study, learning everything you were studying together, and I didn't go anywhere.

Of course, except for weekends and vacations, and even though you wanted to keep studying, I would close the studio so you could play with your cousins, and we could go out to the town of Ma'y Tab, and you could also be there with the family, and we could spend days at the house in Cancún with your dad, so you could get familiar with the city and the people. I never forgot Aunt Meche's concern that you might become unsociable, and despite all that, you're not unsociable, but you are a little withdrawn.

I was fascinated by studying English and French online. I didn't like German, which you learned and I didn't. When you took your German classes, I did some housework. I loved our way of life, being with you in the studio, learning and traveling the world virtually, meeting exceptional professors from Harvard, MIT, Oxford, UNAM, and scientists from all over the world, Nobel Prize winners, who explained their theories in person.

The bmd's virtual teaching program is an incredible reality; I'm sure that over time it will become a much more modern form of teaching; schools will tend to be virtual and led by highly educated teachers. And I inevitably remembered my little village school, with two classrooms, and my beloved teachers who were like your grandparents, husband and wife, teachers by vocation, but with the limitations inherent in school. I remember my dad bringing the chalk and erasers because they didn't have the budget.

At the ranch, I felt very safe because of my uncles and cousins who looked after me, and because of the hurricane-proof windows and power plants at the house. Our studies didn't stop when the power went out, and when the power lines fell because of *Wilma*, the ranch had power all the way to the entrance.

When my dad found out about the *homeschool*, and built the studio for you, he bought so much equipment, so many things, made it into a cyclone bunker, and with your dad's help, he selected the best video, computer, and communications equipment, and put up antennas to capture what we needed from the BMD satellite. And one day I asked him, "Dad, where do you get so much money for so many things?" And smiling, he answered, "My daughter, I didn't just buy little buildings, but also some land. When I need it, I sell some, and you don't know how much they sell for now. What used to cost one now costs ten. It's incredible."

One day your aunt Meche told me: "I'm worried that you're locked up here; when your son gets out, what are you going to do?" I said: "Look, Aunt, the little girl from the Mayan village that you knew, the cheerful young woman from school and university in Cancún, and the locked-up mother, as you tell me, learning languages and everything else, and the one who will get out of here when my son's studies are over, she's the same, and you can rest assured, I'll always be the same, and you and my whole family will always be the most important thing in my life," and we both cried for a little while.

You know more than anyone about our life in the studio, how happy we were with our family, in the town, in Cancun, with the uncles and cousins we loved seeing so much, how we swam in the sea whenever we wanted, how we enjoyed seeing dolphins in the sea from your studio window, and how we were scared more than once when we saw a shark's fin pass by in the distance.

Until today, when you turn 18, it has been happiness, and I want to tell you that I have a deep faith in the future, of Mexico, of the family, of you, of the changes that I see in the state with this new governor, whom you know and in whom I have faith and your grandfather has faith, and the president who has made so many reforms, and who for me has been unfairly criticized for a thousand things and who prepared the country for a better future, who is transforming all of education, fighting against a retrograde and perverse union that only seeks its

profit at the expense of the education of millions of children. I'm sure you'll succeed, and that in Mexico in the future there will be thousands educated like you. In my past, in my present, and hopefully in my future, I'm very happy, in your company and that of my entire family.

Ruben's tears began to flow, and he added:

—She didn't write me another message, because, as you know, they both died about eight years later. They were very young, about 58 years old. She still accompanied me in my studies until I was 25, and she died just as I finished them all, as if her mission was to guide me to the end. There have been three generations: my grandfather, my mother, and me, and as she asked my father, he let me be. And over those three generations, my family changed from the Middle Ages to the space age, and we were able to embrace it all thanks to the efforts of each of us. That's why my true God, my inner God, is the God of self-improvement, study, work, family, and the world that I've learned to love in this study.

And Tere felt immense happiness and pride that the man who spoke to her like that He was her future husband and father of her child.

Esa noche, Rubén invitó a Miguelito Chi, que era con el que Javiercito jugaba más, a que fuera a dormir a la casa con Javier, y que llevara su ropa para la boda. Los dos niños iban a ir vestidos iguales: guayabera blanca, pantalón negro y zapatos negros con calcetines negros, igual que Rubén. Tere le dijo que usaría unhuipil blanco con flores que había comprado.

Javiercito was happy that Miguelito was staying with him, and when Rubén told him that he was going to go with him on the trip, they both became happy, and Rubén noticed that Tere smiled blushing but happy.

The next day, don Juan informed Rubén that he had returned from the village, where he had slept, and that everything was ready. He suggested he arrive immediately at the wedding; they had scheduled 2:00 p.m. for the civil ceremony, with the meal to begin at 2:30 p.m. Rubén left at 12:30, expecting to arrive by 1:30, and asked one of his relatives to follow him in case of any eventuality.

"I'm going to explain how the wedding is going to unfold, so you don't get nervous or surprised," Rubén told Tere. "Everyone is going to come: the Chi family and those from Cancún. Aunt Meche is going to take two trucks with the families she invited, who know me but mainly knew my mother. Uncle Juan is going to take two trucks from the Puerto Juárez neighborhood with relatives who worked with my grandfather and whom I met on the ranch when I visited him. Another truck will leave from here, with all the Chi families, led by Uncle Jacinto and Aunt Lencha. There are seven trucks in total, with about 44 people each; about 300 people in total. The rest will be from the town."

Tere asked her a little worried: "How many more or less?"

—I wouldn't know, it depends on how much word got around, but it's between 500 and 1,000.

"Good heavens!" Tere exclaimed. "I'm glad you gave me a heads-up, more or less."

Ruben continued:

— About 20 piglets will be cooked on a barbecue and there will be tomato sauce and mukbil chicken.

"What's that?" Tere asked.

—It's a huge chicken tamale that is buried, like barbacoa. And there's going to be zic of

Venison, which I believe will be beef, because hunting deer is no longer allowed, but by tradition we call it that, and rice and beans. The waitress will have 50 waiters and 20 *bartenders*, and there will be four spots on the corners, with 10 people each, serving tortillas. The trucks have already arrived with about 200 cartons of beer, 100 cases of various soft drinks, and 10 cases of sugar-free sodas; 100 bottles of tequila, 100 bottles of rum, and 100 bottles of aguardiente, one bottle of each per table. Wine will not be served; it is not used in town, and I don't want to make a difference. We will leave at 5:00 p.m., and Don Juan, with ten trusted young nephews, very well trained and who will not drink, will make sure that nothing happens as the afternoon and night progress.

Upon arriving, Tere realized from the photos she'd seen of the town that it was much larger than she'd imagined. The tables had been set up with four circus-style tarps in the main plaza. There were ten rows of round tables to the east and west, and ten rows to the north and south; a total of 100 tables with ten people each, arranged by section: Cancún, Puerto Juárez, the ranch, and the town's neighbors. When they arrived, a little before 2:00 p.m., there were empty tables at the Cancún tables. Aunt Meche told them that a truck was about to arrive, that she couldn't wait any longer but had been notified it was on its way. There were about ten empty tables in the west wing, and Rubén ordered them removed so he could expand the dance floor on that side.

The ceremony began at 2:15 pm sharp. People kept arriving, but it was no problem. The food was splendid. Despite the fact that there were food stands on every corner, the waiters couldn't keep up and security had to assist them. Everyone was happy. Aunt Meche, Uncle Juan, Uncle Jacinto, and Aunt Lencha, the two children, and the bride and groom were at the table of honor. Tere noticed that Rubén didn't even have a drink. The meal was enlivened by harp and violin music, but at 4:30 pm

The marimba bands arrived. The music began with a Yucatecan zapateado, and many from the town and also from Cancún stood up to dance. At 5:00 pm, Rubén asked for the microphone and, with his girlfriend at his side, said:

—Dear family: First of all, I apologize for not stopping by the tables to say goodbye, but I ask you to understand that going around to greet 90 tables and saying goodbye to 900 people would take me all afternoon and evening. I just want to tell you what a joy it has been for my wife, Tere, and my son Javier, whom I'd like to take this opportunity to introduce to you because we've decided that I should adopt him since Tere is a widow. I want to tell you how much joy it has given me to be with you, to meet my new family, and for us to be able to share. I ask that we make a toast in memory of my great-grandfather, Jacinto Chi; my grandfather, Juan Chi; my father, Rubén; my mother, Alicia; and my uncles, Jacinto and Lencha, who are here present; my uncle, Juan; and my aunt, Meche, whom you all know.

Everyone stood up and toasted. Javier signaled the marimba and the tap dancing began, and everyone danced at their tables and on the dance floor.

Rubén grabbed Tere and the children, gave Jacinto a hug, who was already somewhat cheerful, and Aunt Lencha, Uncle Juan, and Meche accompanied them to the truck. Meche blessed them, and Uncle Juan said to Rubén:

—Your whole family is here, never forget it —and he gave them a hug.

The children were happy, and Miguelito said:

"Uncle Don Rubén, that was a great party," and they all laughed very happily.

The kids went to play with their iPods in the back of the truck, and Rubén told Tere, "My plan for the

honeymoon is this. Let me know if you like it or if you want to change anything."

She interrupted him and said:

—In advance, everything seems fine to me —and they both laughed.

—Well, the plan is to get to Mérida. I've reserved two suites at a hacienda at the entrance to the city. There are several renovated haciendas like this one nearby; I chose it because it's in the city. We'll be there for two nights. Tomorrow we'll visit the city; the day after tomorrow, Sunday, we'll leisurely visit the ruins of Chichen Itzá and spend one night there. Monday is a long day, as we'll go to Maní, which has a large church, in whose atrium almost all the Mayan codices and books were burned by Bishop Diego de Landa.

Miguelito added: —

My dad told me that that man was bad, that he wanted to erase us from history and that if it weren't for the ruins, we wouldn't know anything about our grandparents. I don't want to see it!

Ruben reassured him:

—Don't worry, that man died a long time ago.

"That's great!" said Miguelito, "and Rubén smiled and thought, "Something still runs in the Chi blood."

—Afterwards, we'll go see the flamingos and eat seafood at Río Lagartos. Afterwards, we'll visit the Ek Balam ruins and then head to Valladolid. There, we'll spend two nights exploring the city. On Wednesday, we'll head to the ranch, stopping by the cenotes. We'll be back at the ranch for lunch.

—Tere said:

—It's the longest trip we've ever made.

To which Ruben replied mischievously:

—Yes, but this is our honeymoon. Now I'll tell you about that separate world that is the Yucatecans.

"Mérida was the last major capital city connected to central Mexico and its capital, as the train arrived in 1958 and the highway in the early 1960s.

They were so isolated that they aspired to independence. In fact, wealthy families had more

contact with Havana and New Orleans than with Mexico City. Most doctors trained or completed postgraduate studies in Havana, and landowners spent more time in New Orleans than in Mexico City. There was a steamship that connected with Veracruz and another with Havana and New Orleans. Wealthy families formed what was known as "the divine caste," and the requirement for entry was money and owning estates. They were wealthy and educated and demanded to be distinguished by the people.

Many felt like semi-aristocrats, having inherited the lands from the Spanish encomenderos to whom the crown had granted them, but most of the Spaniards who arrived were scoundrels of seven soles. Those of the divine caste felt like pure blood, no one knows how, since the vast majority of the conquistadors and colonizers didn't bring wives. Therefore, on the peninsula you were either mestizo or Mayan.

"Mérida was a closed society practically until the 20th century. Nowadays, it has opened up much more; the grandchildren and great-grandchildren of the divine caste are no longer so exclusive, and the incursion of a group of hard-working Lebanese has created wealth similar to or greater than theirs. But there is no rivalry; they have come together very well."

"The Mayan people have traditionally been very peaceful, and you'll be hard pressed to find better hosts than the Yucatecans. They are cheerful, talkative, hard drinkers, womanizers, and excellent at business. Never even think of doing business with them; the women are excellent mothers and magnificent wives, who tolerate their husbands' antics, 'as long as they do everything a man should do at home.' They are wonderful cooks, or have wonderful cooks, because food is a marvelous ritual. There is no Yucatecan who doesn't know how to eat well; I remember that when we had a big family meal, my grandfather would say: 'We look like Yucatecans.' We won't have much contact with them over time, but I'm sure you'd find them charming. Don't forget, never do business with them. They cultivate what is called 'a Yucatecan culture,' and to illustrate this, I'll tell you an anecdote about my Aunt Meche.

Aunt Meche recounted that at the last Red Cross dinner she had attended with my grandfather, my mother, and my father, my grandfather's engineer friend, his wife, and their three children sat at the table. My grandfather was surprised because my mother knew two of them perfectly, having been classmates at La Salle High School, and they chatted all night. Aunt Meche chatted with the oldest, whom she found charming, as she was like her, very fond of certain esoteric theories and philosophies. She was very sensitive, and she said that if she had known her better, she would have been a great friend. My mother was delighted and said that the other woman was very cheerful and mischievous, that they got along very well, and that the young man at school was very serious and studious, and that my mother and he had competed for the highest grade point average throughout college and that they shared a very happy time together. Aunt Meche felt very comfortable with the engineer's wife, impressed by her simplicity and kindness. She knew her by sight but hadn't had the opportunity to meet her. She said she was the most peaceful and tranquil person in the world.

spiritual quality he had known, and he was struck by the fact that at her age she maintained an iron discipline and exercised daily. She also had a natural grace, having been a ballet dancer in her childhood and youth.

"But the most important part of the meeting was the dialogue between my grandfather and the engineer. My grandfather asked him why he hadn't seen him at hotel construction sites since 1992, to which he replied: "I'll explain briefly. My partner, the friendly

Yucatecan with whom I sometimes visited construction sites and who was there when Hurricane *Gilberto hit us hard*, was someone I appreciated very much; I considered him almost a brother, and he was the person I had the most understanding with in business. He was brilliant with numbers, ambitious, a hard worker like few others, and he was also a drunk, a party animal, and a gambler; a great host. I admired him, appreciated him like a brother, and had absolute trust in him.

'Well, it turns out that, following a series of circumstances, he began telling me he had reliable information that our system, designed by lawyers and advisors, had legal flaws and that the government was going to act against us. At first, he was very subtle, but little by little, he escalated his tone, until he managed to panic me. He took advantage of that moment to tell me that some people in Mérida were willing to buy us out, taking all the risks, but at a third of the real value. I believed him blindly, and the partners signed in good faith, making a completely legal sale of the shares.

'It wasn't long before I discovered he had been the real buyer, and not the *bridge buyers* he'd led me to believe, and I realized the *Yucatecan cultivation* he'd made of me. Two weeks before the operation, we had dinner together, and he got a little drunk, and with tears in his eyes he said to me: 'Don't let me do what I'm thinking!' And I, in the height of innocence, replied: 'Don't worry, I'll never let anything happen to you.'

'When I realized the reality, I fell into a terrible depression that almost killed me. The only one I've ever had in my life. I had thrown away ten of the most creative years of my life, because I had designed the entire plan, and a group of top executives and my brothers, along with him, had carried it out. Believe me, don Juan, it wasn't the business that brought me down, it was the lies and deceit of someone I thought I knew like a brother. Time passed, and I recovered thanks to the support of my wife and a friend who had the idea of taking me to Ixtapan de la Sal to recover. I returned to work in what was already a passion, administration, and that's why he didn't see me on construction sites anymore. With skill and intelligence, I co-participated in a company that has generated thousands of jobs. That's the story, don Juan, which I've never told anyone.

"And the most interesting thing came later, because my grandfather told him: 'Listen, engineer, I'm also going to tell you a story that I've never told anyone. When I met Alicia, who was my beloved wife and mother of my adoration, my daughter Alicia, she

She worked in a restaurant in Nuevo Yucatán, where I was working. I learned a lot about palapas and masonry at the sawmill and on the construction projects it carried out. I had breakfast, lunch, and dinner at the restaurant for nearly two years, and little by little, Alicia and I fell in love. I couldn't believe it, because she was educated and very beautiful; I had just left the town; I knew how to read and write and read a lot, but she, with her clear eyes, was a real woman. Things were going well, but I didn't dare speak to her clearly because I was afraid of losing her.

'One day, after dinner, we stayed up talking, as was our custom by now. The most I dared was to take her hand. She said to me: 'Juan, I'm worried because my cousin Aidé, whom you know, has been slowly speaking badly about you to me for some time now. Each time she tells me that she's found out... that she's been told... that she's seen increasingly serious things, and yesterday she told me you had a lover. I didn't believe her because I have blind faith in you because I know you're a man of integrity.'

But besides my cousin, I've realized that my people don't look favorably on our relationship,' and tears began to flow from her eyes. It was then that I gathered my strength and said to her: 'Alicia, if that's the case, why don't we go to the village together and end this back and forth.' And she, squeezing my hand with a strength I didn't think she had, replied: 'And why did you wait so long to tell me, Juan? We're leaving tomorrow.'

'We both left early with just what we were wearing. She carried a small suitcase with some papers, and I carried my backpack with clothes. We left for Valladolid, and on the way she said to me: 'Juan, do you know what a *Yucatecan crop* is?' I replied that I didn't.

She told me it was a strategy from someone who wants you to do something, and little by little, they cultivate the idea in you, as if nothing had happened, until they feel it's time, and then they push you in that direction. 'That's what Aidé tried to do with me, but I let her go ahead to see where she'd go, and when I realized what she was looking for and that it reflected the environment I was in, that's when I spoke to you.'

'In Valladolid, I tried to get married, but since I didn't have a birth certificate, the judge refused to let us marry. She told me: 'Juan, what's your concern? We're going to get married by the supreme law of God and our nature, which is the law of love.'

'Alicia told me that what had hurt her the most was the betrayal, since her cousin was the person she loved and trusted the most. She felt deeply betrayed and never forgave herself. And yet I didn't want to tell her that her cousin had made advances on me on more than one occasion. And between us, I was as if I couldn't let her go, but it never crossed my mind to betray my beloved Alicia. I never mentioned it to her so as not to upset her further.

'I respected her until Jacinto married us in a traditional ceremony in the village. But I'm telling you this because a *Yucatecan crop* could have destroyed our lives.'

"The engineer replied: 'You see, Don Juan, one crop was successful because I was naive, and the other wasn't because Doña Alicia was clever and brave. That's the way it is, Don Juan.'"

They arrived at the hacienda, which Tere and the children thought was wonderful. They had dinner—Tere would say it was Yucatecan: delicious and plentiful. Rubén took the children to their room, and seeing how large it was, Javiercito asked if it was all for them. They settled in, and Rubén told them the door led to their room, and if they needed anything, they should knock.

Tere took out the pajamas she'd brought for the children, and Miguelito said he couldn't sleep dressed and preferred to go to bed in his underwear and T-shirt. They started watching television, and when Tere kissed them, they were almost asleep.

Tere and Rubén left the room and walked a little through the gardens; the night was cool, and they breathed in the scent of the flowers. Once in the room, Tere took something out of her suitcase and said to Rubén: "Wait for me, I'm going to the bathroom to change." Rubén got into bed, just like Miguelito, in underwear and an undershirt, and waited. Tere came out dressed in a beautiful negligee; it was backlit, and her figure was transparent. Rubén thought: "She's more beautiful than ever." Tere said mischievously, "It was a gift from Aunt Meche," and Rubén replied, "Bless her!" and they laughed. Rubén became a little serious and said: "Tere, I have a confession to make. I've never been with a woman." He said it in an innocent tone that fascinated Tere. And approaching him, he said: "Don't worry, I know everything will be all right."

Minutes later, they were embracing with unbridled passion. It was a true honeymoon. In the morning, Rubén, who was beaming with happiness, said to her, "Gosh, Tere, if I'd known it was like this, I would have started sooner." Tere burst out laughing and replied, "It's not always as wonderful as today."

When we got to the children they were already dressed, and Tere asked them: "Have you already bathed?" They both smiled, and Tere said, "Well, whatever, let's go have breakfast." They ordered a Yucatecan breakfast and tried the huevos motuleños, which they found delicious. Tere asked, "Why the name?" Rubén told her it was because the first time they made it was in a restaurant in Motul, hence the name.

They left, and Rubén took them on a tour of Paseo Montejo. He explained that this was the name of the Spaniard who conquered that part of the peninsula, as there were remote areas in the jungle that had practically never been conquered. Tere was surprised by the magnificence and beauty of some of the houses. Rubén explained that they belonged to families of the divine caste. She commented that their architecture didn't correspond to the Mexican architecture she had studied, to which Rubén replied, "Don't forget that the divine caste was more influenced by Havana, New Orleans, and Europe than by central Mexico. Another day we'll tour the henequen haciendas that have been renovated, some with period furniture, so you can see a different type of architecture."

Afterwards he took them to the Central Plaza and they visited the portals and the Cathedral of Mérida, in the city center. Rubén commented: "This is what Cancún doesn't have."

Afterwards they went to the Great Museum of the Mayan World and he told them that there are four large museums with important Mayan collections: the National Museum of Anthropology, which they would visit in Mexico City, the Pellicer Museum, in Villahermosa, Tabasco,

which was named after the great Tabasco poet and also includes important Toltec pieces; the Cancún and Mérida museum, which opened in 2012 and was warmly received by Yucatecans and Mayanists from around the world.

They walked around it for a while, until Miguelito said, "I don't know about you, but I'm really hungry," and they went to eat at La Pigua restaurant, which had a reputation for being the best seafood restaurant.

Afterward, Rubén took them to Puerto Progreso. Along the way, they saw some beautiful neighborhoods, and Tere commented that Mérida looked like a very structured city, to which Rubén replied:

—That's right, it's been around for almost 500 years. We wish Cancún, which is 50 years old, had Mérida's infrastructure, even though it already has the same number of inhabitants.

In Quintana Roo, the governors have never truly loved Cancún, even though it generates 90% of the state's revenue. Chetumal has proportionally better infrastructure because it is the seat of the state government and the federal delegations; more than 50% of the jobs are government employees; tourism hasn't progressed as it has in the north, in Cancún, or the Riviera Maya, and the population hasn't grown.

They arrived in Progreso. He took them to the dock and explained that for more than 450 years this was the entrance and exit point for goods and people from abroad. Later, as they toured Chicxulub Pueblo, he explained that the houses they saw along the seashore belonged to wealthy people. Javiercito interrupted: "What's wealthy, Dad?" Rubén smiled; he loved that Javier had stopped calling him Rubén and started calling him "Dad." Tere smiled too. Rubén replied: "It's people who have money." Javiercito added: "Are you wealthy, Dad?" Rubén replied: "Somewhat, my son," and continued:

—There's a very old tradition that in the summer, when the heat in Mérida is unbearable, families, along with all their staff, come to Progreso for the "season."

The gentlemen come and go to Mérida daily, and on Saturdays there are parties everywhere. If someone wants to hang out with "the big money guys," as they're known, they have to have a house in Progreso.

They returned to Mérida, and Rubén took them to a park where serenades, folk dances, and traditional Yucatecan trova are performed. Rubén told Tere that Yucatecans are very musical. Tere replied that she was familiar with the music of Gonzalo Curiel and Armando Manzanero and that she particularly loved "*Adoro*."

As they got into the car, Rubén surprised Tere with the song "*Adoro*," which from that moment on would always remind them of their honeymoon. They dined on street snacks: papadzules, cochinita pibil tostadas, and dogfish empanadas. The children were happy and tired; they went back to the hotel and put the children to bed, who fell asleep immediately. They retired to their rooms and resumed their passionate encounters, which, unlike the previous night, had gained more momentum.

The next day they left early to visit the ruins of Chichen Itza. Upon arriving, they were surprised by the street vendors filling the halls with all kinds of cheap handicrafts. Tere asked:

—Why is this happening, Ruben? This damages the grand image of these ruins.

Ruben answered:

—It's because of our politicians, who are demagogues on the one hand and unwilling to confront the problems on the other. They prefer to denigrate one of the seven wonders of humanity rather than its image, without realizing that if they enforced the law, it would improve.

The archaeologist in charge was another Chi, who allowed Javierto and Miguel to carefully climb the pyramid. Upon descending, Javierto told him the view was beautiful and that he had seen a cenote, asking if they could visit it.

Lenin Chi, the archaeologist's name, accompanied them to the cenote. On the way Lenin was playing with the children and Tere asked:

—Why Lenin?

Ruben answered:

—Many Mayans heard about the Russian Revolution and named their children after it. names like Lenin, Stalin, etc.

They arrived at the cenote, and Lenin explained that it was believed that maidens were sacrificed there as an offering to the gods. Miguelito, who knew him, said:

—So, man, were they bad?

Lenin explained to him:

—No, Miguel, they weren't bad, they were rituals with which they believed their gods would take better care of them.

They stopped at the planetarium, and Lenin explained that his ancestors observed the stars and planets; that's how they knew the right time to plant corn, that they had a very exact calendar, and that they used zero.

They finished the tour, said goodbye to Lenin and headed for the town of Maní.

In Maní, they visited the church and headed for Valladolid. In Valladolid, they stayed in a lovely little six-room hotel in an old colonial mansion belonging to two brothers, sons of a friend of their father's. They shared their mother's last name and were highly regarded in Cancún. It was rumored that they might be related, as the friend's father had founded Nuevo Yucatán.

They immediately went to eat at La Casona, a wonderful restaurant, also in a beautifully remodeled mansion, which had a kind of altar or fountain that was a work of art. The food was an **extraordinary buffet** of Mexican and Yucatecan food. Rubén advised the children to serve themselves as much as they wanted, but to have a little of each so they could try everything. They ordered Jamaican water, coconut water, tamarind water, and orange water. They made several rounds of the *buffet*, serving themselves very little. Javierto said his favorite was the mole; Miguelito said the stuffed cheese; and Tere said everything!

When they left the restaurant, it was partly cloudy and cool, and Rubén told them to go for a walk. They walked along a renovated street, without lampposts and with little traffic, which led to a convent, which they visited. They returned to the center, walked through the park and visited the church, and returned to the hotel.

They made love with great passion and sensuality, happy, passionate and overwhelmed.

The next day they had breakfast and headed out to Río Lagartos. On the way, as usual, the children rode in the back of the truck to play with their iPods. Tere perked up and said to Rubén:

—On our first night of our honeymoon, you told me you'd never had sex with anyone, which I believed and believe with absolute certainty, but I'd like you to explain to me why you're so skilled at doing it.

Ruben smiled and answered:

—It's a long story, but there's time to tell it. When I finished my courses at my grandfather's ranch studio, I was 22, and while talking about the future with my mother, she said: "Look, Rubén, I recommend that before completing your master's and doctoral degrees at the BMD in New York, which is what you want to do, you take a gap year and travel the world." And together we designed a round-the-world trip, to be completed in one year, which included flights by plane, train trips, bus trips, ocean and river boat trips, and even a short stretch in a hot air balloon. I made a plan in my studio of the detailed itinerary at each site, including museums, cathedrals, mosques, pagodas, Buddhist and Shinto temples, synagogues, and some pilgrimage sites like Fátima and the Taj Mahal.

"I made that trip, which we'll discuss calmly one day, because my experiences during those months were all different: France, Germany, England, Spain, and many other countries. I arrived in some places as a traveler because I spoke the local language, while in others I was just a simple tourist. After completing that trip, I went to New York to study at the UN headquarters of the WBF. There I had a wonderful experience, especially because of the quality of the teaching staff. It was sensational; I established very good contact with the teachers. My classmates told me I had the advantage of not having had direct contact during my previous training and that's why I had no preconceptions."

"For one reason or another, I was very happy and busy all the time because I loved what I was learning. When I finished my studies, I decided to stay in New York for about two weeks to see theater and get to know the city a little better. Over the course of those two years, I don't know if it was because I was used to studying or for some other reason, I had become very withdrawn. I was in a hotel, having decided to give up the apartment I was living in to have more time, when I received a call from Uncle Juan. I was in the hotel room when I heard Uncle Juan's sobbing voice. I was alarmed and sensed the worst. He said, 'Son, I have terrible news to tell you. Your parents just died in a car accident. I'm terribly sorry.' I heard him sobbing on the phone. I managed to say, 'Thanks for letting me know, Uncle,' and added something like, 'Be careful, I'll be there right away.'

"I don't know how I managed to make my reservation on the plane to Cancún at 5 p.m. Afterward, I nearly fainted; I lay in bed, confused, terrified, and anguished. I spent four hours like that. I sat up, grabbed my luggage, paid, took a taxi, and boarded the plane like a zombie. I was barely aware of anything. Sitting on the plane, I became aware of the scale of the tragedy. I closed my eyes and spent the entire trip absorbed in my memories with them, especially with my mother, to whom I couldn't give my diploma and the job offer from the BMD they had made me. I could no longer share my dreams come true with them; I was 25 years old."

"When I arrived in Cancún, my uncle Juan was waiting for me; the two of us cried, hugging each other like children. People looked at us in surprise, but with respect; seeing a man like Uncle Juan cry was overwhelming. He just said, 'My daughter left before me; it's not fair.'

"There was a chauffeur, and we both rode in the back. I held her hand and we didn't say anything during the ride; there was nothing to say. When we arrived, she said to me: 'My son, have courage. Your Aunt Meche is here with the mourners and the family. There are only a few of them. We didn't want to do anything big because we didn't feel up to it. Have courage when you see her because she's devastated.' And so it was. When I hugged her, she almost fainted in my arms. Uncle Juan had to help me sit her down on a sofa. He didn't say anything for a few hours; when he was able to speak, he told me something similar to what Uncle Juan had said to me: 'It's not fair that my daughter—as I called her—left before me and left me with this suffering.' It was a terrible night of pain and nostalgia. The next day, with a few friends of my mom and dad, since my maternal grandparents had died before me, and with Uncle Jacinto and Aunt Lencha, also heartbroken, we buried my parents' remains in the small family pantheon, on the mound of the beach, in the middle of Uncle Jacinto's flowers and plants.

"The following week was the worst of my life; I even began to think I was guilty for not returning immediately after finishing school. I mentioned this to Uncle Juan, who with a stern face took me by both arms and said in a harsh tone, for which I am grateful to this day: 'Look, my son, you can think whatever you want because of your pain, but not to say stupid things.' It was the first time he had ever said a rude word in front of me, but I immediately understood, from the vehemence with which he said it, that he was right. Uncle Juan decided that Aunt Meche would stay in the house.

The school principal, who had attended the funeral, understood and said she could stay as long as necessary, and she suffered the loss with us.

"But one Sunday, about ten days later, we were having breakfast when Uncle Juan arrived and said: 'Well, enough with the whining and grieving, they wouldn't have wanted this, it's time to face reality and so we shall,' and in an authoritarian tone I had never heard before, he said: 'Forgive me, but tomorrow we'll all get back to our own business. Aunt Meche, you have 40 children waiting for your return, and you, my son, the whole family is waiting for you to take charge where it belongs. We all have obligations to fulfill, and fulfilling them is the best way to honor those who have loved us and who have gone before us.' So get ready, we start tomorrow."

"I don't think Uncle Juan had ever spoken so much so often, but we both realized account, and we painfully begin our work the next day.

"For bureaucratic reasons, I started working at the BMD about five or six months later, and then I decided to return to my studio and look for a way to resolve the doubts that tormented me so much."

Tere saw that a few tears were running down his face and took his hand.

Ruben replied: "It's okay, Tere, don't worry" and continued saying:

—I'm going to play you a very special recording that was very significant for me, on my 15th birthday. It was strange because we don't celebrate birthdays in the family. My grandfather wasn't interested in them, and when I asked him why one day, he said, "I just don't remember when I was born."

They both laughed and Ruben continued:

—My mother had gathered my grandfather, Aunt Meche, Juan and Jacinto, and my grandparents, my father's parents, for dinner at home. That day, the north wind was blowing heavily and it was raining cats and dogs, which is why my grandparents didn't swim in the ocean—which they loved—and after dinner, we went to see a movie in my studio, which has a special movie and video room, which you already know. My mother selected a movie and said: "It's The Passion of the Christ," to which my grandfather replied: "Look, Alicia, I prefer something more cheerful this afternoon." And then my mother, who was usually very discreet, unexpectedly asked my grandfather: "Don Ramón, you're not Catholic, are you?"

Don Ramón replied: "I was, and a very good one, in my youth, but I stopped being one for two reasons: one that I reserve for myself due to the presence of my grandson Rubén, and the other because I could never reconcile the harsh, cruel, and even evil God of the Old Testament with the good God of the New Testament. I cannot reconcile so much cruelty and evil in the world if we are all created by the same God. Why do some suffer so much and others are so happy? And they would answer me: 'These are tests that God imposes, so that we may earn heaven.' I am very tolerant because I was Catholic and I understand that faith helps many people a great deal."

"My Aunt Meche chimed in: 'I was one of them. It was in the Mérida cathedral, where I asked God for help and forgiveness, that the idea came to me. An inner voice told me: 'Go to Cancún.' I went home, took the little money I had saved, and announced I was going to Cancún. My parents, who were ashamed of me, didn't object, and Mom gave me some savings and her blessing. I left with what I was wearing and a small suitcase, satisfied that I had made a great decision. But I was afraid of going to Cancún; it was 1978, and I thought it would be very difficult and that I wouldn't have enough money. A few days later, the only friend I found, who was coming on the truck with me, was a waiter who worked at the neighboring house in Mérida and was a construction manager in Cancún. He introduced me to Don Juan here today. He took me to the school where I work to this day, thank God.'"

My grandfather replied:

—I left religion, and although I am very tolerant of it, little by little I was confirmed-

I send my decision. Although my wife, here present, maintains her religion, largely due to the good fortune of having met Father John, a dedicated priest who is sensational, good as a housewife, and a great promoter of the church. He built, almost with his own hands—because Cancún wasn't rich—a large church in the Parque de las Palapas, which is where my wife attends to this day.

“Father John, due to his popularity and liberalism, was banished by the bishop on duty to Carillo Puerto, and when they asked him why he didn't protest, he said there were two reasons: because that wasn't the bishop's will, but God's, who had his reasons and he accepted them; and second, because there were a lot of poor people there, many indigenous people, who needed to renew their faith, since they retained a religious syncretism with the worship of the cross, which is not that of Christ, and the Catholic religion. These were, as the indigenistas say, their customs and habits, and for him it was nothing more than an anachronism that only creates great confusion. And he would say, smiling: 'Either one or the other, but both are not valid.' And he would add: 'That's what the indigenistas call customs and habits.'”

“Then Father Fernando Rodríguez came in, who, with a different style and without Father John's charisma, has been a priest much loved by the community and also a great church builder. I don't quite understand why Catholics call themselves Catholic but only go to Mass when they can; or say I'm Catholic but only go to confession when I remember; or I'm Catholic but don't believe the Pope is infallible, because that allows them to hear about the Inquisition without worrying, because it happened a long time ago. And that's what happened to me when I was young; or to accept that the good Pope John tolerated and protected Father Maciel, and now they've canonized him after having covered up for a criminal. On the other hand, I feel that the fact that the Spanish conquered us and imposed on us a religion that says things like 'It's easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than for a rich man to go to heaven,' has only produced poor people who consider the rich to be sinners, and rich people who consider themselves guilty and condemned to hell. Compare that with the countries Colonized by Protestants, who consider well-being to be the combination of wealth, health, and work, let's see where they've gotten. We also have the case of divorced and remarried people, whom the Church considered excommunicated until Pope Francis exonerated them just this year.

“In my case I had made a mistake, because by leaving faith I had left God, and that left me with an enormous void that I filled one day in the year 2000, when Rubenci-to was born, here present, and I received a book titled *Hegel Was Right*, whose author was a certain Porfirio Miranda, whom I never knew until one day I attended a talk given by two teachers at an organization called Comparte, organized by an engineer friend of Grandpa Juan, to which your aunt Meche had invited us, because she was taking the human development course given by two teachers who were members—charming and very good—, Meche said.

“At the conference, Professor Luis Brito and his wife, Lupita, mentioned Professor Porfirio Miranda, and at the end of the conference I spoke with them and said: 'I have the

Hegel's book *was right*, which you mentioned, and it was fundamental for me because in it I rediscovered my faith, totally different from what I had been taught in my childhood. That gave me tremendous spiritual peace and I am deeply grateful, but I don't know who the author is.' Professor Luis told me: 'Not only do I know who he is, but he is a great friend of ours, he is a great philosopher, but he became enthusiastic about the liberation movement, and it was when he wrote *Marx and the Bible: Critique of the Philosophy of Oppression*, which earned him expulsion from the church.'

'I was also expelled for protecting a Shining Path guerrilla. Maestro Miranda was anathematized by the intellectual right. He later disappointed the left when Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn discovered the realities of communism.

"I told him that I had also read it and it had removed my leftist anxieties.

'Well,' continued Professor Luis, 'the teacher was banished by intellectuals from both the right and the left, and he survived because the UAM gave him a philosophy class. He lived for several years in Ciudad Nezahualcóyotl in conditions of immense poverty, of which he never complained. Later, he married a good woman who was well-off, and they went to live in a small house in Totolcingo, where a group of former Jesuits, and some guests—one of them from Cancún, by the way, who was my disciple and friend—would come to discuss philosophy.

"And where can I find your books?" I asked.

The teacher said that they are sometimes found in Gandhi bookstores.

"And I said: how good that there is one in Cancun.

"I've read all your books, and even though all my doubts about the Church have been confirmed, I attend all the baptisms, first communions, weddings, etc., that my wife and Meche take me to. And except for the sermons, I feel comfortable and at ease, and I think that many of those here are Catholic but don't know they're Protestant, since they don't go to Mass, don't confess, don't pay tithes, don't believe in the Pope, and don't keep God's commandments."

"That was very important to me," Rubén said. "Later, I read all of Porfirio's books in my BMD, and I've never had any religious conflicts. And it's allowed me to have a very clear and objective mind, which is why: when I study, I study; when I work, I work; and when I have fun, I have fun."

Tere already saw those characteristics in Rubén, but upon listening to him, she realized that he was very clear about his abilities, and she wanted to assume that perhaps he was also clear about his defects, which until that moment she hadn't noticed, and she thought about how lucky she had been to know him.

—And then I began to review a path similar to the one my father mentioned in the document he gave me when I turned 18, and I made a plan: I studied the

Evolution, history, philosophy, anthropology, and Hegel. At the same time, I studied human development and transpersonal therapies, which my aunt studied at Comparte, and I read a book I found by chance called *I Am We*.

"I found a number of alternative therapies to cure things, including anxiety and pain problems, and I selected three of them:

Yoga: to exercise the body and mind.

Meditation: to strengthen the spirit.

The *Kama Sutra*: to strengthen sensuality and reason.

"I immediately applied the first two and reserved the knowledge of the third for when necessary. The first two helped me a lot with the hard work I was experiencing, and now that I've practiced the third with you, I believe it's the one that has brought me the most happiness."

And they both laughed. Javiercito asked:

—What are you laughing at, Mom?

And Tere

said: "You're welcome, my son, one day your dad will tell you."

They arrived at the Lagartos River and boarded a boat. The boatman told them they were going to see the flamingos before they left; then the birds, the lizards, and then a dip in the spring.

Javiercito said he wasn't swimming with alligators. Time passed quickly because the flamingo show was wonderful. Javiercito said he'd seen them in a park before, but he couldn't remember which one, since he'd gotten used to it after so many trips. Afterward, they went to see the birds and then the alligators, so there was no time for a dip. Javiercito and Miguelito felt relieved.

They went to eat fish and seafood with a beer for Tere and Rubén, and Tere commented that they were the freshest she'd ever eaten. Rubén pointed out that they weren't even refrigerated; the fishermen were delivering them when they arrived.

They then went to the ruins of Ek-Balam. Miguelito commented that these were the largest Mayan figures he had ever seen, referring to the figures representing priests, hierarchs, or guardians—no one knows—that are on the main pyramid. To which Javiercito replied that yes, they were the largest.

They left the ruins and headed to the hotel where they had dinner and went to bed. Entering the room, Tere said mischievously:

—It's the fourth night of the honeymoon, will the *Kama Sutra* work?

Ruben answered:

—We'll see.

The next day, the first thing Tere said to Rubén was:

—Yes, it worked.

And he asked:

—Is it always going to be like this?

Ruben answered:

—I highly doubt it!

And they both laughed heartily.

After a good breakfast Miguelito asked:

—Uncle, where are we going now?

Ruben said:

To the most beautiful cenotes you've ever seen.

—More beautiful than Uncle Jacinto's?

—So pretty but bigger.

Upon arrival, they saw a sign that said *Xenotes*. Rubén explained that it was a group of parks, and since the first one began with an X, they had all been given an X. They were amazed by its size, the water, and the jungle that surrounded it. They rode zip lines, paddled in kayaks, swam, visited the two cenotes, and saw an armadillo, toucans, macaws, and howler monkeys in the trees. The lush vegetation contrasted with the blue sky; it was a clear, hot day.

They ate a good meal, got in the truck, and headed back. Miguelito said, "It's the best honeymoon I've ever been on!"

In the following days, Rubén spent his time putting things in order in Cancún and at the ranch, as he wasn't sure when they would return from Nicaragua, as the plan was to be there for at least two years. There was a direct flight from Managua to Cancún that took less than three hours, so he planned to go some weekends. So Friday came, and Rubén organized the last tour and again asked Miguelito's parents for permission to take him for the weekend. They agreed, but they were worried about when Javier left, since Miguel talked about nothing but Javier and what they did together in all the places they had visited. On Friday afternoon, they left for Tulum and arrived at a very "chic" little hotel, as Tere said. The hotel was charming, with very elegant and tasteful decor. They swam in the ocean, had dinner, and went to bed early.

The next day, they left early for Punta Allen. They were breaking in the road and a bridge. Rubén told them that ten years earlier, the last time he had gone fishing for mackerel and permit with his father, it took them four hours to cover 60 kilometers, or 15 kilometers per hour on the dirt road. This time, they arrived in 45 minutes. The town was much better than the last time he saw it. They hadn't had breakfast so they could eat live lobster.

Javercito said:

—I won't eat her alive.

Tere reassured him:

—Don't worry, it's a way of saying fresh, they're not alive.

To which Javiercito said:

"Oh, Dad, you can't even grind it anymore! Right, Miguelito?"

He agreed.

They had breakfast and boarded a boat to tour the lagoon and the Muyil community, where they put on life jackets and drifted down a river.

On the way Ruben said to Tere:

—This natural wonder is due to the efforts of a single person, who with a tiny team, including the graduate my grandfather admired so much, founded a research center known as Ciqroo. His name was Alfredo, and he's one of Cancún's unsung heroes, as my grandfather used to say. He succeeded in creating the Sian Ka'an Reserve, which an altruistic organization called Friends of Sian Ka'an has since helped preserve. This will be the great ecological lung of Quintana Roo when hotel development spreads from Punta Norte in Cancún to Chetumal, and there are 250,000 rooms and 100,000 homes for American, Canadian, and European retirees, who with their pensions will be able to live like kings.

They arrived at Muyil and toured the river; they saw an enormous number of birds and fish and enjoyed the natural beauty of the place. Afterward, they went to Cobá; they stayed at the small archaeological hotel and ate. They toured the ruins, and he remembered that his grandfather had gone to Cobá with his mother when he was about six years old, and they climbed the first pyramid. When his grandfather stood his mother on the top stone at the top of the pyramid, the pyramid's energy made her hair stand on end.

Javiercito said, "They'd stand up on me," to which Rubén replied, "What, if it's half curly and short." And Miguelito said, "And me? I don't have it short." "Well, let's see," said Rubén.

They climbed the first pyramid, which wasn't very big, and when they lifted Miguelito onto the stone, his hair barely moved, it was not known whether it was because of the energy or the wind, and everyone laughed with amusement.

Then they rode the carts to the larger pyramids. As always, Javier and Miguelito wanted to climb everything and admire the jungle scenery surrounding them.

The next morning Tere jokingly commented to Rubén:

—Hey, the energy didn't make Miguelito's hair stand up, but with you it seems to have been different.

Rubén blushed; later he would say it was the first practical joke he'd ever heard from a woman. Later, in Managua, he'd get used to them with Tere's friends, whom Rubén jokingly called "a bunch of girls."

They went to Xel-Há, where they were fascinated by the cove. Javier asked, "Is it a big pool?"

Ruben said:

—No, it's a cove.

And he pointed to the sea on the left, where there was a bridge.

They were served by a manager who knew Aunt Meche very well and was charming—as Tere would say. They went to the large spring and went down the river, each in a tube. But Javiercito and Miguel got off the tube to jump off a small cliff; then they went on the zip lines, but the most exciting part was when the four of them went swimming with the manatees. Javier wanted to swim with the dolphins, but Rubén told him to wait; he had a surprise for him. They continued swimming toward the ocean and got off at a two-story restaurant. They ate upstairs at a table overlooking the cove. The view was beautiful.

When they finished they left the park, but not before buying something at the store. Miguelito bought his dad a hat and they went to the truck.

On the highway they turned right and entered Akumal.

Ruben said to Tere:

—You could say it all began here. The first tourist accommodations on the coast were built here by Don Pablo, and the group of relatives and friends of my grandfather's friend, an engineer, arrived here, and my grandfather built what they called "the little houses"—and he pointed to them to the left of the cove. —In Xel-Há, I told them to save their swimsuits for a surprise.

And the surprise was swimming with turtles. I had reserved the last permitted swim at 5:30 p.m. They swam with several turtles that weren't allowed to be touched; the turtles were gentle. Tere noticed that some had a small white mark on their shells and asked what that was. Rubén replied that the Flora, Fauna, and Culture Foundation runs the turtle protection camps together with the municipal government and other organizations. This organization is run by the sister of the architect who arrived, and she is very interested in conservation. They have protected turtle nests, released millions of turtles, and for many years the park embedded a small white implant made of turtle shell in the turtles' shells. Over the years, turtles with the mark have returned to their birthplace to lay their eggs and roam the surrounding area.

They headed back to the ranch, happy and tired. On the way, Javiercito said, "I've swum with whale sharks, regular sharks, barracudas, dolphins, manatees, and now turtles. I'm not going to tell my friends about it because they won't believe me." That night everyone slept like a rock. In the morning, Tere jokingly said to Rubén:

—The Cobá pyramid didn't work.

—To which Ruben replied laughing:

—Not all pyramids work.

And they both died laughing.

The next day they returned to Cancun, and at the airport Ruben said to don Juan, hugging Aunt Meche:

—Let's see, Don Juan, I want this lady to come live at my ranch, because no I want her to live alone in her apartment now that she's leaving school.

Aunt Meche did not expect it, she hugged him and said:

—Thanks, Rubencito, you can't imagine how worried I was about being alone. At my Alicia's ranch I will be very happy with the entire Chi family.

Don Juan added:

—It was getting late for you, my son, to do that. Don't worry, I'll charge.

They said goodbye. Aunt Meche cried, and don Juan wished them a safe journey. On the plane, Tere asked him:

—When we went to say goodbye to Uncle Jacinto, he touched my belly and said something to you. Maya, what did he say to you?

He replied: "I

don't know, I didn't notice because I was a little nervous."

Tere just smiled.

They arrived in Mexico City, and the driver was already waiting for them. Just as Rubén was about to introduce her, Tere said:

—I'm glad, Ruben. We met him when he did us the favor of driving us to the airport.

Ruben said:

—Of course! This month has been like a whole year, and with so much happiness I've forgotten how-sas. Sorry, Jesus, I forgot to tell you that Tere and I got married in Cancun.

Jesus said,

"Congratulations, ma'am, welcome to the Chi family."

Tere didn't know it was another Chi. The driver drove them to the Polanco neighborhood, to a building across from Chapultepec, and they went up to the *penthouse*. Tere was surprised by how beautiful it was and the wonderful view. It was modern, elegant, and a bit eclectic, filled with paintings and memorabilia. It had three bedrooms and a large, also remodeled maid's room with a television, bathroom, and all amenities. Rubén introduced her to Zoila, who was looking after him, and then took Javercito to show him his bedroom. He asked him if he wasn't afraid of sleeping alone, to which Javercito replied that grown-ups aren't afraid anymore. Jesús had the other bedroom, as he stayed with Rubén all the time, and Tere settled into the master bedroom with Rubén.

At dinner, Ruben told them: —

I'm going to leave Jesús with you all the time, I'm going to move around in Uber, in the end it's just leaving and returning to the office, and I'm going to recommend the following: tomorrow go to the Papalote Museum, which is a museum for children, and to the Fair. Eat at the Restaurant del Lago, and

In the afternoon, go to the zoo, which has some of the best facilities in the world. So you don't have to walk so far, take the little train. On Tuesday, plan to go to the National Museum of Anthropology and eat in the cafeteria, where the food is very good. In the afternoon, go to a children's theater next to the auditorium; there's a children's play. I've already reserved some tickets online—and he handed the reservation to Tere—. The next day, tour the city, go to the Historic Center, visit the National Palace and the Orozco murals in the Antiguo Colegio de San Ildefonso; visit some other museum—and he gave Tere some brochures—and eat at a typical restaurant downtown. Jesús has tickets and will accompany you everywhere. On Friday, go to Xochimilco, so that, as we say in Cancún, you can see the original and take a trip to the University City. I'll spend Saturday with you, and I have a surprise for you, Javiercito.

"Which one?" said Javiercito.

— You'll see —Rubén told him.

Rubén went to the office every day, arriving late, when Javiercito was already asleep, and Tere told him about the day. On Friday night, they were discussing the week when Rubén received a call. When he answered, Tere saw that he paled slightly, and a tear ran down his face. When he hung up, Tere asked him what had happened.

—Grandpa Jacinto died.

It was the first time she heard him call her uncle, grandpa. She expressed her sorrow to him. and wanted to comfort him, but he answered:

—Tere, don't worry. Uncle Juan told me that when someone who, given their age, should live many years, like my parents, dies, it's a tragedy. But when someone like the great Jacinto Chi dies, at over 80 years old, it must be a joy because he's finally at rest.

He made round-trip reservations for the next day at 7:00 a.m., returning at 9:00 p.m. on the last flight. The funeral was scheduled for 2:00 p.m. Tere told him she wanted to go with him, but Rubén said he didn't want Javiercito to go through that experience so young.

"I'd rather you wait for me here. I'm very grateful, and I know it's a loss for you too. But I prefer it this way. It's a lot of hassle in one day, and tomorrow we're leaving for Managua."

The funeral was very simple. Everyone was calm. Everyone was saying, "Good old Jacinto passed away in his time." The one who didn't say anything was Aunt Lencha, who was sitting next to the coffin. Later, at the burial time in the cemetery on the northern hill, they placed a chair for her. She watched the burial without saying a word. When she got home, she asked to be put in her hammock and fell asleep. Rubén returned on the night flight, and when he arrived, Tere was waiting for him in the living room. He told her everything, and they went to sleep.

office driver in the armored truck. They settled into their house, and Tere's mother said: The next day they arrived in Managua, where Tere's parents and the

—Hey, my dear, you didn't tell us about the wedding and we didn't go with you.

To which Tere replied:

—Look, Mom, I thought about it a lot, but it was a very rushed wedding: on Monday night I found out I was getting married on Friday, and I also thought that for you all it might be a little disconcerting, because as I told you, there were about 900 guests in town.

But I have a surprise for you: Rubén agreed to let us get married in the church in Managua, so you'll give me away at the church and you'll be the godparents and witnesses, and only two people will come from Cancún, Uncle Juan and Aunt Meche, as godparents and witnesses.

"I'm so glad," said Mom, clapping her hands. "It's going to be a great surprise for your uncles and cousins. We'll have a nice wedding. I'm going to ask you not to go to a hotel right now, since your apartment only has one bedroom. Come to the house, which has three bedrooms, and you and Javiercito will have your own."

"That's great," said Javiercito, "because I'll be able to play with Firulais."

The grandparents' house had a small garden, where Javiercito played with the dog. Javier responded quickly:

—Of course, it will be a pleasure to be with you while we find something suitable.

The next day, Tere and Rubén went to the office. Tere had set up the Mexican delegation's offices according to the instructions Rubén had sent her, including some plans.

A month later, the boy started elementary school, which was just around the corner from his parents' house. Tere said the best elementary school was the one closest to home, but that school also had the reputation of being the best in Managua. It was run by the Marist Brothers, but Rubén didn't mind because he said he wouldn't be there for more than two years.

A few weeks later, one day Tere didn't go to work and didn't tell Rubén why. When Rubén returned home, Tere was beaming with happiness, and so were the parents. Tere hugged Rubén around the neck and said, "I have a surprise for you." Rubén replied, "It's not a surprise, you're pregnant."

Tere withdrew and said:

"Now you're going to tell me the truth, what did Uncle Jacinto say to you when we said goodbye and he touched my belly?"

Ruben answered him:

—The surprise will be yours. He told me you were pregnant and he also told me that it's going to be a girl.

"A girl!" Tere exclaimed happily.

And Javiercito said:

—That's great, I prefer a girl, so I can play alone with my dad.

—Tere's parents didn't understand anything and asked, also happily:

—How do you know it's going to be a girl?

Tere told them:

—Don't worry about how, but we're sure it's going to be a girl.

—Well, I hope so, but it's all the same to us.

The hard days of work continued, two months passed, and the wedding was approaching. It was to be held at the house Rubén and Tere had rented, a mansion belonging to a Lebanese man, a friend of the dictator, who had left with him after the revolution triumphed, leaving his house for rent. The house hadn't been rented because he wanted to rent it in dollars, which were restricted in Managua. But Rubén had no problem, since his salary abroad was in dollars, and it was a good salary.

The house had the original furniture, which Rubén and Tere loved. Since it had been moved overnight, it was fully decorated and had a beautiful garden with large trees. That's where the wedding was going to take place.

They decided it was time to personally invite Ortega and requested an audience. It took a day, but they were granted one. When they arrived, Tere was surprised that he greeted them standing behind the desk, not as usual, coming out of the desk and greeting her warmly and seating her on a less formal sofa. He asked them to sit across from the desk. Tere told him cheerfully that they were inviting him to her wedding. Rubén noticed that Ortega grimaced as if in pain, and taking the invitation, he said:

—You can count on me to do my best to go.

Tere glanced at Rubén.

Ortega asked them:

—How's work going?

Tere responded a little sharply:

—That's not what we came to see with you, we'll discuss that another day.

He stood up, an attitude that Rubén imitated, and said goodbye to Ortega saying:

—I hope you can go!

Rubén also said goodbye. Ortega said:

—The best for you.

As Rubén left, he asked Tere:

—What happened, Tere? He's the president.

—What president or what eight quarters, first of all I considered him my friend,
That I'm going to see if I can go, let your grandmother believe it.

Rubén had never seen Tere so upset, but he had a strange feeling about Ortega's attitude.

The wedding took place on a beautiful afternoon in the garden. Uncle Juan and Aunt Meche attended the religious ceremony, for which Aunt Meche had had a suit made by the tailor Tino, who was as old as they were, and he looked very elegant. Of course, no human power could put a tie on him, but with his corpulence, he looked truly distinguished. The banquet was very good; many relatives and all the heads of the two delegations that were negotiating attended. At the wedding was an old comrade who had also been a guerrilla and who was part of the government, but in a not very important position, something like a Research Center. He approached Tere—it was evident they had always liked each other—and said in secret:

—Tere, be careful, don't be surprised by some of the things that are going to happen.

She replied:

—Please tell me more.

—Don't worry, it's nothing personal, just don't be surprised.

He kissed her on the cheek, said goodbye, and left.

At night, in the privacy of the bedroom, Tere told him what her friend Gustavo had told her and Rubén answered:

—Look, Tere, I hadn't wanted to tell you anything, but there are two things I want to comment on. On the one hand, the guys told me they're encountering unexpected resistance from some sectors that are raising awareness for the referendum to approve the BMD . In the only personal interview I had with Ortega, I found him evasive, I'd even say a little annoyed, although he didn't mention anything negative.

I've also perceived a certain negativity in General Javier González and Dr. Lucio Cañedo, whom you told me are the two people closest to President Ortega.

—She replied, annoyed:

—Stop calling that jerk president, he didn't even come to the wedding.

Ruben said to him:

—He's your friend, not mine, and I must observe protocol.

—Even between us?

—Yes Tere, I must be respectful, even between us.

And Tere felt it best not to enter dangerous territory.

—And on the other hand, a more delicate and personal issue. I wonder, if the president didn't want this system, why did he agree to implement it? And I only found one answer, which I confirmed in our interview with him.

"Why?" Tere asked, intrigued.

And he received the answer he was afraid to hear:

"I think," said Rubén, "that Ortega has always been in love with you."

A few tears ran down her face and she said:

—Unfortunately, Rubén, I'm afraid that's the case, and I swear I don't understand how it could have happened. We've known each other for over 15 years. He was Javier's best friend, and after these two and a half years, there's never been a single hint of anything.

Ruben said:

—Please, Tere, you don't have to swear anything, don't worry. But if that's the case, I think I understand better what's going on. Knowing President Ortega, he thought your passion for the BMD would be the instrument through which he could win you over. And when he realizes that not only did it not bring you closer to him, but it actually pushed you away, we're going to suffer the consequences.

Tere said:

—That can't be.

—Tere, I remind you of what my grandfather used to say: "Only power changes human beings more than money." Didn't they teach you in your postgraduate studies at the BMD about the changes that Marcos in the Philippines; Fidel in Cuba; Chávez and Maduro in Venezuela; Ortega, the previous one from your homeland; Perón in Argentina; Hitler in Germany...? You can expect anything from politicians in power, at all levels.

That night they both slept uneasily.

It didn't take long for the news to hit like a bolt from the blue: Ortega would not only postpone the plebiscite, but also the elections. The argument was: "The Nicaraguan people are not yet ready for elections; there's a lot of living history from such a protracted revolution." Period. The armed forces gave the junta he presided over an absolute vote of confidence, and any democratic aspirations were postponed indefinitely.

When Rubén and Tere went to inform him of the definitive suspension of the registration process, he received them kindly, even getting up from his desk and sitting them on the sofa. He spoke first and said: "I know what you're here for, and let me tell you that in making the decision I've made, this matter of the BMD was one of the most painful for me, because I knew we would lose the opportunity to register, and it was a passion I shared with Tere, but I can't avoid it, because the price could be another armed insurrection, which would be disastrous for the people. I hope that in the near future we can call for free elections. I will allow the formation of parties, and I even plan to give you government positions when the situation is ripe."

I will invite you again to participate in the effort to enroll Nicaragua in the BMD."

Rubén stood up, extended his hand, and said, "I appreciate your sincerity, Mr. President. The day you hold free elections in Nicaragua, the BMD **will be here** to register them. On behalf of myself and my family, I take this opportunity to bid you farewell and wish you every success in this new effort to democratize Nicaragua."

Tere, cautious, gave him a kiss on the cheek and said: "Goodbye my dear friend, "May God be with you in power."

Ortega looked puzzled, blinked, and muttered, "Thank you very much," turning around and walking to the desk.

They left the office and Rubén took Tere's hand, who had a tear in her eyes, and said: "It's over," and she said with a sob: "Goodbye Nicaragua!"

They still spent a month closing their offices, dismissing the Mexican commission, and disbanding the Nicaraguan one. Tere managed to find jobs for everyone who wanted to stay, and others decided to return to the US to study or work. They had to pay a large sum in dollars to leave the house before the contract expired.

Returning to the family was made easier because Tere's parents agreed to return with them to see Cancún and as much of Mexico as they could. So there were no sad goodbyes; there were a few dinners with close relatives and a cocktail party at home with the rest of the family, and before they knew it, they were settled on the plane. The grandparents sat in the two side seats. They were assigned to sit in the middle, and Javier asked to sit in the middle.

A few moments later, Javiercito, very seriously, said to them:

—Dad and Mom: My dad told me he was going to adopt me, and that he would really be my dad, and I want to ask you something. I never met my dad or my Espíndola grandparents. Since my dad is going to adopt me, can I be called Javier Chi Ríos, like all my cousins back home?

Ruben looked at Tere, who nodded, and said:

—I swear to you, my son, that I will do everything necessary to make it so —and she hugged him affectionately— sly and tears ran down her face.

When they arrived in Cancún, Uncle Juan and Aunt Meche were waiting for them at the airport; they were overjoyed; they already knew Tere's parents, whom they greeted with great familiarity.

They arrived at the ranch, walked along the road, the *lobby* and the mother, amazed, said:

—But daughter, what the hell did you want to do, returning to Nicaragua with this?

Pablo, her husband, was surprised by his wife's expression and Tere replied:

— For you, parents, for you.

They immediately went to see Lencha, who, upon seeing them, tried to sit up but couldn't. Since Jacinto's death, he had decided that he no longer had any reason to be with them.

to get up, and stayed in the hammock, and Uncle Juan adjusted everything to suit their different needs. Aunt Lencha, who was perfectly lucid, touched Tere's belly and said something in Mayan when she greeted her. Uncle Juan, who was nearby, said to Tere: "He says Jacinto told him when you said goodbye that you were going to have a girl." Tere smiled and replied: "Yes, Uncle, Rubén told me too, and I'm sure it will be."

They spent the first week doing nothing. They took Tere's parents to the beach, which they loved; they thoroughly enjoyed everything they saw and experienced, telling Tere that she was very lucky, that it was an admirable family, that they were all good people, and that they clearly loved her very much: "Love them too, daughter."

The following week, Tere noticed that Rubén was very restless. She called his office in Mexico City and didn't mention anything, and then called New York several times. Tere knew he had something important, but that until he deemed it prudent, she wouldn't tell him, and she let him do it. She brought in a surveyor and marked some areas to the south and north of the land, and then locked herself in her studio for several days. She only came out to eat, or to play with Javiercito for a while; at night, he slept restlessly.

One day he said, "I want to have lunch with you this Saturday, and then I want to spend the afternoon in the studio. Tere, invite Miguelito so he can be with us and make the boy feel comfortable."

They ate very happily and after finishing eating he invited them into the study, and said:

—What I'm about to present to you is subject to the approval of Tere, my wife here present, and my family, my uncle Juan and aunt Meche, and Don Pablo and Doña Consuelo, my wife's parents. I'm going to present to you my future life plan.

Tere felt a chill, she knew Rubén, she knew it would be something truly transcendental.

—Mother-in-law, I want to tell you that all this started suddenly when you had that sincere and beautiful exclamation: "But daughter, what the hell did you want, returning to Nicaragua, having all this?" Well, in these days that I've been so distracted, I've done two things: first, I've started a series of procedures on the computer that I'll refer to at the end of my presentation, and I began to design our future, thinking that we have all this, how to preserve it, and live it. All the plans I'm going to present are subject to your approval," he said, addressing Tere, "because they are decisive for our life together."

"In Nicaragua, I realized three things. The first, which is fundamental, is to increase training and better inform all levels, including the current president or prime minister, about what the BMD is all about, how it can influence and affect people, and what the enormous benefits are in education, which is fundamental to people's development. The BMD **also needs to** have the right personnel to study each country and see it in "real conditions" to avoid real frustrations.

"The second is more personal. Before meeting Tere, I was alone; traveling anywhere and for any length of time didn't affect me; in fact, I liked it. But when we got married and I had a family that I love deeply, and also

We're expecting a daughter—because that's how it's going to be—I thought it would be difficult for them to be moving every two years, that it would be a bit unstable and difficult, although they would grow up more universal and with more languages, which in this age of globalization isn't bad, but they would lack consistent affection. And on the other hand, there are the Chi family, for whom there are many responsibilities and things to do to fully integrate them into the 21st century, and I know that for my grandfather, this was a great dream that he passed on to all of us. There's a responsibility there to fulfill.

“The third is that in this place there is the possibility of doing something that jointly resolves all these observations or interests, and the solution is to create the World Training Center for Third World countries here on the ranch, to achieve their integration into the BMD and put them on the path to global development in this globalized world. And on the other hand, to create the Chi family colony with the essential development requirements and to promote the fundamental economic resources in the family trust to guarantee, on the one hand, education up to a master's level for all young members of the Chi family, an adequate standard of health and nutrition, and also to protect the elderly in the family so that they spend their final years properly protected and cared for. And to achieve all of this, I will explain the following plan.”

And he projected the plan of the ranch on the floor.

On the northern part of the site, facing Puerto Morelos and Cancún, a 20-hectare plot had been marked out, where the Study and Training Center (CEC) would be located. This, in turn, would have four divisions. The center itself would be fronted by the center. The second unit would be a flexivilla-style all-suite hotel, where delegations from all countries would be received for training and where the center's students would live, learning how to apply each of the BMD concepts. Next would come a complex of 60 three-bedroom houses with services, where the center's directors and teachers would live. Finally, there would be a sports center and beach club, which could serve the entire complex and provide all the necessary facilities.

“Afterwards,” he continued, “all the calls I made these past two months were to present this project in Mexico, at the United Nations, in Washington, and to the accredited diplomatic corps. I also met in person or via videoconference with the rectors of the 20 most prestigious universities in the world, including those in Mexico. All of them, without exception, have confirmed and ratified their interest. Not only that, 25 of the 27 current members of the BMD have already confirmed that they are each contributing \$20 million within their support funds for developing countries, which already provides the capital to build the Center. In addition, the BMD reaffirmed its unconditional support, donating \$50 million for pre-operational capital for the Center.”

“I proposed that the hotel and the houses would be an investment I would make with our trust, and when I explained its purpose, everyone approved. The Center's land would be donated to the trust as a permanent loan, since it couldn't be sold, and the Center would be self-sufficient.

"To those who had doubts, I told them about the survey I conducted. The Center would have 10 universal training classrooms to train 10 independent executives, with the best teachers in each subject, Nobel Prize winners, and executives from large corporations (whom I consulted via videoconference and confirmed that if the project was carried out, they would accept). They will be among the few executives in the world who will have fully updated training and a continuous updating method, because today any knowledge becomes obsolete between two and five years, and the world's universities cannot update at that pace. Therefore, when professionals graduate, their knowledge is already obsolete after two years. These studies would cost \$1 million per year, for four years, and in the open call I launched, explaining the deadlines and everything else, I received more than 100 applications in the first week from huge family consortiums, large transnational corporations, and governments that want to. to train their children, their executives, or their civil servants at the level the Center would offer. I couldn't believe it myself, so I replaced the 10 special cubicles in the project with 20. The income from the rentals of the houses and the hotel would be used for the trust.

"I divided the southern part of the land into four parts: the first lot would be for building houses for the present and future families of the Chi family who wanted to remain in the area; we started with 20 and it would grow as needed. The second lot would be a sort of nursing home hotel, with the essential services of doctors, therapists, etc., for the elderly members of our family. Next would come our sports club and beach club, preserving a 20-meter oceanfront lot by 200 meters deep, where the cemetery land would be respected, which would then be legalized and would be for the Chi family and their in-laws. The club would have a small school, with fully computerized classrooms, where support and refresher courses would be given for elementary, middle, high school, and university, for extracurricular studies and support with homework and projects. All Chi relatives from the ranch, the town, or wherever they came from, would have full scholarships for their children at the best schools in the area, and in Quintana Roo at the University of the Caribbean, in whatever program it offers. The strict condition would be to have a minimum GPA or equivalent of 9. Those who don't achieve this and apply would be supported to pursue technical or trade studies, provided they meet minimum requirements. When the trust funds aren't sufficient, I have been offered loans from the Inter-American Development Bank to develop hotels on similar land measuring 100 meters wide by 1 kilometer deep, to raise funds for the Chi family fund. My income would be a magnificent salary for running the Center, another equivalent salary for chairing the trust, and the income from my parents' inherited estate outside the ranch, and Tere will receive a salary based on her work in both.

"With this I believe I fulfill: 1. My grandfather's wishes to protect the Chi family

2. Give stability to my family
3. Bring a world-class study center to Quintana Roo
- 4th Participate in the development of my country."

Everyone was amazed and happy. Tere enthusiastically told him that she not only accepted him, but that she supported him unconditionally and would help with whatever was necessary.

Don Juan, the uncle, told him he was proud of him, and that his grandfather and parents would be too, and Aunt Meche hugged him, crying. The in-laws thought, "My daughter certainly made a good choice."

From that moment on, Rubén devoted himself to preparing for the birth of Alicia, whom Tere had requested to be named after him, to Rubén's satisfaction. Tere's parents stayed for a few months after Tere's birth, and they had brought some documents that Rubén had requested.

Alicia was born without incident, and Rubén asked Tere to stay at the hospital for two more days for safety reasons. Tere's mother asked for her baptism soon, and Rubén told them, "We'll have the baptism the day after tomorrow, and I have a surprise for you."

The day arrived, and Ruben showed up at the hospital with Javiercito, Uncle Juan, Aunt Meche and Tere's parents, and said:

"The surprise I've prepared for you is this. On this day, we'll not only baptize Alicia, but we'll also sign the following paperwork:

- Tere's naturalization. • Javiercito's naturalization. • The legal adoption and name change, which will now be Javier Chi Ríos—Javiercito jumped for joy, turned to look at the newborn girl, and said, "We're siblings on both sides." • Tere's **registration with the BMD** .
- Javier's registration in the BMD
- Alicia's registration in the BMD and her birth certificate."

And he submitted his will and the modification of the trust where in- It included Javier and Alicia as trustees, and Tere as executor.

After finishing the signing, which took place at three locations, in addition to the Nicaraguan consulate, they went to the ranch where, as a surprise, a meal was prepared for them with the ranch's uncles and cousins.

Upon arriving at the ranch, the first thing they did was visit Grandma Lencha, the late Jacinto's wife. Upon seeing them, she became a little nervous and asked Rubén in Mayan, "Is everything okay with the little girl?" Rubén told her, "Yes, Grandma, and Javiercito is also now part of the Chi family. I adopted him, and he took the last name Chi." And she replied, "Like old Jacinto."

"Yes, Grandma, just like him." Then she said, "Oh, well, then there's the next head of the Chi family, I can sleep peacefully now." She said goodbye and closed her eyes.

Also present were the town's elders and leaders, whom Rubén wanted to witness Javier's adoption. They happily signed an informal document acknowledging the arrival of the two new members of the Chi family. Rubén asked them to inform the entire town, which had already known Javiercito since the wedding.

The next day, when Rubén went to kiss Grandma Lencha, as he always did when he was at the ranch, he found her asleep, never to wake up again. Grandma had waited for the news before joining her beloved Jacinto. And Rubén thought: "There shouldn't be any mourning; it happened naturally and when she decided." Her burial took place that same afternoon, with Grandpa Jacinto, and the ranch family was present.

Life began to return to normal. Javiercito started elementary school at Tepeyac School in Playa del Carmen, and Tere breastfed the baby; she had decided to do so as much as possible and would do so for the next three years. By the time she was a month old, she hadn't gone out a single day, and one Saturday, after putting the baby to bed, Rubén gathered the whole family and took her to dinner at a restaurant in Puerto Morelos that had been known for years as one of the best in the world. It was called Le Chique. The family began anew the routine of going out every Saturday to eat, go to the movies, and visit different places.

When they went to Crococun, Javiercito said, "The only thing I was missing was to pet a crocodile!" Rubén had bought a school bus with special equipment, including tables and seat belts for every seat. The bus stayed in the town of Ma'y Tab and left early with the children enrolled at Tepeyac, then stopped by Javier, Miguelito, and two other relatives to take them to school. He later bought another bus as a replacement for the first one, but it had a different function: twice a week, it took the ladies and gentlemen of the town and the ranch to a shopping mall in Playa; sometimes to Cancún, and Aunt Meche and Tere always went. Sometimes he took the girl, carrying her in a rebozo or *hetzmek*-style. They liked going to the *food court* at Plaza Américas because everyone ate whatever they wanted; there, many of them were introduced to Chinese, Japanese, and Italian food, foods they had never eaten before.

It took Rubén two years to complete the Center's project due to its complexity and the fact that it included classrooms and equipment that had never been built before. One day, he told Tere that he was very happy because the project and construction had been won in a competition by a company from Cancún, owned by the architect, son of his grandfather's friend, and by the architect, son of the architect, "al llegar," as his grandfather called him. They had also built a bungalow for Tere's parents, who spent six months a year with them at the ranch.

When the girl turned three, they took her to kindergarten, but she sat at the door of the classroom and didn't want to go in. So Tere asked her, "Why don't you come in?" And she said, "I don't like it; you make too much noise." And Tere asked her, "Do you want to have kindergarten in your dad's study, on television?" And the girl, excited, replied, "Yes, that's what I want."

Tere consulted with Rubén, and he told her:

—I'd be delighted, but realize that this means you'll be responsible for being with her every morning, and that will cut your available time in half. The decision is yours.

She replied:

—It will be three years, until she enters primary school, and then when the Center opens, well, it corresponds to the time you have thought it will be finished, we'll see.

Ruben said to him:

—I want to ask you something. I have three very important offers: one for the house in Cancún, which we hardly use anymore, for which they're offering me \$1,000 per square meter, which is \$20 million. And another for the two small squares, each 27 hectares, into which I divided the land in front of the ranch, the north and the south, since the other 46 hectares are where the reverse osmosis drinking water production project is being carried out, and where the anaerobic treatment plant, the emergency power plants, and the land reserve are located. That one is in a T shape, since at the back I left a plot of land 100 meters deep by 1 kilometer. Almost in front will be the ten large wind generators. For now, we'll only install four, to generate what will be needed.

Well, for those 270,000 square meters each, they're offering me \$100 per square meter, which is \$27 million each. With those \$74 million, I can finance the entire project trust, since 100 hectares across from the ranch aren't in the trust. So I can sell the 54 hectares and add the other 46 to the trust, so they become part of the whole project.

"And what are they going to do?" Tere asked.

— In the northern polygon, there's a shopping center, and in the southern polygon, you don't know, a group of American retirees is buying it. Both agree to leave a 100-meter buffer in front of the highway, although the shopping center asked me, and I approved, that the mall should have a large billboard on its entrance boulevard, perpendicular to the highway, advertising it. This won't affect the view of the ranch. On the contrary, we guarantee a 100-meter visual buffer along the entire length of the highway.

Tere thought it was fantastic, as that would eliminate all the credits, except for part of the hotel, which pays for itself.

Rubén told him:

"Not only that, I've already done the budgets and there are 14 million dollars left over, which more than guarantees the operation of the trust and I'll be able to give it to Uncle Juan, who wants to do a lot of things in the town."

When they gave the news to Uncle Juan, he was happy and asked: "How much?"

"Whatever you want," Ruben replied.

—So I'm going to remodel the school. I'm going to put in a classroom like the one you're going to build here, for refresher courses for the children. I can hire a teacher. I'm going to build a brand-new Red Cross and add an ambulance. Can I hire a full-time doctor at the Red Cross to care for the people?

—Sure, man.

—And remodel the plaza and the sports center.

—Sure, dude, too.

"How rich are we?" Uncle Juan asked.

—Not us, but the Chi trust does.

Don Juan happily devoted himself to these things; he said he would do them himself, with an elderly teacher, a friend of his grandfather, and his sons, who were also teachers. And every day, for the next three years that the Center took to build, he went with his chauffeur to visit "My works!" as he called them. Sometimes he took Aunt Meche, and the family went some weekends to greet the family and see the works.

Three years passed, and in 2035, the last week of August, the entire BMD CEC was inaugurated . The inauguration was attended by the President of the Republic; representatives in Mexico of the UN, the World Bank, and the International Monetary Fund; the governor and his entire cabinet; the municipal presidents of Quintana Roo; members of the local congress; the governors and representatives of the states of the Yucatán Peninsula; the rectors and directors of the universities and schools of Cancún and Puerto Morelos; eight rectors of the world's most prestigious universities and two Nobel Prize winners; members of the Chi family; and the ambassadors of the participating countries.

The Center's auditorium was packed, as students and teachers were already present. There were several speeches—they had agreed that each would be a few minutes long. But the shortest was given by the Center's general director, who simply said: "I wish to emphasize that we are inaugurating this Center on land where 80 years ago there were only two inhabitants: my great-grandfather, General Jacinto Chi, and his wife, and on a coast where there were no more than 100 inhabitants. Today we have 2 million inhabitants; where there was only one daily flight, today there are more than 1,000 daily flights to 50 countries around the world. Welcome, and we are deeply grateful to all of you, without whom this reality would not be possible."

Not everyone knew who Jacinto Chi was, but they did know who Rubén Hernández Chi was.

The week went by, which was extremely hectic, and over the weekend Rubén decided to rest, and on Saturday he slept for 12 hours straight, something he'd never done before in his life. On Sunday he gathered on the terrace of the house with the whole family.

In the morning, Rubén and Tere had walked along the beach, discussing the week's events calmly and happily. Tere's parents had swum in the sea, which they loved. The children had played with their cousins, and Uncle Juan had been meditating in the small cemetery. Aunt Meche had gone to the kitchen to help prepare lunch.

It was a very pleasant meal, and during the after-dinner conversation, Uncle Juan suddenly said,

"I want to say a few words. First, I'm very proud to be part of the Chi family," and turning to Rubén, he added, "but I want to remember something that Juan, your grandfather, used to say: 'You have to be careful, Juan, because power and money change people.'" And looking at Tere, he said, "Always take care of him, so that his simplicity and modesty never change, and that he always takes care of his Center and his family." Then he added, "During the inauguration, after you spoke, Rubén, I couldn't concentrate on the other speeches because memories of my childhood and early youth in the village came flooding back. I didn't leave the village until I was 16, with Don Juan driving his truck." He taught me how to do it, and I remembered how as children we used to walk around half-naked and all of us pot-bellied from parasites, playing in the puddles on the street when it rained, and there were pigs, dogs, and chickens everywhere. Walking through the classrooms, with all those electronic devices, and all the satellite dishes, I remembered Don Beto's radio, which since it was battery-powered, he only turned it on for the news and on Saturday afternoons and evenings, when the townspeople would gather for a beer, and also on Sundays to listen to the National Hour.

"For me, Mexico was the school flag and the anthem we heard on National Time, and those inspectors who showed up in town every six months, supposedly looking for Jacinto, and beat some people. Families locked up the girls and women because on more than one occasion they raped someone.

"And at the banquet, I remembered the famines we suffered when the gales knocked down the cornfields, and those two years of drought, when no matter how much we men, women, and children carried water in buckets from the cenotes to irrigate some of the cornfields and vegetables, we still died of hunger. Even the crickets, the worms, the snakes, and some children and sick people died. And I remembered how, when someone became seriously ill, we would carry them out in hammocks crossed on a pole, and we called them "hammacados," and we would carry them for up to four days to Valladolid. Along the road were the crosses of those who hadn't lasted. And when they left the town, we would see them go, and the people would say goodbye to them, because some would never return.

"And how as a child, on dark moonless nights, I was frightened by the sounds of the jungle, and how the heat overwhelmed me in the dog days of August, when there was not even a

A wisp of wind; when I used to go to the cornfield with my dad as a child and we'd come back in the dark, the fear of snakes and animals. My best friend was killed by a snake that bit him one day when we were going swimming in the cenote. I remember how I managed to get him home, shouting: 'José was bitten by the nauyaca.' Jacinto's potions didn't save him; he was too weak.

"And then in 1976, seeing how from one day to the next everything arrived: the road, electricity, water, the television, the refrigerator, and in Juan's house the air conditioning, the gas heater, the fan; all in a jiffy, and then I remember that Juan built the first tourist room in Akumal and also in Cancun. And we started working like crazy and we built one and another and another. One day, on a very large one that I really liked, I said to him: 'Juan, I congratulate you, look what you did.' And he replied: 'No Juan, it wasn't me; no one can do any work or development or road or park alone. These works are done with a human team, which includes architects, engineers, accountants, equipment operators, construction foremen, officials, laborers. They are a team, as in my case, what would I be without Casimiro in the formwork, without Pedro in the ironwork, without Bladimiro in the finishing, and without the official laborers who They carry everything, and they spend all day shoveling and placing concrete and everything else.

"Like in the project you just directed, Rubén, in each case and in each project there is a leader, like in every organization, but I feel that in those 150,000 rooms, in those thousands of houses built, even in the Cancún-Tulum express train, there is my work, Juan's, and all of ours. One day Juan told me that the engineer, his friend, had told him at the inauguration of the monument in 2012, that for him this was the monument of the vindication of the Mayans of the peninsula, because it marked the moment in which the Mayans were given work and benefits, and that this was the only tool to give any human being dignity and pride. And now with the inauguration, I realized that this is where people are prepared for the greatest task there can be, which is having the responsibility to serve others with the greatest knowledge possible. I am very proud of what has happened and what I have done with my life. I didn't have children, but I had you. I have no assets, but I feel I have formed "part of everything I've lived. I am immensely happy, and I ask you—as I once told you—that when I'm gone, you don't say: 'Poor John, he's gone,' but rather, say: 'He completed his natural life cycle, he worked as he liked, he lived happily, and in a single life he lived like all of history: he was born in the past and died in the future.' I've already said it all."

Everyone held their breath, no one had ever heard a speech from Uncle Juan was so long and so emotional. Rubén and Tere were in tears.

And Aunt Meche said:

—I also want to speak—and everyone paid attention to what she was going to say, and very seriously she said—: I say the same thing that Juan said.

And everyone relieved the tension with a laugh at his joke. But Javiercito said:

—I want to talk! —I was already 12 years old— . I want to say that I am a very good student—

I was the best in elementary school and I'm also the best in high school and throughout school, and when I grow up I want to study and work hard, like my dad.

Everyone applauded, but the one who surprised everyone was Alicia, who was 6 years old, who said, "Now I want to talk too." In her little girl's voice, she turned to her dad and said, "Daddy, I'm a good student too, and I've already talked to my mom about this, and she agrees. I don't like school; it makes me really nervous, and I prefer to study here, in your studio, like my mom tells me you did for your school. I think it's because you didn't like it as much as I did, but she told me to ask you. Will you let me do it, Dad?"

And Tere, seeing Rubén, said to him: —Rubén, let her be! Here in Quintana Roo.

END

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